

*"He steals hearts from all around the world, but one night,
he stole something that wasn't his to steal.
Me."*



MANIK

AMO JONES

FLUKE

with

Prison holds flesh, washed up ⁱⁿ sin
KNOCK KNOCK! Bitch
Now let the devil in

stuck between a rock and a hard place so
I dug her fucking grave screaming
THIS BITCH CAN'T BE SAVED



MANIK

AMO JONES



FUCK LOVE

but I'll fuck you for...



I'll take away your sadness
with my deranged
madness

All Rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without prior written permission of the publisher, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in reviews and certain other non-commercial uses permitted by copyright law.

This book is a work of fiction. All names, characters, locations, and incidents are products of the author's imaginations. Any resemblance to actual person's, things, living or dead, locales, or events is entirely coincidental.

Cover design: Jay Aheer, Simply Defined Art
Editor: Ellie McLove, My Brother's Editor
Proof reader: Petra Gleason, My Brother's Editor
Formatting: Champagne Book Design



TABLE OF CONTENTS

[TITLE PAGE](#)

[COPYRIGHT](#)

[ACKNOWLEDGMENTS](#)

[DEDICATION](#)

[PART 1](#)

[PROLOGUE](#)

[CHAPTER ONE](#)

[CHAPTER TWO](#)

[CHAPTER THREE](#)

[CHAPTER FOUR](#)

[CHAPTER FIVE](#)

[CHAPTER SIX](#)

[CHAPTER SEVEN](#)

[CHAPTER EIGHT](#)

[CHAPTER NINE](#)

[CHAPTER TEN](#)

[CHAPTER ELEVEN](#)

[CHAPTER TWELVE](#)

[CHAPTER THIRTEEN](#)

[CHAPTER FOURTEEN](#)

[CHAPTER FIFTEEN](#)

[CHAPTER SIXTEEN](#)

[CHAPTER SEVENTEEN](#)

[CHAPTER EIGHTEEN](#)

[CHAPTER NINETEEN](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE](#)

[PART 2](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT](#)

[CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE](#)

[CHAPTER THIRTY](#)

[CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE](#)

[CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO](#)

[CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE](#)

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

CHAPTER FORTY

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT

CHAPTER FORTY-NINE

EPILOGUE

OTHER BOOKS

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I have so many people to thank, but I don't want to drag this on. My children who inspire me daily. My partner who puts up with my crazy, and my mummy who always has my back. My brothers who are my everything, and my sisters who are my best friends. My best friend Lyla. I love you. Twenty years of friendship and that's all I've got right now. My best friend, Amiria. Thank you for tolerating me. My best friend, Isis—I love you! Bitchface for life. My readers who continue to support me and have my back! My beta, Sarah! Oh Lord, this girl... I cannot thank enough. I wouldn't be able to polish these stories if it wasn't for you! Caro, thank you so damn much for everything that you do, Bloggers for taking the time out of their busy schedules to read, review and share me.

My agent, Flavia! Thank you for exceeding all my expectations and loving my books like they're your own. Ellie! For editing my words in such a respectful and professional manner! Seriously, I don't know where I'd be without you. You spend so much time on my babies and treat them like your own. PETRA! For polishing my words and turning hay into gold—I shall call you Rumpelstiltskin. The authors who inspire, support, and encourage one another—my tribe! Chantal! You're stuck with me. Anne! You legit had no chance of running from me. Those heels won't help. But they preettyyy though! #IvyAndHarley To Jaci—for keeping me sane most of the time, for our book dates and wine. And coffee. And red velvet cake. And general shit talking. Thank you! My Wolf Pack—(howls). Jay Aheer—I love you. Thank you for my beautiful covers. For learning my vision and nailing them every single time. Also, sorry for being a diva. And lastly, to all the readers who may be about to read me for the first time ever: thank you for giving a girl a shot.

To Wine and Chocolate for feeding my demons.

DEDICATION

To the girls who never noticed Prince Charming...

...because the monster under their bed did that thing they liked with his tongue...

PART 1

"... the devil doesn't come dressed in a red cape and pointy horns. He comes as everything you've ever wished for..."

—Tucker Max, *Assholes Finish First*



PROLOGUE

Cell bars melt together in dark waves of distress, the roof a salient contrast. The cold concrete floor I lay on is stained in puddles of damp old urine that rubs against my flesh. I clench my eyes closed and count to three.

One.

Two.

Three.

My eyes open but I'm still here, sort of. Things look warped, strange, but I'm still in my nightmare. A nightmare that I will never wake up from. I stare down at my legs, my very real legs, and see that it can't possibly be fabricated from some subconscious part of my brain. Everything is real. Very freaking real.

"Who are you, Beatrice...?" someone asked from the corner of the room. His voice is deep, swimming with familiarity. My head pounds behind my eyes and sweat trickles down the side of my temples to the back of my head.

I cranked my neck, turning my head toward the sound, desperate to see who owned the voice that left a foul echo inside my mind.

Where the hell am I?

Why is my brain fuzzy?

"What?" I inched up onto my elbows, only to fall back down from the room buzzing in and out. Was that a cat? Three doors? Three windows? No. There are no windows in a cell. Everything was distorted by manipulation.

Heavy footsteps thudded closer, and for a second, I thought it matched my heart. "I said, who are you, Beatrice?"

"Who are you?" I counter, tilting my head, trying my hardest to see. "Did you drug me?" I asked, confused by my vision going black and then coming back in. Nothing ever stayed in focus long enough.

He finally stepped out of the dark shadow of the corner. "Sorry, Cub, but since new revelations have come to light..." I didn't have to see to recognize the voice. Now that it's closer and the haze of my brain isn't as marbled as it was, it feels more familiar.

Aeron.

He kneeled beside my bed, but I lay back anyway, scrunching my eyes closed. I don't want to see him. I don't want to feel him. I thought I ran from him, far enough to have him not catch me. "... You're no longer something I need to keep alive. Now you're something I need to kill and bury—like you should have been a long time ago."

Who am I?



CHAPTER ONE



“Hit ‘Em Up”—2Pac

When I was a little girl, my grandpa, who I called “Pops” would tell me “Bea, you’re just like your Nona. You have so much fight in you. A little spitfire. Just remember, that it doesn’t matter the size of the dog, what matters is the size of the fight inside the dog. We all have good and bad in us, Bea, make sure you feed the right one.”

Through high school and college, I had that embedded in my brain. When I would get bullied, I would tell myself to “feed the right fire”—Until, I broke Jackson Peterson’s nose for touching my, then best friend’s, ass. Yeah, I got suspended for that, never mind the fact this limp dick jock just inappropriately groped someone. His excuse? Was that she was wearing a short skirt, so she was obviously screaming for attention.

There was screaming after that, but it wasn’t from her. There was a lot of blood and crunching bones, and I was slightly worried about how my pops would react to what I had just done. Only when he picked me up from school, he took me to get a chocolate shake at our local diner and squeezed my hand. “You did good, kid. Must have been one helluva right hook. You get that from your nona too.” In his eyes, I got everything from my nona. A few years later, on the day of my graduation, my pops passed away. I went to wake him in the morning, but when my hand touched his stiff cold arm, I knew.

Phases then passed through my mind.

Phase one: Why isn’t he waking up?

Phase two: Seriously, Pops, wake up.

Phase three: Pops?

Phase four: the cracking sound of my heart splitting open in my chest.

My pops was my world. He taught me everything I knew and set up all the fundamental values I have as a person today. His funeral was very brief and sad. Aside from the grave workers and the priest, it was just me.

Actually, he would probably haunt me for saying that he made me the person I am today, because right now? I don't have those fundamental values.

Flipping a bottle of Grey Goose upside down, I pour a shot into one of the glasses that are lined on the counter.

"Twenty-one?" I grin, draining the vodka down the line of shots.

Young guy in front of me nods his head, a cheesy smile on his face. He is cute, in a puffy I-still-live-in-my-mom's-basement-feed-me-then-screw-me kind of way. In other words, not my type.

"It's my birthday!"

"I see that." I gesture to the shot glasses, flicking the bottle up and putting it back on the shelf.

I watch as he slowly tips his head back and sinks one after the other. When he stops at twelve and dashes for the bathroom, my roommate Kyle puts his hand out to me.

"Dish it up, Beat. You know I won that."

Rolling my eyes, I reach into my back pocket and pull out a fifty. Slamming it onto the palm of his hand, I narrow my eyes. "You know it's so not gentlemanly to take from a lady!"

He laughs, tilting his head back. "Well, I'm not a gentleman, and sugar, you are no lady."

I flip him off as he walks to the back of the bar. Kyle and I met around four months ago when I first moved here from Pennsylvania. After my pops died over a year ago, I couldn't stay in that town anymore. I packed up the house, sealed it up and left. I still have his inheritance money sitting in my savings account, untouched. Eighty-three thousand, seven hundred sixty-nine dollars was how much I inherited after the mortgage was taken care of, and \$83,769 is how much is in there to this day. I couldn't be there anymore. I'm originally from Australia, but when my mom and dad passed away in a house fire, my pops and nona (who had always lived in the US), took me in. Since then, at the tender age of eight, I have lived in the land of the free. Some say I still have a slight Aussie "twang" to my voice, but I personally think they're just taking too much acid. So, for the past year, I've been drifting from town to town, making my way across the country. I guess you could say that I'm a drifter. I'm not sure what I'm searching for yet, but when I find it, I'll know.

Later that night after our shift, we're back home 'laxing out and watching the latest Wentworth.

"You know, we should do this every night." Kyle winks at me.

I shake my head. "Nope. I can't do this every night." Stabbing my spoon into my ice cream. "Unlike you, I actually gain pounds by so much as sniffing sugar."

Kyle chuckles, rubbing the palm of his hand over his thick abs. "That's why I work out, young one!" He stands from the sofa and takes my plate. I give it to him and curl my legs under my butt, watching as Kyle strolls into the kitchen to drop the plates into the sink. He is nice to look at, I'll give him that, and although we have a strict no-sleeping-together rule, I'd be lying if I said it never crossed my mind once or twice in the privacy of my bedroom. Dark blond hair, tanned skin, and deep brown eyes. He's beautiful.

I really need to get laid before I make a huge mistake.

Crawling up from the sofa, I sneak upstairs into my bedroom and drop down onto my queen-sized bed, turning to face the ceiling. Usually, I'd be restless by now and itching to move to a new town, but I don't know. I'm kind of liking New Orleans.



CHAPTER TWO



“Mothaphukin g”—Eazy-E

Manik

Throwing my notepad on to the table, I tear my cap off and fling it across the room.

“Still going through your slump?” Lenny asks around chewing his gum.

My jaw clenches. “Yeah, somethin’ like that.”

“Bro, don’t fucking sweat it. It’ll come back,” Lenny adds. Lenny has been with me since we were kids. He was the nerdy-slash-fucking annoying little motherfucker who hung off my every move in high school. I tried getting rid of him for a month solid, but he never fucking budged. He came back, and back again. I never lowered myself to bullying the little fuck—in fact, people learned pretty quickly that if they came near Lenny, they came near me—and that was something no one ever wanted. Maybe I should have bullied him, maybe it would have been more effective. However, he’s my best friend now, and not so fucking little.

My foot taps in frustration as I run my hand over my jaw. “Nah, that’s not it.”

Lenny chuckles, leaning forward. I watch him pick up a rolled-up dollar bill and shove it up his nose. He inhales the line of coke, clearing his nostril while leaning back in the leather sofa. We’re in the studio for the fucking fifth time this week—shooting blanks.

“Maybe you need to join old Pops for one of his... jobs... to get some more inspiration.”

I snort. “Yeah, I ain’t really chasing what I brought to my last album. But, if I do want another psychopathic, lyrically insane album, I’ll be sure to shed some more blood with the old man.”

Vladimir Pakhan Romanov, aka, my dad. The notorious and infamous Russian Bratva boss. Being raised by a famous mafia Russian Bratva Krestnii Otets in the United States was pretty much fucking unheard of for someone of my stature (what with the fame and shit), but to me, he was just my dad—who already had a documentary show all about him—conspiracies. He’s fascinating for the system, something they need to entertain the masses. Dad’s fourth generation, which is why I have what you could call—extracurricular activities that involve me being engaged in The Family business when I’m not spitting rhymes. Yeah, if you haven’t guessed it, I’m a Vor.

“Whatcha wanting to bring this time, Ae.”

“I don’t know. Something darker, but not in a murderous way. Done enough of that bullshit to last a while. Just darker. Messy. Fucking destruction, but it can’t be forced.”

Lenny leans back in the large leather seat I have in my studio. I had the studio built in my house a couple years ago, just above my garage. Living in LA was never going to be my fucking thing—ever. Everything about Hollywood fucks with me, so I never moved from my hometown in New Orleans. I do have a studio in LA though. I started my record label, Korol’ Records a little over two years ago.

Music will not turn to shit, not on my watch.

“I know what we need to do.” Lenny stands up, throwing my smokes at me. I take them, putting one in my mouth and sparking it up. I blow out a cloud of smoke. “Yeah? And what’s that?”

The door opens and my other two minions walk in. Bo and Xavier—or as we call him—X. Hats flipped backward, hoodies up, all laughing about something they were obviously talking about just before walking in.

I ignore them, turning my attention back to Lenny, who tosses the rolled up hundred at me. “We could roll out. Got a buddy who has opened this place on the eastside.”

My phone rings in my pocket and I reach in, grabbing it out.

“Syn...” my dad growls down the phone.

I flick the dollar bill around my fingers. “Yeah?”

“Meet me at a bar downtown.”

My eyes narrow. It’s not often, if ever, my dad has ever asked me to meet him at a bar downtown. “Alright. Which one?”



CHAPTER THREE



“Top of the line”—Rittz

Beat

“Beat!” Kyle calls out over the loud music. The club is pumping tonight, but it is almost every night of the weekend.

I turn to face him, diving my glass into the ice box.

He waves a tub of ice cream in front of his face.

I shake my head. “What?” What is he doing now? It’s no secret that Kyle is a jokester. He’s terrible.

He starts scooping out spoonfuls of ice cream and putting a bit into each shot glass. Kyle is the mixologists to end all mixologists. When he makes cocktails, he creates art.

Kyle leans forward, licking the ice cream off the spoon.

I shake my head, handing my customer his glass. “You’re such an idiot!”

“What?” He puts his hand near his ear.

“IDIOT!” I yell. He laughs, his face so bright and wide that it has my smile spreading like an infectious disease. Everyone needs a friend like Kyle.

He’s still laughing when his eyes go over my shoulder, but then he stops. His smile falls and his eyes go wide. Shocked by his sudden change in demeanor, I turn around to follow his line of sight when my attention lands on the front doors.

I freeze.

I can see Kyle coming closer to me from the corner of my eye.

Holy crap, is that?

“Manik, aka Aeron fucking Romanov-Reed,” Kyle whispers from behind me, his breath ghosting over my back. I have seen photos of him all over the media, and when I say all over the media, I truly mean *everywhere*. He is the greatest rapper to live and rivaled even the greatest who had passed.

I tilt my head slightly, hoping to get a better look at him. Black leather jacket with a hoodie underneath, dark washed denim jeans and some clean white sneakers on his feet. My eyes go back to his face.

I gulp.

He’s obviously a work of art. Handcrafted to perfection. Intense sharp jaw with prominent cheekbones and an annoyingly perfect straight nose. You couldn’t see from here, but I knew he also carried deep blue eyes that were paired with dark eyelashes, which fanned over his tanned skin. He has equally dark hair that is no doubt the perfect length for his groupies to run their fingers through. And his body... well. It is obviously crafted by some ancient Russian god and then embellished with all the tattoos that were inked into his flesh. It isn’t just his looks though, he is talented, respected, and from what I have heard—not to be messed with on any level. I may have watched a Netflix documentary about his dad, Vladimir Romanov. Also, what I learned from the media is that Aeron, or “Manik,” had a taste for the rich and famous, although he has never been seen with the same girl more than once.

So, he’s a man whore, too. Shocker.

“I wonder what he’s doing here?” Kyle adds, extracting me from my deep thoughts. I watch as his crew—around a dozen of them—split the busy crowd in half and make their way to one of the three VIP areas upstairs. The whole club is double level, but the entirety of the upstairs can be viewed from downstairs and vice versa.

I shrug, turning back around to busy myself with making more drinks. “Who knows. Maybe he’s bored with his extra life.”

Kyle searches my eyes and laughs. “Yeah, maybe.” When Kyle is back near his station, which is on the other side of the bar, I crane my head over my shoulder to look up at Manik and his crew one more time. My eyes collide with his when I see he’s already watching me. Rittz “Top of The Line” is playing in the background, but it slowly fades into the back of my mind and all I can hear is the thrashing of blood coursing through my veins. He slowly brings his drink to his mouth, keeping his eyes on mine as his legs spread wide, taking up half of the blood-red sofa. The camera could never capture the intensity of his stare, it makes me squirm. The song’s baseline thuds, vibrating through me. My lashes flutter and I quickly spin back around and go to the fridge, taking out a carton of milk.

I should not look up there again.

The rest of my shift goes by tensely and briskly. I managed to stay busy, but I was always conscious of the crowd in the VIP area, and every now and then, I swear I could feel eyes on me. Or, I was just being paranoid.

I check my watch. Quarter to four in the morning. Perfect. Only fifteen minutes left to go before everyone needs to get the hell out. The crowd had long since thinned out, with most people leaving around the three a.m. mark.

I pour a shot of Patron and shoot it back. I don’t drink, I’m not a heavy drinker by any means, but my nerves could do with a break. Jesta’s is a large club, but it sure felt small with Manik and his entourage being here. They left around thirty minutes ago, and I made an extra effort to not watch as

they made their way out of the bar.

“You alright?” Kyle asks, slapping my ass.

I shove him. “Stop, and yes, just feeling a little tired tonight is all.”

He nods his head over his shoulder. “Go home. I’ll clean up and see you this afternoon.”

“You sure?” Normally, I don’t let him do this, but I could really do with sleeping for one-hundred thousand years, or just into next week.

He nods his head again. “Get out.”

I chuckle. “Ok, then.” I head to the back of the bar, taking my leather jacket off the hanger and putting it over my short crop top. The general bar attire is a short black crop top, a little short leather skirt, and black fishnet stockings. A couple of the other girls wear heels, but I wear knee high Doc Martens, slightly unlaced. I’m pulling my smokes out from my pocket while stumbling out from the staff exit at the back of the bar. It’s backed up to a large overgrown bush area with an old wire fence and a couple of large garbage cans. It’s sort of creepy, but I’ve always liked the unease of it all.

Banging the lighter on the palm of my hand, I go to light it, but it won’t flick.

“Crap.” I drop my hand and take my keys out of my pocket, walking toward my little beat up Mazda hatchback, when I stop. Unexplained apprehension grips my spine, freezing my movements. Fear ripples through me and before I’m even turning around, my fingers are shaking.

Maybe it’s the Patron.

But it’s not.

My eyes land on Manik first, and then they swing around to the three other guys who are all standing defensively. Obviously shocked to see me.

I tilt my head.

“Should I ask what you guys are doing out here?” Adrenaline must ignite my bravery. Famous or not, they left thirty-minutes earlier. Why are they all standing out here looking shady, and besides, I don’t even like rap music. I like jazz & R&B and anything that I can dance to. I haven’t been able to dance in a while, not since my pop passed. He would come watch me dance at the Metro Center in Philly. I may have fire when I dance, but that’s only because my pops was the lighter fluid of support. I loved watching his eyes light up proudly. I’m too afraid to start again because it would be too sad to realize the flame may have died.

Manik’s jaw tenses, then he shifts slightly, and that’s when my eyes fall to the ground, where a man is lying face down.

My eyes fly back up to them, the streetlight from the road casting shadows over their bodies.

I walk backward.

Manik counters my footsteps, coming toward me. More like a prowler. Calculated, slow. Like he’s thinking about what his next move will be.

My attention goes back to the man on the road, then I see it. The sticky blood that is oozing out of his head, expanding into a puddle beneath him. A scream rips out from me, but only for a second, because in the next, Manik pounces and has his tattooed hand wrapped around my mouth and his chest pressed to my back. I breathe in and out heavily, my chest rising and falling as tears drop down my face.

“Ae!” one of the guys call out to him, and he shoves me forward, his hand still covering my mouth. Headlights cut through the dark, a car slowing near the entry to the parking lot. I start flailing my hands around to wave them down, hope growing inside my chest. That hope is short-lived when a sleek black limo slowly pulls into the driveway and stops right near the guys. Manik keeps walking us closer, to where the body is.

I moan, my eyes slamming shut. I've never seen a dead body before, and the sight is making my stomach turn.

"There's her bar mate, he'll be out any minute now. We need to move unless you want to add another body to the pile," one of the other guys announces, pulling out his smokes. The stretch limo door swings open, and a tall lanky guy stands, seems to assess the area, and then steps aside.

My eyebrows knit in confusion.

I see the top of a fedora and then—I start to scream, my legs and arms kicking around, but Manik squeezes my mouth and shakes me. His lips come to my ear as he whispers. "Shut the fuck up, little *voronoy*."—Vor what? His tongue curls around the foreign syllables like a perfectly crafted poem.

One of the big guys who is with Manik's crew laughs. "Oh, she knows of Pops." Vladimir Romanov buttons up his suit jacket and slightly stretches his neck. I can't see his eyes from here, only the sharp edge of his scruffy jaw. Fear cripples me so much that my throat dry retches.

"Aeron, what's going on here?" His voice is smooth, like a shot of aged whiskey. It sends shivers down my spine.

Please, please stay in the bar extra long tonight, Kyle.

"Don't know," Manik says from behind me, his voice growling over my back. His other hand drops to my bare stomach, his fingers stretching out to hold me there. "This fucker tried to shoot me, and we got him first. I don't know who sent him."

"I'm not talking about the boy, Syn." His voice is low, eerie. Then he tilts his head up to look at me. I freeze, goosebumps rising over my flesh. Manik's fingers twitch on my stomach. He clicks his fingers, and the lanky guy who got out of the limo first goes to the trunk, taking out a clear tarp. He gets to work on the body and I turn my head away.

"Oh, this? Bartender. She strolled out right after."

Vlad's eyes come to mine, pure hate vibrates off his energy, directed at me. Maybe that's just how he looks at everyone. "Take her."

I swallow.

"Now, Syn. All of you—leave."

I can't leave. I have my car here, and I just witnessed a murder. A murder that is involved with, not just *one of*, but *the* biggest mob boss in American Russian history. The guys who are with Manik start walking toward a white suped up Mercedes SUV.

The Popeye on steroids, the one with long-ish hair, opens the door wide. "Throw her in." My eyes go to his pleadingly. "Oh, we don't bite, sweetheart."

Manik shoves me into the back, loosening his grip around my mouth. I don't scream, I don't fight, because I know that no matter what I do, there's nothing that can save me at this point. There are too many of them and they're experienced. These aren't stupid thugs, these are men who know what they're doing and do it with precision.

Tears stream down my face as I wrap my arms around my torso defensively. Manik reaches in and snatches the keys that were still in my hands, throwing them out the door to another guy. Leaning my head back against the seat, I ignore Manik when he climbs in next to me, his hard thigh pressing against my leg.

When the door closes and the car starts, I whisper, "Are you going to kill me?"

He doesn't answer, so I crane my head around to look at him.

He stares down at me. How can someone so achingly beautiful hold a soul so dark. Or maybe that's how it works, maybe the most beautiful faces hide the darkest souls.

The guy in the passenger seat hands Manik a couple of cable ties. He pulls them apart and grabs

my hands, banding them together.

I search his eyes. “Well?”

He glares back at me, and I try not to wince from the intensity in his stare. “You’ll have to wait and fucking see.”

“Where are you taking me?” I counter, looking away from him and to the front of the car.

He doesn’t answer, but glances to the driver in the rearview mirror.

“Kyle will know something is wrong,” I answer softly, watching the trees pass by.

Manik’s phone dings with a text, and he pulls it open. I look over to him briefly and watch as his mouth tips up in a crooked grin. “Really? Because Beatrice Kennedy, it looks like you jump around a lot and have no living family.”

I swallow nervously.

He looks at me finally, his eyes darkening. “So, I’ll take you wherever the fuck I want.”



CHAPTER FOUR



“Thug Love”—Bone Thugs

Manik

I swipe my phone off the counter, pressing it to my ear. “What’s wrong?”

“Where’s the girl?” Dad mutters.

I twist the cap off my beer with my teeth and take a swig, slamming the door with my fist. “Here.”
There’s a long stretch of silence.

“Was it taken care of?” I further ask when I realize he’s not going to comment on my previous statement.

“The boy you ganked? Yes, it was.”

I squeeze the bottle. “I don’t know who sent him.”

“Doesn’t matter right now, Syn. I need you focused. About the girl, maybe keep her around a bit longer until you hear from me. Got it?”

“Loud and clear.”

I hang up the phone, tossing it back on the counter. Yeah, I’ll be keeping her around a bit.

Blood spilled near Aeron’s feet, his mom’s eyes going toward the man pleadingly. “Please, leave my son, he didn’t ask for this. He didn’t—” The man and woman who’d kidnapped Aeron and his mother laughed, leaning down near her face and bringing the sharp edge of the knife to just under her jaw.

“You asked for this life, bitch!”

Aeron couldn't stop the tears from falling anymore. He wanted to be strong like his daddy, but seeing his mom like that broke him in a way that no child should ever be broken. The kind of way that awakens a beast.

Beast

I search the room and take in a couple of things.

One, I'm in a basement. Not entirely old, or even beat up, just—a basement. There are dusty wooden stairs that I can see leading up to a door and a small window behind me. The fact that there's already a bed down here should be concerning. The sheets aren't exactly dusty and old either, it's almost as though the bed is made. Like he was waiting for someone. Was he? Maybe he locks girls down here for fun.

My head is pounding, my mouth is dry and tacky and I need to pee like no one's business, but the slight fear of dying is stopping me from asking.

The door opens, and I crawl backward until I'm pressed against the wooden headboard.

Manik comes down the stairs, his chest bare and his grey sweatpants hanging off his lean hips.

He pins me with a glare, his eyes flat. His features are shrouded in pain but shadowed by what one could only describe as evil.

I clear my throat. "Can you let me go?" So, it's worth a try.

His jaw clenches, and he tilts his head as his eyes drop down my body. "How about no."

"Okay, well can I go pee? I'm bursting."

His eyes narrow as he pushes his hands into his pockets. "Do you know who I am?"

I gulp again. "Um, yes. Aeron Romanov-Reed. I know of you, if that was the question..."

He advances closer, lighting a cigarette. He inhales deeply, his eyes squinting from the smoke and then blows out the cloud, clenching the cigarette between his thumb and index finger. "That wasn't the fucking question. I asked you if you *know* who I am." He then steps closer to me, his eyes on mine. "Look into my eyes and tell me," he pauses, inhaling his smoke. He blows the cloud out in my face, a smirk on his mouth. "Do you know *who* I am?"

I tilt my head, confused. "I don't know how to answer that."

His hand comes out and he grabs my wrist, shoving me down onto the mattress until I'm flat on my back and panting. He seems to pause for a second like he's having a silent conversation with himself on how he's going to continue, but then he jackknives off the bed and stands. "You'll stay here for as long as I fucking want you here." Then he tilts his head and smirks. "*Cub.*"

"Okay then can you answer one question? Are you going to kill me?" I ignore the pet name, my lips starting to tremble with nerves.

His eyes darken. "Yes."

"I won't tell anyone," I say, rushed. "I swear. Listen, I don't—it doesn't." I shake my head and he sits beside me on the bed, the mattress sinking under his weight. I exhale. "I won't tell anyone."

The door opens, letting in a sliver of light. My eyes shoot toward it, but I can see Manik watching me out of the corner of my eye.

I slowly look back at him.

His eyes.

I flinch at the burning intensity.

“Manik?” a big guy—one of the guys who was there last night—says.

Manik slowly peels his eyes away from me, looking over his shoulder. “What?”

“Ah, your old man is coming over to check on the issue.”

“Me being the issue?” I whisper out, more to myself than to them.

I rest my head on the headboard. Suddenly, it’s hot and I’m flustered. I’m going to fucking die. Something happens when you surf close to the riptide of death, it’s as though you start to second guess every wave you rode to get there. I’ll never get to surf them again. Who would miss me? I don’t think anyone would. I don’t have family. Christmases were always spent alone, my birthdays, even more lonely. Truly, what is the point? Defeated, I get to my feet, ignoring whatever they’re talking about and remove my leather jacket.

Their chatting halts immediately, and I turn to face Manik. “Just, please make it fast. I know you don’t owe me anything, but I’m hoping that there’s some human compassion under all that hard exterior and you’ll just, do me a solid.”

I open my eyes when I don’t get a reply, and Manik’s eyes are on my right arm. He’s eating up every inch of my skin. I look down at my arm, then back at him. “I like tattoos.”

He licks his lip and then looks back to the guy on the stairs. “Leave.”

Oh God. Oh God here we go.

The guy looks at Manik, and then at me. He gives me a small smile that speaks louder than a verbal warning could give, and then turns and retreats. Manik stands and I clench my fists so tight my nails sink into my palms, forming little crescent moons. I can feel his presence. His heat is thrashing into me without us physically touching. I keep my eyes closed and watch behind my lids as little color dots dance around in various shapes.

My chest rises and falls.

Inhale, exhale.

A gun safety clicks.

I freeze, my heart thundering in my chest. The silence is deafening, with nothing but the pounding of my heart and loud desperate inhales of breath.

A cold metal ring presses against my forehead and I squeeze my eyes shut tighter, my shoulders stiffening. Sweat drips from my forehead and down the bridge of my nose, balancing on the tip.

He fires.

Bang.

I flinch, expecting something. Anything, as I wait for death.

I slowly peel my eyes open again and they land on Manik, dropping his other hand to the side of him.

My lip trembles, my knees shake. I drop to the ground in a heap and sob. “What?”

I curl into a ball and rock softly, the tears soaking the front of my shirt.

“I changed my mind. I’d rather see you fucking suffer,” is all he says, making his way back to the stairs.

I can’t form words. My mouth is stiff and dry, fear and terror seizing my bones. When he finally reaches the top of the stairs, I swipe my face and ask, “When did you change your mind?”

He looks at me over his shoulder and smirks. “About one second before I pulled the trigger, and Beatrice, this isn’t a fucking guarantee on your life. This is a fucking promise to you suffering, because when I’m done, you’re going to wish that bullet went through your skull and not into the wall.”

Horror. Pure undiluted horror.

He jerks his head over his shoulder. “Bathroom is on the other side of the room. Would rather not clean up your body fluids.” Then he leaves, the door slamming behind him.

As soon as he’s gone, I dive toward where he gestured, finding the grungy pale pink door and kicking it open. Rushing, I dive head first toward the bowl just as saliva and small parts of whatever I last ate comes gushing out of my mouth. I dry retch a few times until my throat burns from the acid of my stomach lining. Sagging against the wall, I swipe the residue from my mouth. I know why I’m here, but I don’t know why he’s *keeping* me. Maybe that’s how he got his name, from his neurotic thoughts. We all know his music is insane, and if that’s even a slight glimpse to inside his head, then his thought process is not something I should feel comfortable about.

God, I’m so screwed. I stand and rinse my hands in the little porcelain sink, then dry them with the soft cotton towel that’s hanging there.

Why would a man who has everything want someone like me locked in a damn basement? And why do I feel so much hatred from him? Hatred I didn’t earn.

I just want to leave. I feel sick. I’ve never experienced the feeling of homesickness, not even the slightest inclination of feeling homesick. Probably because I never really had a home. Aside from Sydney and my nona and pops, I’ve never really felt like I had a home, or a family. Not the kind that most think of, but right now, I want my lonely life back. Better to be lonely than dead.

I head out of the bathroom and go back to the bed, crawling into a ball and slamming my eyes shut, thinking of slightly better days.

One, two, three. My feet move to the rhythm of the music, my body rolling like a perfectly orchestrated choir. Music is my life, and dancing is my soul, one can’t survive without the other.

“Yo! Beat! Hit this jam!”

“Mi Gente” by Beyoncé starts playing.

“Ohhh, I see what you did there...” I teased him with a wink. My head nodded slightly, then when the beat dropped, my body broke down the syllables smoothly enough to have the small crowd gasping. I waved my hands around, moving my hips with it. I was freestyling, which is what I loved to do most. I loved choreography, but freestyling was something more freeing. Less politics and restrictions. It was just where you got to let loose and showcase what you’ve got off the bat. Bey’s verse came in and I flicked my hair, popping my ass out and shaking slightly. I had the ass to do it—and I’ve always had the small waist. Dancing has given me a very fit body, so every muscle I had was defined and ripped. I wasn’t a small girl, I was a fit girl. I ate as hard as I danced. The base dropped again and I let it flow, dropping to the ground on my back and snaking my shoulders up in a wave motion before flipping onto my stomach and pressing the tips of my toes into the ground and shaking my ass as I came back to standing. The song finished and everyone cheered loudly.

“Damn, Beat!” Gerald slapped my ass. “That shit was tight. I’m putting that up on YouTube, stat!”

I laughed, shaking my head while taking a drink of water, then the next song played.

My skin prickles in shock and I shiver, my eyes popping open. The room is dark, with the only light coming from the small window above the bed. It didn’t give much, just the outline of the bright moon.

So cold, so dark.

“Jesus, he wasn’t kidding,” a voice purrs from somewhere in the room.

I quickly shoot up, crawling to the headboard and pulling the covers up with me. The girl I can see now, comes closer to the bed, the slight crack of light glowing over her face.

Dark hair, that's all I can see right now, a slim body and jaw length, razor-sharp dark hair—"Who are you?"

She tilts her head, the same way I've seen Manik tilt his. "I'm Katiya, Aeron's little sister." She takes a seat on the mattress.

I freeze, wondering how this would go. "What do you want?"

"Hmmm?" she asks, then her head turns to me and I get a full look because she's directly in front of the window. Large lips, pale skin, dark hair, and almond-shaped eyes—can't tell the color right now. Her face shape is different than her brother's though. Where his is clean-cut, square and prominent, hers is round. Beautiful, almost baby-like.

She smiles. "Oh, I'm not going to hurt you. Ae just told me that he had a girl locked in his basement. I thought he was joking, but he wasn't."

I swallow. "Ok." I had a sip of the tap water earlier, but it didn't do near enough to curb the ache in my voice.

She leans over the bed and I hold my breath. She must hear the deep intake because she chuckles slightly, shaking her head, and then sits up again, handing me a bottle of water. The cool condensation slips over my fingers, taunting me. My stomach churns at the thought of wrapping my lips around the rim, so I quickly twist the cap off and toss it across the ground, taking the water in with a couple of large gulps. The first sip is like nothing I've ever experienced. The cool liquid soothes the dry cracks that had formed in my throat. Best. Feeling. Ever. I drink the whole lot, and then slowly swipe my mouth.

She clears her throat. "You seem surprised to see me? Like you didn't know he had a sister," she says it with a scoff in her voice. As if every person would know who she is. Maybe they did, I don't know.

"Because I am surprised. I don't know who you are, and you're right." I put the bottle onto the ground and slowly lean back against the headboard again. I can feel the water rushing through my bloodstream, hydrating my bones. I shiver, shaking my head. "I didn't know that he had a sister."

There's a long pause. "Really?" she is skeptical of my words, and that's okay, because I'm skeptical of her reasons for being here.

"Really."

"Huh," she hmphed and then points to the bottle. "Want another?"

I shake my head.

She stands slowly, retreating back to the stairs. She turns slightly just before she gets there. "My brother has killed people for much less than what you've witnessed. He's relentless and savage. Do not think under any circumstance that just because you're beautiful that he will let you live, because he won't."

My body stills, even though her words don't come as a surprise. "Why are you telling me this?"

"Because. If you're going to attempt to escape," she forces out the words *attempt to escape* rather obviously, like she's maybe hinting for me to do it. She continues. "I would do it fast, but know this, little Cub, that if you speak of what has happened here to anyone, ever, I will know, and let me tell you something. If you think my brother is evil, and my father is the devil, then wait until you've met Lilith—me." Then she jogs up the stairs before I can ask any more questions, the door closing behind her.

Escape.

Shit.

Should I try? What if he catches me and kills me? But, what if I stay here and he kills me anyway? Rather live on my feet than die on my knees, right? Another line from my pops. I stand from the bed and turn toward the window. I have no idea what time it is, but judging by the obscure setting outside and the bright full moon, I'd say—I have no idea. Between seven p.m and four a.m.

Crawling up onto the bed, I grip the window trim and take a closer peek outside. The grass is right there, level with the window, and from what I can see from here, it's maybe the backyard because there are trees lining the back. I can't see much more than that. I try my luck by pressing on the sill, but it doesn't budge. Must be locked from the outside. Frantically, I turn around and my eyes fly all over the room in search of something—anything I can use. The prickle of adrenalin spikes my ingenuity when I find a thick cloth hanging delicately over a small door that leads into a crawl space. Quickly, I dash toward it and then go back to the window. Wrapping the cloth around my fist, I breathe in and then out a couple of times, internally giving myself a pep-talk. I've seen this happen on movies all the time—it can't be that hard, right?

Closing my eyes, I rear my elbow back and punch into the glass. I hear the distinct sound of glass shattering when my eyes pop back open.

“Yes!” I whisper out excitedly. Then it dawns on me. I don't know where I am. We didn't drive far, so we have to still be in New Orleans or the surrounding district, and anyway, I just need to get out and I'll worry about the rest later.

Wet drops start trickling down my arm and I flinch when a sudden rush of stinging pain courses through my bones. I look down at my hand and see the cloth must have slipped at the last minute, or sharp shards slipped through because there's a deep gash right between two of my knuckles. I throw the cloth aside, fearing that some loose glass bits are still wrapped up inside of it and reach for the windowsill again, removing the larger pieces that are still stuck in the pane. Pushing myself up, I slide through the window. I wince from a sharp pain that shoots through my hip, but there's no stopping now. Another thing to worry about later. With grass and dirt digging into my nails, I finally get to my feet.

I'm out.

I'm almost there.

Dropping back down when I feel too exposed, I drag myself through the shrubs as the dehydrated leaves scrape against my flesh. Standing back up, I don't look anywhere, I just shoot forward and run. I run fast and I don't look back. It's dark, but I can make out the deep shadows of the trees lining the backyard. To the left, I can hear laughter, music, and glasses clinking together. I ignore it and keep running, my legs power the hardest I've ever pushed them. I'm almost there, the trees are getting larger and I can see a clearing between two that I'm making my way toward. I'll run through the forest, hide, and think things through more thoroughly, maybe case out my surrounding area and see—a hard body crashes into my back, causing me to nosedive onto the grass. My nose throbs and I instantly taste the metallic sting of blood oozing down my throat.

Whoever is behind me is not wearing a top, because I can almost feel the thick indents of his abs pressing into my back.

“Where you think you're going, Cub?” I can smell the strong stench of alcohol.

Manik.

“Please, just let me go. I promise I won't say anything to anyone...” My voice is muffled from the grass and dirt that's pressed against my face. Fresh pine needles and mud rubbing into my cheeks, creating a smell similar to that of a football locker room after a game.

Silence.

I turn my head sideways and see his tattooed fist beside my face. His body is heavy on top of mine.

“No,” he answers simply.

“No?” I reply, waiting for him to elaborate.

He must lean down because his lips come to the back of my ear. “No,” he repeats through a whisper.

I gulp. I’m going to ignore what my body is doing right now, because it’s being a sick, demented slut, so I clench my thighs together.

His body stiffens.

Oh shit. Did he feel that?

His hand comes to the front of my throat where he squeezes and yanks my head up to face him from the side. I can’t see him clearly, but I can see the outline of his features thanks to the light from where he came from.

“Do not fuck with me, *Beatrice*,” he spits my name with so much disdain I flinch. “Because I don’t fuck fair.”

I’ve never really been a fan of swearing. I can think of one hundred other words that can be used to insult someone with the same impact, but the way Manik swears? His tongue clips out each syllable—and unfortunately, it does nothing to calm my erratic needs. I don’t like the way my body responds to his proximity. It has no right to react to his words or his touch.

“I’m not trying to do anything, Manik, I just want to leave...”

“Can’t do that...” he growls into my ear and then grips my hips to flip me onto my back. He glares down at me. Again, I can’t see him clearly, but I can feel the burn of him penetrating into me. I can see the defined, cut lines that shadow his cheekbones, and the vein that’s pulsing in his tattooed neck.

I lick my lips, and his leg opens one of mine so he can rest between them easier.

I still, trying to slam my legs closed to block his entrance, but fail miserably.

He forces them open anyway. I think my bleeding nose has somewhat stopped, but my hand and my hip are still throbbing in pain.

“I won’t rat, Manik. You don’t need to keep me here.”

“Oh, but I do...”

That catches my attention. Why would he need to keep me here?

“What?” I murmur, moving my head to rest sideways, the grass brushing against my cheek. “Why?”

His mouth comes over mine, just enough to feel his breath fall onto my lips. “Because I’m a bad man who has done very bad things, and you just so happened to fall onto the wrong radar. Or maybe it was the right one...” He pauses, then chuckles. “Either way, you’re fucked.”



CHAPTER FIVE



“A Kiss”—Bad Meets Evil

Manik

My dad took me into a building, industrial and heavy with metal. He sucked on his cigar and I watched his back that was covered by his long trench coat. The five other members of our family following closely beside him.

He glanced over his shoulder, his eyes squinting on me. “Syn, I’m going to teach you a hard lesson today, but it’s a lesson you need to learn.” Then he turned to me completely and dropped to my level. His hand rested on my shoulder. “You’re young right now, Syn, but one day, you are going to be initiated into the Bratva and become a Vor. You will have your ritual and you’ll sure make me one proud otets. But right now, there’s an important set of lessons you must learn in order to be the best version of you that I need you to be. Understand, Syn?” My father searched my eyes very closely, and I nodded, swallowing past my fear. I’d always known who my father was—to an extent. I may only be all of eleven years old right now, but I know the respect my dad held. The men he kept around. I knew my dad was in the mafia, but I didn’t know him any other way, so it wasn’t weird for me. My friends at school—the few I had, would always say that he scared them, but I didn’t understand it. See, Dad never brought the stuff he did into my home. He always respected my mom and put her on a pedestal. They were in love in a big way, we could all see it. There wasn’t a moment where his hands were not on her or hers on him, so I never really did understand the fear that everyone else was so hell-bent on casting over Dad.

That was all about to change.

Dad grabbed my hand and we began walking toward the big industrial shed. I looked over my shoulder quickly at all the boats that lined the wharf, and then gulped and gazed back ahead.

“Lesson one, Syn, is you turn cold. You turn cold toward every human walking this earth, but not completely. You save a spark, just a small flicker of heat, and when you meet the right girl, you give that one spark to her. She will ignite it into an inferno and build you a home. Your kingdom and your empire. This woman will be very important to your success. She will give you a family, and then that inferno will soar, but Syn,” he paused just as we reached the entrance. He looked down at me. “Everyone else is just flesh and bones. No one deserves that spark but her and your sem’ya.”

Screaming cut through his words, but it wasn’t a loud scream of pain, it was a scream of pleading, muffled through a closed mouth.

I nodded because what else was I supposed to do? My eyes swung to a man who was hanging by a rope, upside down. He had on no shirt and dirty old jeans. His wrists were bound together by a thick lace of the same kind of rope but dangled low above his head. His mouth was covered by a piece of silver tape, and his long hair moved with the wind and the jolting of his body. His eyes came to mine and his eyebrows knitted.

“Syn?” Dad said, interrupting my focus.

I glanced up at him, he was so tall. “Yes?”

Dad directed his attention to a man beside me, Joseph was his name, he was the consigliere. He went everywhere with Dad, but I didn’t like him. Never had. My uncle Az is the Underboss, and he and I were best friends. I wanted to be just like uncle Az when I grew up.

Dad nodded his head at Joseph and I watched as he took a dagger from him and his eyes came back down to mine. He kneeled to my height, but I was too busy watching the dagger. His fist clenched around the white base of the blade.

“This is going to be yours when you become a Vor, Syn. You will take this now. This.” his finger traced down the white base of the blade where intricate patterns were carved. “Is the bone of your ancestor.”—I need to keep my face straight, but I’d be lying if that didn’t make me think, gross. “This blade is a virgin, Syn, it’s ready for its journey—are you ready?”

No?

“Yes.” I nodded, wanting to appease my father. Craving his approval of me—his only son. My stupid ass sister would never be able to do this shit.

He smiled, handing me the blade. I took it in my small hand and I dropped it slightly. Boy, it was heavy. A lot heavier than it looked.

As I took a tentative step toward the man who was hanging, bound by the ropes, I knew then that it wasn’t necessarily something I wanted to do. I loved my father, but I wasn’t sure if this was something I wanted for myself. I liked words, and I liked music. I loved to rap when no one was watching, and I think I was okay for my age.

But, for now, and forever, I would silence my father by playing his games.

The man started wiggling more, his eyes came to mine. Dark brown to my blue. I wasn’t quite sure what scared him when he looked into my eyes, but something happened because it was as though he gave up.

Father spoke. “This is someone who owes a client a lot of money, Syn. He’s been given enough time, but it hasn’t happened. We like this client, so we need this man gone.” He leaned down again and into me. “Do you have the balls to do this, Syn? Or did I misjudge you?”

Something rose inside of me. A fire I wanted to feed, a beast that was born, something fierce that wriggled under my skin.

I looked at my dad, my eyes firm and my shoulders stiff. "You'll never misjudge me, Dad."

Then I took one more step closer and leaned in to do something with this blade, I actually wasn't sure what, when Dad's hand came out to stop me. "Like this, Syn." He pointed to a spot behind the guy's neck. "If you get the spot right, it paralyzes him completely. It makes his death slow, but his pain unbearable. It's glorious, Syn, because you get to watch the pain pass through his eyes. He can't do anything about it."

He would feel everything, without being able to do anything at all.

I walk around to see the spot and take my dad's advice, then pressed the point of the blade against the fatty flesh behind his neck, and pushed down slightly. It didn't take much pressure to penetrate his skin because my blade was very sharp, so when I saw the bubble of deep red blood surface, I sunk it deeper until it felt as though I was diving into room temperature butter.

Dad chuckled, looking up to his men and a couple of soldiers. "See, told you he was ready. He's a Romanov, it's in our blood."

He puffed on his cigar as I continued to dig into flesh.

Lesson one was the easy part.

It was what happened in lesson two that really fucked me up.

"Get up," I order, launching off her body when I realize what I'm doing.

I stand ahead of her, my eyes rolling down her body. She stands up and my eyes go to all the blood on her face, her clothes, and her hand. Something is bleeding beneath her shirt.

I clench my jaw, hooking my index finger under the edge of her shirt and yanking her into me. She pulls away, hitting at my hand. "What are you doing?"

She's feisty, it's kind of cute. The same way a baby cub is. She's cute now, but make no mistake, she could probably rip your heart out. Irony. Funny how shit slips into the puzzle so effortlessly when life happens.

I fist her shirt this time and yank her into me forcefully. Glaring down at her, she looks up at me, and I'd bet my bottom dollar those eyes would work on every man walking this earth—but I'm not every man, and she's fucking annoying me. "Don't piss me off, Cub, that's warning number two."

She continues to search my eyes. When the moment passes, I yank her shirt up, pulling my phone out of my pocket with my other hand. Shining my phone onto the gash on her hip bone, I bite my lip and drop her shirt.

"I'll fix that." I go to walk back to the house, but I sense she's not following so I turn back around to face her. "You have three seconds to move, or I'll throw you over my shoulder, Cub, and trust me, it won't be in the way girls like to be thrown over my shoulder."

She walks toward me slowly, and I see a flinch of pain flash over her face. "Then what?" she asks as we make our way back to the house, getting closer to everyone who is around the pool. Her questions are getting on my nerves.

"Then," I start. "You're going to get your ass back downstairs and stay there like I fucking said so. If you don't, I'll fucking kill you. You feel me? Or do I need to force the feeling on you? Maybe rub my dick on your face for a bit, until you get how fucking serious I am..." Her body stills, her face draining of any color. There's a long silence that stretches between us. When the song "X" by 2 Chainz starts playing and I see she's not going to reply, I continue toward the house.

Once my feet hit the concrete patio that surrounds the pool, I turn back to Beat, my eyes boring

into hers. Why the fuck hasn't she answered me. I would have expected her to have more fire...

"Yo! Man! Get your bitch back downstairs. Got some impatient girls waiting on that dick..."

Beat flinches at X's words. I lick my lips and then slowly make my way back toward her, my eyes eating up every single inch. She gulps, I catch the movement, then grin.

"You didn't like that did you...?" I bring my hand up to the side of her cheek and she slowly pulls away from me, but I run my index finger down her soft cheek anyway. I think I'm starting to fucking love how uncomfortable I make her. I take the last step until her tits are pressing against my chest. I skim my lips over hers, grinning more. "*My bitch*, that has a bit of a ring to it, hmmm?" Even as I say the words, they leave a foul taste in my mouth.

The side of her lip kicks up slightly, and if I didn't know better, I'd say she was about to snarl at me.

I lick the bottom rim of her lip. "Except you're not fucking mine, never fucking will be. Now, move your shit into the house."

I grab her wrist and yank her toward me. As we walk past the handful of people who are near the pool, my eyes meet X, who is watching us closely. "Be back in a beat."

Loud claps of laughter break out just as we make it through the opening of the formal room and toward the long hallway. There are a couple doors that lead off down here. One is another spare bedroom, another opens out onto a basketball court and gym room, the other is the entry way to my bedroom and studio. It has stairs that lead up to the studio in my room. Yanking the basement door open, I continue to drag her down the stairs, her wrist so fucking small in my hand. Once we're back at the bottom, I eye the broken window. "Until that's fixed, I'll be down here with you." I shove her onto the bed and go into the bathroom, opening up all the cupboards until I come across the first aid kit. Never fucking been in here before.

Going back to the bed, Beat rests against the headboard, drawing her legs up to her chest.

I toss the first aid kit onto the bed.

"How does this end?" Her eyes come to mine.

I let the silence drift peacefully between us, with nothing but my eyes eating up hers. When she can't take the eye contact anymore, she pulls away, shifting her head to look to the side.

"You think I want you here? Because I fucking don't."

"Well why haven't you killed me or let me go?"

I sit back down, opening the kit and tossing out some antiseptic liquid, wipes, and a bandage. "What makes you think I'll tell you anything, Voron? Hmm? And what the fuck makes you think I'm not going to kill you? Maybe I just love the thrill of teasing my prey before making a feast of them." And I do.

"That's the second time you've called me that," she whispers, her eyes darting to my hands as I rip open the wipe. "Are you going to tell me what it means?"

I chuckle. "No." Then dab some of the liquid into the cloth. Grabbing onto her ankles, I yank her down the bed until she's flat on her back. I need to stop calling her that. I need to contain all of the rage I feel bubbling inside of me and threatening to surface.

I gaze down at her. "I kinda think I like this view..." Yeah, fucking aye. Sex is a good distraction for my wrath.

She freezes.

I laugh, crawling between her legs and up her body. Her eyes stay on mine. "What are you doing?"

"Whatever the fuck I want, or have you forgotten, you're a captive here?"

“Why are you cleaning my wound if you’re just going to kill me?” she asks, not even pushing my hand away as I roll her top up. I pause when I’ve rolled it enough to display her gash, but then keep going anyway, just for fucking shits.

“Because I don’t feel like calling in the doc if it gets infected, because I’d rather you die at my hands than by an infection, and because I fucking am. Don’t take this to heart, *Printsessa*, I don’t fuck with your kind.”

After dropping some disinfectant on her, I rub the lotion over her gash and then put the clean gauze on it. It’s too fresh to do anything else right now and will need to wait a day or two.

My phone vibrates in my pocket, and I fish it out, seeing *Dad* flashing over the screen.

I answer it but point to the bed. “Don’t fucking move, I mean it.” Then I turn around and press the phone to my ear. “Yeah?”

“How’s the problem going?”

My jaw clenches as I tilt my head over my shoulder slightly. He’s a shit fucking liar. “We’ve had a couple of small mishaps, but nothing I can’t handle. Why?” I drop my voice to a shallow whisper. “You gonna fill me in what’s going on here?” So am I.

There’s an audible pause over the phone, then Dad’s tone clips out. “No. Just make sure you keep her there.”

“Why?” I grunt out again, fucking over playing babysitter.

“Because it’s an order, Syn. I’m sure you can play with her for a bit.”

I turn around to face Beat, who’s now back to sitting position and leaning against the wooden headboard. “Yeah, I don’t think so. She’s a little too breakable for my taste.”

“Christ, Syn, I don’t mean…” he sighs. “Never mind. Just, keep her there and try not to kill her just yet. Not until I see you.” He hangs up, so I push my phone back into my pocket. Man, I’m a little insulted by his assumptions.

I walk across the room and go into a small storage room that’s beside the bathroom. Pulling open the door, I go through the duffle bag that’s in there, pushing away the Glock and the army blades and pulling out a set of cuffs. I stand and fling them around my fingers, walking back toward the bed. I smirk at her as her eyes connect.

“I’ve decided I don’t wanna stay down here, so here’s the deal. I’m going to cuff you to this bed, and I will be back in the morning—how does that sound?”

She doesn’t answer, her eyes still on the cuffs.

I need to conceal the rage, take hold of it and not let it penetrate me. Years, I spent years waiting on this. *Conceal*.

“If you need to use the bathroom, now would be a good time to tell me.”

She doesn’t answer again, her eyes closing. Why the fuck is she so submissive? Or maybe she knows she’s going to die, either way, she annoys me. I like a submissive girl who knows when to be submissive. If a chick is like that constantly, it just dries out the juice.

I go back to her, snatching one wrist and clamping the metal cuff around it. Her eyes finally open, her thick lashes fluttering up as her eyes come up to me.

My hand slows as I fastened one cuff to the small poles in the headboard, my cock swelling in my pants.

I lick my lips, grinning, my eyes on hers. Then my thumb goes to her lower lip. “Well, damn, princess, with these lips around my cock and those pretty fucking eyes peering up at me like this, I might just stay down here.”

Her eyes slant away, and it’s then that I notice for the first time that there’s a spark behind her

eyes. Just fleeting, and it's gone before I can over-analyze it, but it was there. Maybe she isn't as submissive as I thought.

I put my leg over her waist, straddling her as my knee sinks into the mattress. I secure her final wrist onto the other side of the bed and then look down at her, tilting my head. Her eyes are straight up, right on my cock.

My hand flies to her throat and I clench it roughly until I feel the organ click under my palm. "Don't fucking ask for things you aren't prepared for, Cub."

Her eyes fly up from under me. "I didn't ask for anything," she whispers out huskily, or maybe it's because of the lack of oxygen. I loosen my grip. Is she taking the piss right now? Gazing up at me like she wants me to fuck her into next Sunday. I could. I would. She's way the fuck above average, which just infuriates me more. She must be fucking with me.

Let me test it.

I lean down, my legs coming between hers. "Maybe not with those lips, but you did with those eyes. Watch it."

She licks her lips again. "I don't mean to. I—"

I shove my knee up, pressing against her clit. "You what?" I rub her up and down. "You wanna fuck my cock, Cub, maybe fill that void in your chest with my nine-inch dick?" My hand comes to her tit and I squeeze. "The thing with a nine-inch cock, is it leaves a nine-inch hole. Not just in your cunt, either...so I'll say it again." Then my hand flies to her chin, my finger clenching her cheeks as I squeeze roughly until her lips tighten together. "Don't fucking ask for shit you can't handle. You think you can handle a man like me, Beatrice? You have no idea. I make the boys you bounced around with before look like child's play."

I swing off of her and storm up the stairs. I need a fucking drink, and I need my dick sucked before I end up riding this little toy right into the Bermuda Triangle and she disappears forever.



CHAPTER SIX



“Pick It Up”—Dr Dre

Beat

My heart is still pounding in my chest hours after he slammed that door and left. He’s so stupidly intense. He reminds me of a Pitbull, sets off unease throughout my entire body because of his unpredictability, and is as messy as my mind. After tossing and turning for a couple more hours, I find my mind slipping deeper into unconsciousness...

Blood hit my nostrils like a metallic river of lead rushing right in front of me.

Ash particles float across my flesh, flying up to the burning ceiling, before it opens up to reveal stars in the dark night, glistening down on me. Heat crashes into me as the flames that eat up the wood of the house threaten to lick over my skin.

A silver blade flashes across my face, but not in a threatening way, and that same metallic smell drifts past again as it moves past me. A dark trench coat steps out from the shadows, with a smudge of green, dancing in the distance.

“Where am I?” I ask, confused. I look up at the people who were standing on my street. My street?

Is this my street?

Yes, this is my street, because that’s Bindi’s house not far down. I remember Bindi.

“How can she just forget minutes after?” a voice asks, and I don’t recognize it.

Should I?

“Shhhh,” was the next voice that sounded.

Goosebumps break out over my skin all the way down to my toes.

Who am I?

I shoot up from the bed with sweat pouring down my temples. The dreams I had came often—and were often the same. When my pops was alive, I tried to ask him about them, because I’d relived the same one over and over again for as long as I could remember. So vivid, so colorful yet so dull at the same time. Pop’s would say that it was my mind mixing my fear with reality. We gathered it was about the house fire my parents died in, but that’s not how it happened. The neighbor, who was my then best friend Bindi’s aunt, was outside having a smoke when she saw the smoke and flames coming out of my parents’ window. She ran into the house and took me out, but by the time we were out, the house was already going up in flames. My pops continued to ask me if I remembered anything from before that or after, and I always said no. I remembered Bindi, but even so, the memories of her were very broken, as they would be. Who remembers every detail they had at age eight? Not me.

There’s something frightening about the dreams I have, and every time I wake up from them, I have to sleep with a light on. It would unexplainably send goosebumps over my skin. I don’t know what was worse, not knowing what happened before and around that time or maybe knowing.

Manik

“Nawwww.” Lenny tosses a bottle cap onto my lap and I shove it off. “That’s not why your old man is doing this.”

I lean my head back on my chair, stretching my legs wide out in front of me. “Yeah well, I got nothing else.” After putting Beat back downstairs, I kicked everyone out of my house but Lenny. I needed space to think. To decipher what’s going on.

“So, I am confused, though. He wanted you to kill her initially?”

I shrug. “I don’t know. You can never be too sure with him, he’s too smart. He makes a move without consulting anyone or even hinting at said move. Man.” I lean forward, running my fingers through my hair. “It would be so much fucking easier if I could just eighty-six her and move on. My old man is being sketchy when it comes to her.”

Lenny doesn’t answer me so I look up at him. “What?”

Testing, testing...

“She’s weird, right?”

And there it is. Lenny doesn’t like anyone, and he treats people like shit mostly, unless they mean something to him. That little pause he did at the top of the stairwell when he came down to get me didn’t go unnoticed. He’s starting to grow a softie for her.

“That’s cute. Real fucking cute.”

He looks at me, confused, but before he can ask me and pretend he doesn’t know what I’m talking about, my phone rings in my pocket and I pull it out to answer, my eyes flicking back to Lenny briefly.

I answer it. “Syn...”

“Yeah?”

“Tell me she’s still breathing.”

I shuffle, cranking my head. “For now, and are you going to tell me what I’m doing here? She’s a witness. Can place all of us there. With anyone else, this would be an open and shut decision. Maybe I should just drag her ass to The Pen, then it’s done. I got more important shit to do.”

Pause. Take the bait, old man. Give me a slip-up.

“Listen to me, Syn, you are not going to kill this girl. Not yet.”

I exhale. I can feel my patience wearing thin, and that never happens with my old man. “What do you need me to do? What’s got *you* so fascinated with her?”

He doesn’t answer. “I’ll be around sometime soon. Make sure she’s still there.”

Then he hangs up.

I drink the rest of my whiskey, pour another, and then drink that one too.

“What’d he say?” Lenny asks, laying back on one of the sunbeds, his eyes looking directly up at the sky.

“I need you to make sure Katiya doesn’t come over—and if she does, tell her I’m away and the girl is out of bounds.”

Lenny doesn’t answer so I kick his chair. He wakes up. “You hear me? Make sure no one goes down into that basement...”

Lenny watches me carefully. “Fuck,” he whispers, slowly getting up. “She about to meet the reaper, huh? Shame. She seems like a nice girl and she’s hot as fuck—”

“Lenny, shut up and do as you’re told.” It’s no surprise he thinks I’m about to go in there and put a bullet between her eyes. I’ve done it before and I’d do it again.

“Is she though?” he asks again just as I reach the open doors that lead back into the sitting room of the house.

“No, fucker.” I shake my head, disappointed in my right-hand man losing his grip. I need to play with her a bit, dig deep and see why the old man could be so fascinated with her.

Beat

A rough hand slams over my mouth and my eyes pop open.

“Scream if you want, no one can hear you down here...”

I gulp. I won’t scream, I won’t give him the satisfaction of doing that, so I remain quiet, my eyes slammed shut.

The bed squeaks under Manik’s weight, and he slowly climbs on top of me, one hand still firmly over my mouth.

Silence. I hear silence and the sharp intake of his breath. His other hand comes to my upper thigh, so I try to slam my legs closed, but his big body in between stops that.

“Ever felt violated, Cub?” His lips skim over my earlobe, but his harsh voice is what sets goosebumps across my skin. His hand soars up to the edge of my jeans, setting off fire with his movements. His finger dips beneath the waistband. My whole body feels like it’s burning to a crisp as sweat breaks out on my temple. I still, internally fighting with myself that I can’t let him know he has just lit a fire inside of me that should never have been ignited. The thing with boys who light fires, is they don’t care if they get burned. The room is deathly dark, and all I can hear and feel is the pulsing, the breathing, and the touch of him all over me, penetrating me like a smell I don’t ever want to scrub off.

He chuckles brazenly, like he can hear the intimate echoes inside of my head struggling against his advances, even though they secretly don't want to. "That's it. Fight me."

I buck my hips, but it only puts friction between my thighs and his thick body. Groaning in defeat, forbidden hot flashes rush through my body, taking ownership of every single cell inside of me. His other hand comes to my throat and he leans up on his elbow—I think. Judging by the weight on one side. His fingers tighten around my neck as he slowly slides a finger down the front of my throat, and then farther across my collarbone.

"Where'd you get this scar?" he asks, his voice barely above a growl. "I'm going to release your mouth, so be very careful with your next move or I'll fuck it whether you put up a fight or not."

He lets go.

I clear my throat. "I don't know."

He pauses, and I wish I could see what he was doing. "What do you mean you don't know?"

"I mean, I don't know as in I don't really remember."

"It's a mighty big scar to not remember..." It's not that big, it's thin and short and slices just above my collar up to the side of my neck.

"I don't know. My pop always said I fell off a playground swing as a child and broke my collarbone so they had to do surgery."

"Really." I don't miss the disbelief in his tone. "That's interesting because surgical cuts are much cleaner than this."

"I don't remember. I just know what I was told."

He hits the small lamp that's on the floor and it takes a few seconds for my eyes to adjust to the warm soft light illuminating the room from it. Finally, when my vision focuses, I see him watching me carefully. His eyes looking through me. Or at me. Through me, I think. "He's a liar."

I flinch. It was as though he physically slapped me across the cheek. "Excuse me?"

Manik clenches his jaw a couple of times and then repeats. "Your pops lied, Cub, that's no surgical scar and the reason why you don't remember?" he adds, and he's just about to carry on with his sentence when his expression morphs into something else, his lips curling between his teeth as he smirks. "You're mad."

"Don't change the subject," I reply softly, wanting to know where he was taking this conversation. "Why don't I remember, Manik?"

His eyes search mine. His hips press into me, but it is more of a twitch. As if he didn't mean to. "All in good time."

"What does that mean?" My throat burns from the dust particles that have settled down my airways.

"It means, Beatrice, that you're going to do as you're told while you're here—if you want to live."

A shiver of hope naively rushes through me. "You're going to let me live?"

His fingers wrap around the backs of my thighs as he drags my body down the bed. "I am. In fact, I'm going to get Katiya to bring some shit down for you to wear. But there will be rules. Are you following me, Cub?" he asks, leaning forward and unclasping the cuffs from my wrists. I stretch them out and slowly crawl to the side of the bed once he's standing beside it. It's too late to change tracks when I realize that I'm kneeling on the mattress directly in front of him.

His fingers wrap around my chin, tilting my head up to face him. His shoulders are firm and straight, his stance every bit as intimidating as I feel intimidated.

"Rules?" I whisper, looking up at him. I'm entranced, having been lured into a cage that he holds

the key to.

He nods. “Rules of survival. You follow them, and I won’t hurt you. In fact, I’ll reward you. You break them, and I’ll punish you, and Beatrice, when I say I’ll punish you, I don’t mean in the fluffy way that can be used in the bedroom. It’s in a way that’ll have your blood spilling between my fingers while you’re gagging on my cock, you feel me?”

I gulp. “Ah—”

He wraps my hair around his fist tighter, yanking my head back. “Do. You. Feel. Me?”

“—Yes.” I answer, my eyes watering at the strands being pulled from the roots. He releases, then his fingers go in a circular motion over my scalp.

Just as I think he’s about to leave, my jeans get pulled down my legs. I bite down on my lower lip, fighting the fright.

When the cool air hits my bare thighs, Manik pulls out a black bandana that’s tucked into his back pocket, his other hand holding the cuffs. He leans forward and cuffs each hand to each side of the bed, his chest so close to my face that I can taste him.

My brain is in tug-a-war with my body, and it’s losing. Once they’re back on, I tug on them roughly, my eyes blazing onto his.

“Let me go.”

Instantly he whispers, “No.” Then he smirks, bringing the bandana to my eyes and tying it to the back of my head until all of the soft light I could see is shut out.

“Why?” I answer through a dry throat. My chest is swelling, my skin tingling with adrenaline.

“Because I like to kill and fuck.”

I clear my throat. “And what are you going to do with me right now?”

He chuckles, and I swear I feel the vibration against my flesh. “I don’t want to fuck you, Beatrice. Your blood is filthy, you’ll never bounce on my dick.”

My mouth slams closed, then open. “So why the hell am I half naked, cuffed, and blindfolded?”

“Nah, don’t get your hopes up, Cub. I kill people with that same blindfold.”

It goes silent, with nothing but the light thudding of footsteps crawling up the stairs.

I’ve lost track of the time or the date. I’ve lost touch with a small part of reality since being here. I wish I could say that I liked it. That Manik was so hot that it made this okay, but that would be a bunch of bull. Yeah, Manik is obviously very, very good-looking, but so was Ted Bundy and Vera Renczi. I will admit that the way my body is reacting to him lately doesn’t sit right with me. It’s like he holds all the answers but won’t share the questions. There’s a darkness inside of him that is hidden behind the secrets he preserves and the cries of his victims. It’s not a place I want to visit, but there’s an appeal to him. I’m drawn to his shadows so I can see who they reflect.

I’m stupid, in short.

I feel a little dirty, filthy really, and a lot unworthy. This feeling is new to me, since being here, but how can I subconsciously slip into such toxic thoughts so quickly? Had I opened old wounds, and that’s why these feelings have come on fast, or is this my survival mechanism?



CHAPTER SEVEN



“Hey Luv”—Mobb Deep

Beat

Something is prodding my cheek, and I flinch as the tickling sensation drags down my temple. I fly up into a sitting position, wide awake when I realize it's real and where I am. My clothes are worn and stained with old blood, my nose throbs and my stomach stings.

“Sorry,” a voice says. I see Katiya sitting on the edge of the bed. “It’s just you look real banged up. I’ve got some clothes for you, and some other stuff that you know, you might need.” Her beautiful polished skin and appearance clears my dry eyes with moisture of envy. I’ve never been envious of other people, or particularly other girls. I’ve always felt like women are a part of some lost sisterhood that got corrupted and manipulated by society and, to a degree, men. We’re just waiting to reconnect again and take over. But right now, I’m envious of Katiya, and I don’t think that really has anything to do with my current predicament either—which is even worse—because she’s just flat-out beautiful.

“Thanks,” I croak out, and then go to sit up, but the cuffs halt my movement. “Did he take the blindfold off me in my sleep?” I ask more to myself.

Katiya rolls her eyes with a soft chuckle. “Probably. He doesn’t leave that thing anywhere. Surprised he let you touch it.” She leans forward, and I hear the familiar clinking of metal as my eyes go over her long neck. Her skin is as flawless as her brothers and her dead straight hair tickles my forehead. My arms drop to the side of my head once she has unlocked my cuffs.

“There you go!” she announces, sitting back. I rub my wrists and inch up on the bed, unsure of how to take her. She seems nice, but most people do. It doesn’t matter how many times a snake sheds its skin, it’s still a snake.

She places the little overnight bag closer to my legs. “There are a few changes of clothes in there, we seem to be the same size, so they should all fit. There’s a toothbrush, some soap, shampoo, and tampons too! I don’t know, I just figured you might need them all.”

I don’t question why she did what she did.

“I told you my brother is...”

“Evil?” I laugh, but the word is far from funny.

She gestures to the gym bag, ignoring me. “Go take a shower, I’ll stay here.”

I look down at it and then back at her. “Are you watching me?”

“What? In there?” She points to the bathroom, raising her eyebrows. “I mean, I would. I’m not against it, but I think my brother has a thing for you. In *his* kind of way.”

“A thing...” I deadpan. “What’s a thing?”

She laughs, patting my leg and standing. “Beat, he literally calls you ‘Cub.’ He doesn’t do pet names, ever.”

I ignore her, grabbing the bag and getting to my feet. “Thanks for the clothes and the toothbrush.” Then I leave, almost tripping over my feet in my desperate rush to the shower.



CHAPTER EIGHT



“Breathin”—2Pac

Manik

“Ae, this is not right...” Katiya murmurs, pulling a bag of popcorn out of the pantry.

I raise my eyebrows at her. I love my sister, but she’s a fucking pain in my ass. “Kat, we have done far worse in our time and you know it...” I pause, running my tongue over my teeth. “Hold up.”

She stops what she’s doing, her hand hovering over the pot.

I lean forward, my elbows resting on the counter. “You’re fucking wet for her...”

“What?” she screeches, tossing the corn kernels into the pot. “That’s absur—”

I lean back in my chair, kicking my foot out. “Stay away from her, Katiya. Go find yourself a new toy. You don’t fucking want this one. Trust me.”

“Who said that I was using her as my toy, brother. She’s not—”

“—is...” I correct, getting off my chair and making my way to her because I know exactly what she’s going to say. “She *is* your type, but you don’t get this one. No one does.”

She pouts. “Fine!” Then turns away from me and pretends to be focused on the popcorn. “I’m going through a dick phase anyway!”

“Classy.” I roll my eyes and start heading out of the kitchen. I pause when I’m passing the basement door, deciding whether or not I should go down there again. I don’t know what my dad is playing at with her, but there’s something more that he’s not telling me. I thought it was coincidence that she witnessed that bullshit outside Jesta’s, but the more I piece shit together in my head, the

finished puzzle looks more like my dad orchestrated something.

I climb the stairs that lead up to my studio, passing all the old LPs I have glazed and hanging on the wall. Eminem circa 96 with his first LP. N.W.A and Eazy-E with the record Eazy-Duz-It, Dr. Dre's first album The Chronic, Biggie's album Ready to Die, and Tupac with 2Pacalypse Now. All artists that inspired me as a young buck growing up. Not a big fan of the new school shit, though some would say I would classify as new school since I was just a pup around their time, but the ones saying that are usually the ones who listen to shit like Machine Gun Kelly. Nothing against Kellz, he's got dope flow, but it is what it is. He's that new school generation shit.

Once I hit the top stair, I go straight for the mixer after flicking on the lights. I stand there for a few seconds, looking into the sound booth where I should be standing right now, busting out rhymes. I haven't had any spark in me for months.

Leaning on my fist against the table, I crank my head over my shoulder to look at all of my own records. I've hit Platinum, Gold, and Diamond, as well as Double Platinum. Next to the records are photos of me growing up, going out, getting fucked up, but all influencing me and making me who I am today. I started young, at seventeen I had my first LP out. It wasn't a slow pickup either. It all blew up, and I blew up fast. I waited for the decline from hitting the top, but it never came. Most artists fuck up every now and then, doing a few stints in rehab, but it never happened with me. Probably had a lot to do with my old man. Not that I don't dabble in drugs, because I do. I just know when to stop and when to not use. Drugs, yeah fuck it, snort that line, but never use it as a scapegoat to try and mask your problems. I have other ways to vent my issues.

Biting my lower lip, I throw my phone down onto the counter and pick up the pen and paper I had tossed in the drawer underneath.

Fuck it. I'll put my pen to paper. What's the worst that could happen?

Two hours later, my finger is tapping to a silent base that's thudding through my head as the lyrics wrap around each strum in a perfect synchrony.

"Shit." I run my fingers through my hair and look down at the notepad with a whole bunch of blue ink scribbled onto it.

"Yo!" Lenny saunters through the door, eating a burger. "I think Katiya is sulki—" His eyes drop to the notepad, and then come back to me. "Is that?" He snatches the pad with his free hand and takes a seat on the leather sofa opposite me. His eyes drift over each line, and when he finally looks up at me, it's with a full-toothed grin. Thank fuck there are no lettuce leaves showing.

"You got a beat to this?"

I smirk. "Yeah, and I got about three other songs floating around too."

"This album is happening?" Lenny asks, you can't hide the excitement on his smug face.

"I'm insulted by your lack of fucking faith in me."

"Faith and Aeron Romanov-Reed do not go hand in hand, my brother." He looks down at the paper and then drops his burger onto the little table, wiping his hands.

"What are you doing?" I ask, eyebrows raised.

He heads toward the turntables. "What do you think? We about to spin some beats."

"Not yet, I gotta go check on the one downstairs. Make sure she hasn't tried to escape again. Can't be replacing windows every couple days."

He turns slowly, his legs crossed at the ankles and his arms over his chest. "Really? You wanna go play with your little toy and then come back? No. Not happening. I'm putting my foot down. Something is obviously happening to have inspired you, so you gotta keep your ass right here so we

can at least get some rhymes out.”

My eyes narrow. “The fuck? You can do the rhymes. I’ll be back soon.”

“You scared your baby sister is going to steal her heart?”

I roll my eyes. “Katiya can have her fucking heart. I ain’t interested in that, or anything close to that bullshit, especially with Beatrice. You don’t know what you’re talkin’ about.”

Lenny chuckles, turning back around to hit switches.

“What’s funny, Chump?” Chump is Lenny’s nickname that only I’m allowed to use.

“Oh nothing, just that you’re full of shit.”

I wasn’t lying. I’ve never had a girlfriend. Ever. I don’t do the girlfriend thing, I do the get money thing. I’ve always been focused on my career that anything more than getting my dick wet was always out of the question. Girls pressed the issue in the beginning, sure. But after a while, I earned my reputation. I keep the ones around who don’t ask questions. Yeah, so they look a little fucking broken when I tell them to get the fuck out after, but they know the deal. So whatever Lenny is spewing, even he knows he’s full of shit.

Beatrice is—well, good looking. I mean, she’s not pretty or exotic. She has classical features, but it’s completely undeniable she is attractive. With her long, pure black, raven hair that hangs right to just above her peach shaped ass in natural waves and her slanted bright green eyes. She has a heart-shaped face that has you questioning her fucking age and innocence since she looks so damn young. She has a tiny little body but legs that go on for days, legs that I want to spread any time I’m even near her. She has soft swollen lips that have a natural pout and straight white teeth that most bitches in my industry would spend thousands to obtain. Don’t even get me started on that ass...

But I ain’t with it. She can be the perfect woman for me, and I still wouldn’t put my dick in her. Besides my personal issues with her, she’s not like the girls I fuck with. They all hold a shallow glint in their eye, one that is easily dismissible when all you want is a good lay. Beatrice doesn’t have that glint. Her eyes show something I’m unfamiliar with—I believe that something, is a soul. The thing about having a soul and offering it up on a silver platter for me, is I’ll shatter that platter after using it as a fucking frisbee.

“Shut up, Chump. I ain’t fucking lying.”



CHAPTER NINE



“Warrior Part 2”—Lloyd Banks

Beat

“So, you dance?” Katiya asks, eating the popcorn she brought down. My stomach growls, but I think I’m so far past hungry that I’ve lost the appeal of eating.

I nod. “Yeah, I started ballet when I was five years old in Sydney, and then jazz. When I moved to my grandparents’ house, I got into hip-hop too.”

She sucks the salt off her fingers, her eyes peering up at me. Is she flirting? No. Can’t be.

“What?” I ask, my cheeks flushing. Katiya is obviously beautiful, she’s the female version of her brother.

She shakes her head. “Nothing. So, did you go to college? I never went. I went as far as high school and that was it for me.”

“I did. Why didn’t you go?” I don’t want to be rude, but I doubt money had anything to do with why she didn’t go to college.

“It just wasn’t really in my cards.” She stands from the bed, her eyes going up and down my body. “It’s a shame really.”

“What is?” I ask, finishing the braid in my hair.

“The fact that my brother has already claimed you.”

“Claimed me?” I drag the sheet up the bed and bring it to my mouth. “I don’t want him to claim me. I don’t—” I pause, and it’s like everything that has happened in the past few days starts playing

vividly in high definition inside of my head. Realization sinks into my bones, frightening the daze I had unknowingly put myself in. It's a scary thing when you realize you've unwittingly adapted to a scenario that should really have you screaming. I have submitted to my fate without even realizing it. "I don't want that?"

She gives me a sad smile, one that doesn't touch her eyes. "Oh, I didn't say it was a good thing, actually, I'd be worried. One, my brother doesn't do this—ever, and two, there's something off about the way he is with you. Be careful with that."

She leaves a couple minutes later after securing me back to the bed. I never got to ask what she meant by her last statement, but I should be thankful for the shower, clothes and the toothbrush. Not all captives get treated this way, I'm sure. In the couple of days that I've been here, I've come to recognize his energy, the way his eyes seem like the entry gates to hell, the kind where no souls survive. He doesn't even capture them, he spits them out once he's done. Maybe if I play his games, he will let me go. The thought doesn't sit completely okay with me, but I've got to do something.

I hear the door open, a few footsteps plod down, and then it closes again with a slow clink. My eyes shoot around the room frantically, trying to figure out what to do. I'm not ready to have another one-on-one with him. I shut my eyes and count how many steps he takes.

Thud. One.

Thud. Two.

Thud. Three.

Thud. Four.

Eight steps. He takes eight steps before I hear the faint echo of him landing on the floor.

"Open your eyes." His voice is unlike any voice I have heard before. It's low, yet soft. Harsh, yet lazy. It is everything while being nothing. "Do as you're told."

I slowly open my eyes and they land on him instantly. He's topless, with his tanned flesh on display. He trains hard, I can tell. That is not a body that you get from just diet and good genes. That's a body you lift heavy iron for. Dark sweatpants hang off his slim waist, a perfectly dipped V dancing down his pelvis. There's a tattoo going over that area too though, in big Old English font. My eyes dart to his left rib cage where a paragraph is inked in cursive. He also has two full sleeves of tattoos—no color, just grey and white—and what looks to be a bird of some sort with blood dripping from it on his chest and the sharp word **Z V E T** just beside it.

Strange, but I love tattoos—which is why I have my own sleeve. I also have one small phoenix on my right lower back, because I wanted to rise from the ashes of my parents' deaths. I was raised being told that I was "classically beautiful"—girl next door, cute. Now, I think I confuse a hell of a lot of people when they see my tattoos.

I love it.

I realize I've been checking him out the whole time and my eyes snap back to his face.

"Not a good idea for you to be looking at me like that while you're cuffed to a bed and at my disposal, Cub." He stalks in closer, his steps slow and calculated.

I exhale. "I was admiring your ink."

His legs hit the end of the bed. "You really, really don't want to lie to me either."

I shut my mouth, not wanting to say anything just in case it works against me getting out of here.

Must stick to the plan.

I settle for eye contact.

His teeth catch his bottom lip and my eyes falter slightly.

He grins like he caught my fumble. He probably did. "Hungry?"

My eyes drop down his body.

“Beatrice!” he snaps, his voice showing more emotion in it since I’ve been here.

I swallow even though my saliva is on empty and it feels like I’ve got a ball of cotton lodged down my throat and in my mouth. “Yes.”

“If I take you up there to feed you and you try any shady shit, I know the exact places where I can cut you and not kill you. So, I’ll ask you, are you going to behave if I take your ass upstairs?”

“Yes.” I nod my head, trying not to show my eagerness. I must be somehow gaining his trust if he’s willing to take me upstairs into a civilized environment.

He slowly inches down over my body and I can feel the heat radiating off his flesh and hitting my cheeks. He puts one knee between my legs, and his hand to one handcuff, then he pauses, his body hovering over mine and his face so close to my head that if I look up, we’d be inches away from each other. His fingers slowly wrap around my wrists and stay there. “Look up at me.”

That voice.

I slowly lift my head until his eyes collide with mine and I can feel his breath falling over my lips. Don’t look at his lips, that’s an invitation. I keep my eyes on his instead.

“Maybe in another life, I would have had you exactly like this. Tied up, spread out, and completely at my fucking mercy. I’d hit places you didn’t know existed and I’d hit them so hard you’d still feel me penetrating your pussy for weeks on end,” he pauses, cocks a brow and grins. “But in this lifetime, I’d not let you so much as breathe on my dick, sweetheart, so stop looking at me like I’m a snack, because I’m a fucking six-course meal and if you try to take a taste, I’ll be sure you choke on your bite.”

Jesus.

I try to ignore everything he said while trying not to wane from his brutality. “Can you, ah, untie me?” I use my soft demure voice to coax him, my poker face better be helping me out right now.

He chuckles heavy enough for me to feel the vibration in my chest. “That’s the kind of tone you use on puppies, Cub, not a fucking Rottweiler hungry for meat.” He unlocks both handcuffs and then latches them to the back of me and moves off the bed, taking his warmth with him. “Speaking of, hope you like meat.”

So, I guess that didn’t work.

Manik

Two things I have always been sure about.

One, my dad wasn’t as bad as the media makes him out to be—he was worse.

And two, don’t let a girl with pretty eyes fuck you.

I’m a smart man. I had to be with who my dad was, so I’ve never broken the second thing. Girls with pretty eyes are lethal, and Beatrice had that shit on lock. If there wasn’t something inside of me that roared higher and hotter than her little advances, I’d have already fucked her black and blue.

“Are you going to take the cuffs off me?”

I shake my head, watching as she sits down on one of the bar stools. “No.”

She licks her lips in answer.

I start pulling a bunch of shit from the fridge. Lenny practically lives here too, and I’m a food guy, so the fridge and cupboards are always filled up. I pull out one of the premade chicken sandwiches

and a bottle of water. Tearing open the package with my teeth, I kick the seat out beside her and sit down, placing the bottle on the counter.

“Aeron, take the cuffs off me.”

My cock stands to life when she says my real name. Now she has my dick’s attention, this just got a little bit harder. Fuck.

I shake my head, grabbing onto the edges of her stool and lifting it to turn her around, facing me front on. She sucks in a breath, her eyes shooting straight to mine.

Conceal.

There’s a long silent pause. Quiet enough that I’m pretty sure I could hear her heart pounding in her chest.

I take the sandwich and press it up to her lips, needing to hurry this along so she can get back downstairs. “Eat.”

Her eyes widen slightly, and just when I think she’s going to fight me, she opens her mouth and bites down on the bread. I watch as her lips fold over the slice and end up shuffling in my seat to try and calm my cock. This was a shit idea.

She chews slowly before taking more bites. I put the water bottle up to her lips and she wraps them around it while peering at me.

Fuck it.

I yank the bottle away from her, putting it onto the table and splashing her chin in the process. Grabbing her from under her arms, I pick her up as she screams slightly. I slam her down onto the counter and push her until she’s on her back.

“Aeron, what are you doing?” Her chest rises and falls, her perfect tits right in front of me. I climb onto the counter and slowly crawl up her body, spreading her legs out with my knees. “I’m wearing your sister’s clothes!” she blurts in a sad attempt to distract me from what I want.

I tilt my head and lick my lip. “You’re right.” She relaxes slightly, but I grab onto the front of the button-down shirt she’s wearing and tear it off. “So, it’s a good thing clothes come off.”

She gasps. Silence stretches out with nothing but the echoing of small buttons falling to the marble floor.

I look down at her, resting my dick into her crotch. Her eyes search mine and I watch as drops of water trickle down her chin. “Tell me you don’t want this.”

“Will you stop if I say no?” she asks after a couple of seconds.

I lean down while thrusting my hips into her and slowly lick the drop of water from her chin. She freezes, and I continue dragging my tongue up until it’s on the corner of her lip. Her mouth opens slightly, her breathing now audible.

“Probably not.” Then I bite down on her lip, tugging at it softly, but not giving her enough to call it a kiss. I’m testing the waters. I’m not a fucking rapist, if she really said to stop and really wanted me to—I would, but right now, she’s not said anything, let alone given me any signal that she ain’t feeling it.

I let her lip go and her back arches off the counter. Her eyes take in my body again, this time hungrily, fucking raging for me.

I chuckle, shaking my head. “You want this, and you know it.” Bringing my arms up to her head, I hold myself up by my fists. This way I can get a clearer look at her too. Fuck, Lenny ain’t lying. She’s fucking breathtaking. That kind of beauty should never exist, especially not in my world because I ruin girls like her. I take everything I want from their pretty little existence and leave them with whatever remnants they have left of their soul once I’m done. I won’t be leaving anything behind of this girl,

though. I want it fucking all. Not just her pleasure, but her life, too. She's going to pay, she will pay, but only after I've taken her for everything that she has. Yes. I smirk, grinding myself into her. I won't just stop there, I'll fucking break her soul, rip out her heart, and make her wish she never met a cunt like me.

She continues to look up at me with her sharp green eyes, her dark lashes fanning out over her makeup-free face. I drag one hand down the front of her throat and then over her tit, squeezing slightly. Her eyes close, and yeah, it's game on. I continue to move my hand around to her back and yank her into me harder while unlatching her bra. I jerk it off her, fucking annoyed at the cuffs that I can't take all the shit off, but then she grinds into me and I lose it for a second. Dropping my mouth to her nipple, I suck it into my mouth and flick it with my tongue. She moans slightly, and I come up to her face, searching her eyes to find her watching my lips. I know what she wants. She's a fucking girl, they need to feel wanted during sex. Part of feeling wanted is kissing—but that ain't happening. I don't kiss girls. Ever. I mean, I have when I was a kid and shit, but since I was around twelve, I stopped.

"You want this?" I ask again, because I'm a fucking gentleman.

This time instead of ignoring me or fighting it—she nods her head, a deep blush coloring her cheeks.

I drop my mouth to her sternum and work my way down until I reach the waistband of her jeans. Flicking the button, I walk my way backward until I drop down off the counter and she's spread out in front of me.

"People tell you you're beautiful, Cub?" I ask, tilting my head and rubbing the bulge in my pants.

Her eyes drop to what I'm doing, and then fly back to mine, heated. "Sometimes."

"Do they tell you you're beautiful before they put their dick in you?" I slide my sweats down lower, taking my Calvins down with them. My cock drops out onto the palm of my hand. Thick, hot and ready. I pump it a few times until a bead of cum shines on the tip.

She's now glued to my cock, her teeth catching her bottom lip. "Once or twice."

"You like being told you're pretty? You like being told nice things while being fucked, princess?"

Her eyes snap to mine. "I like to think so..."

I pump a few more times, my head tilting back as my eyes roll to the back of my head and my abs tense. Then my eyes snap back to hers and I push my dick back into my pants, a snarl on my lips. "That's one of the reasons why you'll never taste, or ride on my dick." She goes to sit up, but I leap forward, pushing her chest so she slams back onto the counter. Her head smashes against it with a thud and she groans.

I stand there for a few seconds, one hand on her chest to hold her down and the other on her thigh. Then slowly, I move it up, closer to her pussy. I trace my index finger over the soft part where her apex meets her upper thigh and goosebumps break out over her flesh.

"I thought—I—th—" The bitch is panting.

"Thought what?" I tilt my head.

"That you just said we weren't..."

"Oh," I murmur, sliding my hand over to cup her pussy. "We're not." I push a finger inside of her, ignoring how good her pussy tightens around my finger like a clamp. I extract it and her wet walls pull at my finger again in a deep suction.

She moans, her thighs trying to meet my movements.

"Be still," I growl, biting my inner cheek. Fucking focus.

She stills for a few seconds, but when I slowly pick up the pace again, she thrashes around. I take my bandana out of my pocket again and come up, taking my other finger out of her. Her eyes connect

with mine for a second and my jaw clenches.

“The fuck you looking at, Cub?”

She shakes her head. “Nothing.”

“That’s exactly right. Nothing.” Then I tie the bandana around her eyes again and step back, taking her in. Completely naked, cuffed to the back, her palm sized tits jiggling with her movements and her sharp hipbones standing high. She’s like a fucking feast, captured and ready.

My eyes narrow, and I slowly step backward. “Be back in a second.”

When I come back in, she’s exactly where I left her, her lips parted as she takes in deep breaths. I step closer, flicking the dagger around in my hand.

“Aeron?” she calls out, but I don’t answer.

I bring the blade up to her inner thigh, just above her knee and drag it up. She sucks in a breath.

“Move even an inch, and this blade will go through your flesh like a hot knife through butter. I’d recommend against it if that’s not what you’re into.”

Her mouth slams shut and her legs still. I continue up, grinning at the sight of this very dagger beside her skin. Unsurprisingly, she quivers every few seconds at the feeling of the cool metal. When it can’t go any higher, I spread her legs wide and bring my mouth to her folds. Drawing my tongue out, I lick her once, and then twice, making sure I connect with every single inch of the center of her pussy. Then I bring the blade to one side and open her up, her clit is throbbing, wanting in on the fucking show.

“Aeron,” she moans my name like she’s been reciting it in her dreams.

Maybe she has, but they’d be in her nightmares...

Spreading her open more, I lick around her clit, flicking it a few times until her moans become incoherent. I suck on her as my other hand comes up and squeezes her nipple. Her back arches with that small amount of pain, so I squeeze it harder, using my short nails and she groans so loud her pussy vibrates around my mouth. I lick my lips and then dive my tongue into her, licking her walls like a damn ice cream cone while pressing the cool blade of the dagger up against her clit. She starts riding my face and the blade, and my cock throbs in my pants. Fuck. Releasing her from my lips, I flip the dagger around so the bone handle is upward and the blade is in my hand, then I push it inside of her pussy and she screams out again.

“Want me to whisper sweet nothings into your ear, Cub?” I slowly sink the blade handle into her, and then bring my tongue back to her clit. Her taste is fucking addictive, but I’m no addict.

She doesn’t answer.

I slap her tit so hard her back flies up from the counter. “Answer me, Cub. Want me to tell you how much my cock wants to be inside of you, fucking you until you can’t fucking see straight?” Her pants become faster and her wetness is dripping down the blade, but I know she hasn’t orgasmed yet. “You gonna show me how this sweet little cunt is going to squirt?” My other hand goes back to her tit and I squeeze it again, dropping my mouth to her clit and sucking on it. I push the dagger in again and again, driving it into her. I find my hips copying the motion with every thrust, and her waist comes up to meet the dagger.

I lean over and suck her nipple into my mouth, catching it with my teeth, and it’s the exact moment she explodes from beneath me with a scream so loud it’s probably woken Lenny.

I tilt my head back, gazing between her thighs as her cum drips down onto the kitchen counter off the base of the blade.

Smirking, I lift it up and bring it to her mouth. “Suck.”

Her body is still jolting from the aftershocks, but her swollen lips open and wrap around it and

she sucks herself off.
Ah, how ironic...



CHAPTER TEN



“X”—2Chains

Beat

We reach the bottom of the stairs again after whatever just happened upstairs, and Aeron turns me around, so my back is pressing against his chest—which is still bare. He does something to the cuffs behind my back and then suddenly the tight clamps are free—thank god, because it was feeling uncomfortable.

I bring my hands to the front, turning around to face him again while stretching my wrists out.

“Sleep.”

My eyebrows pull together. “What? Is that all?”

He chuckles. “What the fuck you want from me, Beat? A fucking declaration of love just because I had my mouth on your pussy? Get the fuck downstairs.”

I didn’t expect anything, but it felt like I had no impact on him. He blew my mind with oral sex, and I barely touched him. Literally.

He wouldn’t even let me reciprocate, or even have sex. *He didn’t have sex with me.* I don’t know whether I should be honored or insulted. I choose neither and decide to ignore the elephant in the room.

He opens his mouth, but shakes his head and retreats backward. “Go to bed, Beatrice.”

I stay put, watching him leave and shut the door behind himself.

Hopefully, I can go home soon.

Manik

Shutting the basement door, I pull my phone out of my front pocket, hitting dial on my dad's number.

It rings twice before he answers. "Syn, everything okay, boy?"

Time to test the waters and kick it up a notch.

"Yeah, everything is fine. Listen, you know I love playing these tricks when needed, but I ain't with it with this chick. She won't breathe a word about what she saw—I'll put my own ass on it."

Silence.

"Dad?"

"She's a liability, Syn. You may be comfortable offering your ass up as her protection—but I'm not. Wait until I see you. Don't do anything stupid."

"Is that Daddy?" Katiya says from behind me and I quickly spin around, nodding.

"I don't think I'm putting my ass on the line because I don't think she's a liability."

More silence.

"Syn..."

"Yeah?"

"Has something happened?"

"What?" I recoil. "No, no."

Fuck, I probably answered too fast.

"You answered too fast. Listen to my next words very carefully, Syn. You are not to go near that girl again. *Lisus*."

Before I can ask why the sudden urgency for me not to go near her, and ignoring Katiya glaring at me, Dad continues. He exhales. "Let her go."

"What?" I snap, shocked that he agreed. What the fuck is he playing at... I feel like I'm in the middle of *The Matrix*.

"The risk is too great with her there if you're feeling something for her, but, Syn, have eyes on her—or I will, you understand what I'm saying? I want you to watch her closely with every step and wait for my next command. She may be out of that house, but she's not out of our possession."

This is next level. I thought I had this, but like always, he does something fucked and gives me an order that's way out of left field.

Distraction.

"I've just started working on this album. I need to be focused and not run bitch on a bitch."

"Syn, this is an order."

"Why do I get the feeling this is deeper than what it is?" *Give it up.*

He hangs up.

I flip off my phone, just as Katiya leans forward and snatches something from my back pocket.

She grins, shaking her head and twirling Beat's panties around her finger. "These are new, so don't worry, they're not mine."

I roll my eyes. "Fuck off, Katiya. I'm not in the mood." I push off the wall and make my way down the long hallway, toward my bedroom door.

"Ae?"

I pull the door open, looking at her over my shoulder. "What?"

“Are you guys letting her go?”

“Yes.”

For now.

Beat

I haven't seen Aeron for two days, but the night after our...whatever you call it... I got more sleep than I have the whole time I've been here. I could give credit to the orgasm, but I'm not sure whether that would be true.

I miss dancing. I miss the old studio I found when I got to New Orleans. I miss the dusted mirrors and the old boom speaker that would play any song and I'd just roll with it. I miss Kyle and his obsession with fried ice cream—and the shitty way he makes a grilled cheese. I miss my crappy and severely underpaid job, and I miss the simplicity of life, like inhaling the fresh early-morning air when I'd take a run because it's that glorious moment right before the world wakes up and pollutes the oxygen with their anxiety and problems.

He said that he'd let me go, but he had also threatened my life, his sister had also blatantly said something similar, so why the shift. Maybe it was just all in my head.

The door opens and footsteps start down until I see Aeron land on the bottom step wearing light jeans that have tears and holes in various places as well as something scribbled with a black felt-tip pen on the side, it takes me a couple seconds to realize that scribble says Calvin Klein, because of course they do. He's also wearing a dark blue hoodie.

“Hi,” I whisper hoarsely and then clear my throat.

He strides closer to me, his hands pressing into his pockets. His head tilts and I try to force my attention away from him because the intensity of being in the mere proximity of Aeron is too much, let alone being pinned down by him with his glare. “I'm going to say these next words, and you're going to understand them and not cause me any fucking issues.”

I agree with a nod.

He continues. “I'm going to take you home. I'm going to have eyes on you until I am certain you won't rat. I'm going to be watching you very fucking closely, Beatrice, so you even so much as breathe in any direction that I don't like, and I'm hauling your ass back here and tying you back up to that bed—understood?”

My knees are shaking and inside my head has erupted with one hundred thousand fireworks labeled with the words ‘relief,’ but I nod my head, trying to keep my cool. “Understood. Completely.”

He steps forward and smirks. “I might even leave Katiya with you.”

I shrug. “That's fine.” I actually like Katiya so this wouldn't be a huge discomfort for me.

He nudges his head toward the stairs. “Go.”

My feet are moving, but my heart is pounding at one hundred miles an hour.

I'm leaving.

I'm going home to see Kyle, back to my shitty job—if I still have one—and back to my life. Well, sort of. With the addition of having Aeron burned in the back of my head. I start walking up the steps slowly but pause when I feel like he's not following.

Turning around, I cross my arms in front of myself when I catch him staring pointedly at my ass. “Aeron...” I warn.

His eyes snap up to mine. Even in the few minutes that he has been here, I can feel the different shift in him. It's not an obvious one, but at least he's not looking at me like I'm Hitler all of the time. It's now moved to just most of the time.

"What?" I ask when he doesn't say anything.

His jaw clenches a few times, and then his eyes slant. Looking into his eyes is like looking into the center of a storm, one that will suck you in and spit you out. "I didn't say anything."

"You didn't have to," I murmur, turning back to walk up the stairs.

"Beatrice!" he orders, and my feet stop instantly from his tone.

I turn to face him, and this time he doesn't seem to be battling with anything. It's as though he has made his decision. "Run, and I'll catch you. I may enjoy the feast, but I fucking love the hunt more."

I turn back around and carry on until he passes me at the top of the stairs.

He continues to lead me through the house, bypassing all of the doors that lead off. We go into the main foyer where twin stairs elegantly lead up to what I'm guessing is more bedrooms. A chandelier teases its position over me with little black diamonds that are pointing toward the glossy deep purple and cream marble floors. The walls are all black with random artwork scattered throughout. While heading to the front door, my eyes catch the art, and there's an interesting mix of them. Some are portraits of Tupac and Biggie, and some I recognize as the rebellious art of Banksy.

"Getting a good look?" Aeron asks, opening the heavy wooden front door.

I smile, passing him through the entrance. "I was admiring your artwork."

"Biggie and Tupac?"

I shake my head. "No, Banksy."

He shuts the door and my eyes burn from the sudden sunlight. I feel like I haven't seen the sun in decades, but that's short-lived when I see the matte black Lamborghini parked at the front. Black wheels, black windows—it's everything that I would expect someone like Manik to drive.

He unlocks it and I slip inside, feeling every bit out of place sitting on the Italian leather seats that are way more comfortable than what they look.

Manik gets into the driver's seat and roars the car to life.

I reach aimlessly for the seatbelt and clip it in. "Um, I'll show you where I live."

He chuckles, and I shoot back in my seat as he floors it out of the U-shaped entry to his mansion. "It's cute that you think I don't know where you live, Cub."

I turn slightly out toward the window to watch his house disappear. It's the first time I get a look at it, and my mouth almost drops to the ground. It's a four-pillar home, looking completely traditional, but instead of it being painted in white, it's pure black.

As we pull down my street on the other side of New Orleans, Aeron breaks the silence. "You're going to tell your roommate that you were with me."

"Okay," I answer, my heart thundering in my chest. I'm almost home. Almost home.

So why is there a slight nudge in my chest that has me trying to grasp at thin air. An empty pit of longing has started to throb deep inside of my stomach.

He pulls up to the front of my little loft style apartment. "You're going to tell him that we had a fling."

I look directly at Aeron now. "Well, I guess that wouldn't be completely unbelievable, oh yeah, except that I lost my phone..."

He reaches forward and unlocks the glove compartment, pulling out a brand-new iPhone. He hands it to me. "Here. I've already had your old number transferred over to this sim card. Katiya will

be here later tonight, and Beatrice?” he says, just as I grab the door handle to exit and run to my front door. “Look at me.”

I exhale, turning to face him again.

He searches my face. “Don’t let my sister fuck you.”

“What?” I laugh. “Aeron, I’m not bi-sexual. I’m completely straight, and anyway, even if I was, what would it really be to you?”

He grins, leaning backward onto the door and slightly turning to face me. He runs his index finger over his upper lip teasingly. I feel like I’m a puppet for his amusement. “New rule.”

“Nope, you said that there were only two rules.” I throw up deuces. “You can’t go adding on extra ones when you feel like it.” I’m obviously getting bold with my home in the background, like a safety net that will catch me if I fall.

His eyebrows raise in challenge. “What I say goes, Cub, actually, I’m going to expand on this rule. Don’t let anyone fuck you—period. You wanna get fucked? You call me. No one else.”

I freeze all movement. If I didn’t know any better, I’d say he was trying to... no. Can’t be. “Manik —”

“—And call me Aeron, my cock prefers it.”

I squeeze the door handle in an attempt to calm down. I’m going to need a long dance session after this week. “How is that rule relevant to me snitching?”

He chuckles, reaching forward until his hand clamps over mine on the door handle. He flicks it and the door raises. “Nothing has anything to do with you snitching.”

I climb out of the car as the door closes again, and before I can say anything else, he speeds off and I’m left standing there, wondering how the hell all of the last week happened, and what the shit did he mean by that last sentence of nothing being anything to do with me snitching.

I’m about to bounce toward the door, deciding to leave it all alone for now when it swings open and Kyle is standing there wearing loose basketball shorts, no shirt, and about a week’s worth of beard on his face. He scans me up and down and then runs down the steps and yanks me into a hug.

“Kyle?”

“Where the fuck have you been, Beat? I called the police and reported you as a missing person and everything!”

He’s still squeezing me, and the smell doesn’t go unnoticed. “You smell. I’m fine.”

“You’re not fine!” He pulls back, his hands squeezing my arms as he scans my face. “You have a swollen nose and a cut on your hand.”

“And one on my gut, listen, I’m okay. I had an... interesting week.”

I walk up the stairs, climbing them two at a time while needing some space to think of what I’m telling Kyle. I need to be believable or he will call me on my bullshit.

After he follows me inside, he kicks the door closed and I inhale softly, relishing in the smell of being home. Safe. At least for now.

“So? So, fill me the fuck in!” Kyle yells, his hands going up over his head. He looks like he hasn’t slept in a week and, also, the smell issue is a real thing. Has he showered?

“I’m sorry, Kyle, I—” God I’m about to look like such a piece of shit right now. “—I was with Manik...”

His body stills, his mouth opening and closing. “What?” Then he looks me up and down again and narrows his eyes. “Where are your clothes?”

“Oh, um, I didn’t have any and I didn’t want to come home to grab some, so his sister let me borrow hers.”

He raises his eyebrows again. “His sister, as in the little socialite that runs boss-bitch everywhere and anywhere she can?”

“Katiya, yeah, though I don’t know if she runs boss-bitch everywhere. Also, she’s coming to stay with us tonight and will be here for a little bit. I’m so sorry that—”

“—Nope. No! Fuck off. I just got you back, I’m not sharing you with anyone.”

I step forward, my hand coming to his cheek as I run my palm over his beard. “I’m okay, Kyle. I’m so sorry for everything. I lost my phone and I don’t know your number by heart—” I flash my new phone. “So, I didn’t have the means to text you.”

“How’d you afford that? You finally dip into the trust?”

“No. Aeron got it for me because it was his fault I lost it in the first place.”

Leaning up on my tippy toes when I can see he’s going to continue with his interrogation, I try for distraction and wrap my arms around his neck before placing a chaste kiss on his cheek. “I’m sorry, Kyle, but I’m okay—I promise.”

He searches my eyes, and I see the moment his shoulders slump. “Ok, but don’t ever pull that shit again, Beat, I’m fucking serious.” I let him go, itching to go to my room.

“I won’t. I promise.”

He relaxes and runs his hand over his face. “Better shave this and call the po-po. This whole thing has been a cock-block for me.”

I laugh, for the first time in a week my chest warms with love. “Sorry for that too.”

He rolls his eyes and walks past me, going straight for the bathroom which is downstairs. Our living areas are all downstairs, but our two small bedrooms are upstairs. It actually used to be one large bedroom, but a couple years ago Kyle built a wall to cut it in half. So yup, you guessed it, I’ve seen and heard a lot of Kyle’s... long nights. He’s calmed down a lot lately, and usually goes back to their place but there is still the occasional night that he will bring one home. Or two. There’d been three once too. And from downstairs, you can see everything that happens up there, you just can’t see it from the inside of our bedrooms, and you can only get to my bedroom through his bedroom. It’s probably why Kyle and I are so undeniably close, and probably why I’ve already decided that I won’t be leaving New Orleans any time soon. I would say never, but the commitment attached to the words “never” and “ever” give me hives.

He opens the bathroom door again, popping his head out until steam drifts out from behind him. I giggle.

“Also,” he adds, narrowing his eyes at me. “She’s sleeping in your room.”

I roll my eyes. “Fine!” He shuts the door, but then it opens again, and his head comes back out.

“Question...”

“Nope!” I ignore him, stomping up the stairs toward my room, leaving his laughter crackling behind me.

I sink onto my bed and exhale. I can’t believe I’m home. Back in my room.

I look around and see everything is completely untouched. My drawers are still cracked open a little, the evidence of me being in a rush to work that afternoon. My bed is still unmade and everything in this room smells like me, but I don’t smell like me.

I smell like rich Italian leather, rose petal soap, and a hint of Aeron’s cologne. It smells impeccable. So unique and different.

That throbbing in my stomach begins again and I roll off the bed, making my way to my dresser to take some clothes out.

“Aw, boo, that’s the look of sadness in those eyes,” Kyle says from behind me. I look over my

shoulder slightly and see him leaning on the door frame, a towel wrapped around his waist and water dripping down his body. “I’m jealous.”

I snort, pulling out panties—because I have none on—and some yoga pants with a loose white t-shirt. I will never leave my yoga pants again.

“That was an awfully short shower, Norris, why the rush?” I quirk my eyebrow, shutting the drawer with my hip. My nickname for Kyle is Norris, as in Chuck Norris, because the first time I met him, he told me he was Chuck Norris’ nephew. What’s more stupid is I believed him.

His smile falls. “Was worried.”

My heart clenches when I realize I might be a trigger for him now. I step forward until I’m directly in front of him. “I promise I’m okay and I’m not going anywhere.”

He sniffs, and then leans down into the crook of my neck and inhales deeply. “Manik wears Dior, huh? I would have thought he’d wear something else a little more expensive, but I get it. Sauvage is a good smell.”

I ignore the comment about his cologne, tucking it away in my brain for a totally innocent reason.

“I’m fine and I’m not going anywhere, Kyle, I promise.” Then I walk past him carrying my stuff and heading down to the bathroom. I close the door, sagging against it.

I’m pleased I’m home. I am. No one is trying to kill me, or keeping me prisoner in their basement, and I can wear yoga pants. I don’t have to be afraid when I hear footsteps pounding down the stairs and then wonder if I’m going to die or get manhandled by Manik.

This is a good thing.

So why does my stomach ache.



CHAPTER ELEVEN



“Eastside”—Halsey

Manik

I rip off the headphones and hang them on the mic, walking through the booth and back into the studio. I sag onto the couch, scrubbing my face.

“You ok, dawg?” Lenny asks, but my head is leaning against the top of the sofa and my legs are spread out.

“Why wouldn’t I be? We’re six songs deep into an album—finally, and it looks like we can pull it together faster than we have ever pulled together an album.”

“And it’s going to be your best album, Ae, but what’s got you all fucked up?”

I lean my head so I can see him out of the corner of my eye. “Nothing has me fucked up.”

“Oh yeah?”

Here we go.

“Lenny?” I muttered, leaning forward to rest my elbows on my knees. “Shut up.”

He throws his hands up. “Listen, I’m just sayin’, maybe you ought to go see her or some shit. Figure that shit out?”

“Lemme ask you something...”

He folds his arms in front of himself and leans against the table the mixer is on. “Sure.”

“When have I ever given a fuck?”

He laughs, his head going back. “Bro, there’s always one girl. Even serial killers have that one

girl.”

“Yeah,” I say, kicking my foot up onto the coffee table. “And they’re usually their first victim.”

Lenny sobered. I think he likes her. Actually, scratch that, I know he likes Beat.

I get up from the couch and stretch my arms up. “Katiya has her on tap.”

Lenny chuckles, switching off the table. “She’s gonna be Mrs. Steal Your Girl. Call her Mrs. Trey Songz.”

“She’s been there done that already.” I roll my eyes and head for the door, flicking the lights off. Katiya had a whole month fling with Trey. “And Beat isn’t my girl.” I shiver.

Lenny laughs, shaking his head. “You need to do something about that—that’s all I’m saying.”

Once we’re in my bedroom, I push him out the door and then fall backward onto my bed.

Fuck.

My phone starts ringing in my back pocket and I answer quickly when I see it’s Dad.

“Hey!”

“Syn, I need a job.”

I freeze, squeezing my eyes closed. “Dad, I’m busy with this album. You said you’d go easy with it this year.”

“You going soft on me, son?”

Son, not Syn.

“No,” I answer, exhaling and getting to my feet. “I don’t have any of my gear here so I’ll be down in an hour.”

“Good, Syn, that’s real good. See you soon.”

I throw my phone across the room. This will probably be good. Work off some pent-up shit that I have inside of me on something else.

The drive isn’t long—into the deeper parts of New Orleans. It’s where the Romanov Bratva all reside for family meetings. It’s a house surrounded by high, wired, private fences. There are guards who circle the grounds constantly and a pack of Rottweilers too. The Rotties are owned by my dad and the Bratva.

The wired fence opens when I roll up and I turn the music down on the radio, my headlights flashing on the old Victorian styled mansion aka—Dad’s house—aka my home. This is the holy grail of the Russian mafia and no one sets foot near this soil unless you’re supposed to set foot on this soil—you’ll be shot on the spot otherwise, and before you ask where the bodies are buried, we protect and run a private cemetery and cremation center as private partners. In other words, you’ll disappear in a cloud of burnt up ash.

I pull the car around the high concrete fountain that’s squirting water out of the middle and jump out, just as one of the soldiers, Jesse, nods his head at me.

Fucker.

I don’t mind the soldiers, but this particular one doesn’t sit right with me. They all drop to their knees when I arrive, which is where they belong, but Jesse has something else about him that I don’t like. Can’t quite put my finger on it.

I walk into the open foyer and go straight to my dad’s office which is the first door off the hallway. As soon as you walk in, you get a direct view of the front of the house, thanks to the tinted glass that serves as a wall. They’re reflective, so you can see out, but people outside can’t see in.

I shut the door behind me, my attention on Dad who is sitting in his leather chair, smoking a cigar.

“Syn, take a seat.”

I do, going straight to the chair I usually choose when I come here.

“Do you have the file?” I ask, reaching into my pocket to pull out my cigarettes.

He leans back a little more, blowing out a cloud of grey smoke, then slowly reaches for a pale folder and tosses it to me.

“This one—make it quick and easy. Because the next one I have for you is going to take some time to prepare for.”

“Another one?” My eyes shoot up to meet his as I flip through the papers inside the folder.

Dad nods, rolling the cigar around in his mouth a few times. “Yes, Syn, I know you need to concentrate on your career, but don’t forget the deal you made with me in order for you to gain that career...”

My jaw clenches. “I got my career because I worked for it...”

His eyes narrow and I physically feel the temperature in the room kick up a notch. It always got like this when this subject was raised—not that it was a reoccurring subject in our household. “Maybe, but I allowed it. Remember you’re a Vor, Syn. You can’t get out now, you’re just lucky that we give you a long leash.”

After hitting the end of the folder, I toss it back onto his desk and lean my elbow onto the armrest, my finger drifting over my upper lip. “Fine.”

Dad’s eyes crinkle around the edges as he grins, thinking he won this round. Which he had in a way, because he is right. I can’t walk out. No one walks away from the Bratva and lives. I pull a smoke out of my packet and put it in my mouth.

“Don’t forget your bandana.”

I blow out my smoke, relaxing on the exhale. “I won’t.” I never do.

“How’s the girl?”

I pause slightly. He threw me off with that question. “Fine. Katiya is staying with her.”

“Really?” Dad asks, obviously surprised by my sister’s taking to a new girl. “She hates everyone.”

I agree. “Yeah, well she doesn’t hate this one.”

Dad pauses, watching me carefully. “And you?”

I blow out another cloud of smoke. I might need something stronger. “What about me?”

“Do you hate this one?”

I flick the smoke around with my fingers and lick my bottom lip. “My feelings, or lack thereof, ain’t got shit to do with that girl.” I bait him, and our eyes stay locked for a while, the burnt smog from my smoke floating into the air.

Dad stares at me, his focus differing from what he usually looks like. Dad is focused, determined, and always aware of everything going on around him. It’s intimidating and damn near genius, so to see the unfocused look in his eye is a little alarming, thus, he took my bait enough for me to see the slight, and very brief, shift.

“Interesting,” Dad mutters, leaning forward to flick the ash off his cigar. “Well, remember what I said. You can’t go near her again.” We’re back to that.

“Not that I would, but why?”

He grins at me. “Because it’s not good business.”

What?

“That makes no sense.”

“Oh,” he chuckles. “It will soon.”

I've always hated when he gets cryptic with me, but it's Dad's MO. I narrow my eyes on him, tossing my ankle up over my knee. I hate that he can't trust me either, and his lack of faith in me is getting a little irritating. "This doesn't have anything to do with her witnessing that murder, does it?" I damn well know it doesn't.

He seems to think over what he's going to say next, and then a slow smirk crosses his mouth. "No."

And there it is.

"Are you going to elaborate?" I further ask, tilting my head.

He keeps the same grin. "Not yet. All in good time, Syn." He sucks on his cigar, blowing out the smoke. "All in good time."

Popping open the trunk of the stolen Range Rover, I zip open my satchel and take out the black bandana that I use to disguise my face, tying it around my neck and tucking it into my suit jacket to hide it. The bandana is something that started when I was a kid. Before my first kill, Dad gave it to me and I've been using it ever since. It's faded as fuck from all of the chaos it has seen, but I hardly go anywhere without it. The leather gloves that are on my hands stick to my palms as I take out my small bag, swinging it over my shoulder. Closing the trunk, I make my way toward the stairwell, pulling my black bandana up to cover just over my nose. I could take the elevators, but there are operating camera's in there, and none in the stairwell—I know this because we've run all the checks needed. I take the steps two at a time, clutching my bag in my hand. Once I've reached the top, I pop open the door and check the hallway, ignoring the soft melody music that's playing. Shutting the door behind me, I check the doors.

113

115

117

I stop, crack my neck, and then swipe the card down to unlock it. It clicks unlocked and I slowly push it open, shutting it behind myself. A quick glance down at my watch shows it's just after midnight, perfect time for murder.

Darkness shades my vision, but the moonbeam from the large window at the end of the room gives me enough light to make out someone sleeping in the bed. I walk closer, my footsteps calculated, my mind racing a hundred miles an hour. The bedding moves up and down in slow movements, indicating the deep breaths of someone in a rich slumber. Poor fucker. No, not poor fucker. This fucker owes money—big fucking money, and he's on the run from bad men. Those men weren't able to find him—but I was.

I drop the leather satchel to the bed with a thud, not giving a fuck if this fat piece of shit wakes up. He doesn't. I carry on and unzip, bypassing my .50 with a silencer and all the other bullshit I carry in this bag.

I take my dagger, pulling it out from the leather pocket I keep it in. It's still thick and heavy and fits into the palm of my hand effortlessly.

I'm not Manik right now. In this moment, I'm Aeron Romanov-Reed.

I yank the blanket down off his body and slam the palm of my glove covered hand over his mouth. His eyes pop open and land on me and he starts tossing and turning under my grasp. "Keep fucking still, Nigel."

Nigel doesn't keep still. He keeps wriggling like a deranged cat.

"Last warning..." I say, narrowing my eyes on him.

He doesn't stop.

I squeeze his mouth again forcefully, bringing my knife up to his neck. Pressing the sharp tip down onto one side, I watch as dark blood oozes from the incision, right down onto the bright, vivid sheets. His movements get frantic now, and it's pissing me off.

I slice across his neck, just a little. Not deep enough to cause a semi-decapitation, but just enough to freak him the fuck out so that he—yeah. I watch as his eyes close and his body goes limp. Until he passes out.

Taking my hand away from his mouth, I scoop up his body, lifting the heavy-weight up and start carrying him into the small bathroom that's off the bedroom. I hit the lights on my way in, clenching my dagger with my teeth—the metallic sting of his blood seeping through the material of the scarf and down my throat. It doesn't bother me—blood never has.

I drop the sack of shit into the tub and hit the shower, turning it on to cold.

His eyes flicker open again, and when they focus onto me, I can see he's about to start talking, so I yank his mouth open more, grab my knife, and sink it into his mouth until I find the base of his tongue. Once the blade is pressed to the thick of the muscle, I slice it in one motion and yank it out, throwing his tongue into the tub.

He moans again, but it's all muffled bullshit that I honestly can't be fucked with dealing with right now. Lyrics start floating in my head. It happens when I'm on a hit. Murder is inspirational gold for me. *Prison holds flesh that's washed up in sin... knock knock, bitch, now let the devil in... I'm a cannibal, motherfucking Hannibal, Lector, bounce up from this sector before my hellhounds eat ya.... Sic em.* Yeah, that shit is definitely going on the album.

He looks up at me in shock, and for a second, I wonder if he knows who I am—but there's no way. I always wear the bandana when I'm on a hit, not because dead men can talk, but because sometimes ghosts linger.

I tilt my head and chuckle, walking out of the bathroom and going for the TV. I turn it on to a music channel and crank it up a bit—just enough to drown out his moans—then turn back into the bathroom. I lean against the side of the tub and bring my face close to his.

His brown eyes are dilated and moving frantically, his swollen cheeks dosed in bright red shame. “You raped a little girl, Nigel. Remember Jessica Saurez? Yeah, the little girl you cornered at a carnival, dressed as a clown and raped her so badly she can never have kids? That girl was twelve years old, you sick fuck,” I say, flicking the blade between my fingers. My dagger is my favorite. I don't like guns, I mean they get the job done fast, but I ain't a fan of taking someone out from far range. I'd much rather watch as the world disappears from their view. “Now you've got me, and I gotta say, buddy.” I tap on his flabby chest. “You're shit out of luck. At least if it was her father who took you out, his rage would have made your death fast. But now you get me.” I chuckle, shaking my head. “And the best part is I'm doing this shit for free. It's an honor to be able to offer you up to Satan.”

I lick my lip, tasting some of the blood that has seeped through the bandana. “Start praying, fucker, but not even god will save your worthless ass now.”

I flick the knife around again and sink it into his guts, slicing it across until it shreds his flesh open through. Blood spills down over his abdomen and under his pajama bottoms, the hairs on his gut slowly drowning in the mess.

His intestine slips out with blood and fluid from the cut. His eyes are still on me, alive, wanting to scream. I grab onto the organ with my left hand and raise it to his mouth. “You have roughly ninety seconds of life left in you—do you want your last meal?”

His skin pales, the circles under his eyes sink to a dark purple. His pupils dilate to complete black and the ring around his mouth runs pale. He's about to die—die feeling every inch of pain I inflicted on him.

I yank my bandana down in the final ten seconds.

His eyes widen a fraction larger, and I smirk. “Night, fucker.”



CHAPTER TWELVE



“911”—Wyclef Jean

Beat

“I didn’t say that!” I scold Kyle, pulling the chicken tenders from the oven. “I just said that I have never played a real game of Blackjack.

“See, that’s so sad,” Kyle murmurs, throwing back his beer.

“I don’t think it’s sad!” Katiya retorts, evil eyeing Kyle. “I think it’s refreshing. Like, come on. How many girls are there in this world?”

Kyle’s eyes narrow. “Are you asking me to truly answer that? Because I think if you are, I might hate you more.”

Katiya rolls her eyes. “No, dick, I’m not asking you to truly answer how many girls there are in this world—like seriously? Where did you find this chump, Beatrice.”

I roll my eyes again, ignoring their fighting. Katiya has been here for a week now, and I was hoping that their fighting would subside, but it hasn’t. I don’t know if they want to sleep with each other or kill each other, but either way, I really wish they’d get it over with as soon as possible so I can hopefully go back to enjoying both of their company.

“What the hell is your point, Kitty Kat.”

“Don’t call me that...” she snarls, her lip curling.

Kyle grins. “Oh, come on. It’s cute. Kitty Kat.” His face falls. “You’re right, it’s way too cute for you.”

“Cunt.”

I widen my eyes at Katiya. “Kat!”

“What!” She feigns innocence. “Oh come on, don’t tell me that’s the first time you’ve ever heard that word, booboo...” She’s also taken it upon herself to call me booboo and I hate it. And she knows it. Which is exactly why she keeps calling me it. “I know my brother would have used it multiple times... just maybe in a different context.”

I start carrying the food to the table, placing the hot items onto a wooden cutting board. The kitchen is right behind the lounge—which has a couple of large windows that overlook the buildings beside us. Kyle comes from money and his parents basically purchased this place to bribe him into going to college—which he didn’t do. He wanted to bartend for a while until he figured out what he wanted to do in life. If Kyle had it his way, he’d spend the rest of his days feeding hungry kids in Africa. That’s just the type of person Kyle was. Someone you took home to meet your parents because they’d love him.

Lucky for me, I don’t have parents so that pressure was one thing I didn’t have to worry about. He has also made it his personal mission to wear less clothes since Katiya has been here, and Katiya has made it her mission to wear more clothes. They confuse me.

“Okay! Dinner time!” I throw the dishcloth onto the small island that’s made out of steel and yank open the fridge, taking out a bottle of Chardonnay.

Trust me, with these two, I might need it.

I take down some glasses from the top cupboard and go back to the table, placing everything down.

I take a seat, just as they continue their debate about—I don’t even know what now.

“Okay, so, how was everyone’s day?” I ask, dishing salad onto my plate.

They both stop, and Katiya exhales, her eyes coming to mine. She looks beautiful—but there is no way she could ever not look beautiful. Her hair is up in a little messy bun and her face is clean of makeup. She’s wearing a hoodie and some yoga pants, her foot up on the chair as she rests one hand on her knee.

“Good.” Her eyes come to me. “Hey, have you heard from Ae?”

I put some chicken on my plate. “Um, no, but I haven’t turned on my phone.”

“Why?” Kyle asks, his eyebrows raised at me as he digs into his food.

“Um, I don’t know. Just because. Want some dressing?” I ask Kyle, but he ignores me, glaring, and then looking to Katiya.

He wipes his mouth. “Okay, someone tell me what the fuck is going on.”

Katiya smiles sadly at me. “Can you turn it on?”

I look at her, her eyes are pleading with me and I feel a pang of guilt. “Do I need to?” I know Katiya can’t say anything in front of Kyle—and won’t—so I’m hoping she will give me a hint.

“Yes, might be a good idea.” Probably is, since the last time I spoke with Aeron he told me I wasn’t to fuck anyone else.

“Hold up,” Kyle says, grabbing my hand with his. “If you don’t want to, you don’t have to, Beat. I mean I know the whole one-night stand thing isn’t your deal, but it’s okay to walk away.”

“Excuse me, but you don’t know what the fuck you’re talking about,” Katiya snaps.

That’s it.

I groan, standing from my chair abruptly. I make my way for the stairs and dash into my bedroom, shoving all of Katiya’s crap off my bed. I can’t deal with their fighting anymore, I’m honest to God sick of it.

“No, it’s your fault!” Kyle snaps, both their voices drifting up from downstairs.

A few minutes later, there’s a knock on the door. I don’t look up, my face staying buried in my pillows.

“Can I come in?” Katiya asks softly.

“Sure,” I answer muffled. I’m not mad at her, or Kyle, but God I wish they’d stop fighting.

The mattress sinks beside me. “I’m sorry.”

“For what?” I ask, flopping onto my back so I can see her.

She brings her legs up and tucks them under her butt. “For fighting with Kyle, I know that’s what’s upsetting you.”

“So, can you both stop?” I ask softly, hoping she says yes.

“God, I hope so. He just annoys me so much, Beat, like oh my God.”

That warrants a giggle. “I see that.”

She smiles at me, and it’s scary the similarity she has to her brother, especially when it comes to their eyes. Her hand reaches for my cheek as she swipes my hair out of my face. “If my brother wasn’t psycho over you, I think I’d give it a go.”

“Kat, I’m straight.”

She waves her hand. “So am I! Sometimes.” She pauses. I glare. “Okay so like, occasionally or six times a year.”

I smile. “Much better.” I feel so comfortable with Katiya, I sort of always have. Even when she has gotten flirty with me—I didn’t feel like she was going to push me to make out with her or whatever it is that girls do together. She and I just felt like old friends.

Like sisters.

She exhales. “You really should text my brother. He doesn’t like playing games that he doesn’t start.”

“I sort of get that.”

She laughs sarcastically. “Oh booboo, you have no idea.”

I sort of get that too.

She stands from the bed, and just as she reaches my door, she turns back to face me. “I’ll make things right with Kyle and I, okay? I really am sorry.”

My shoulders slack and my heart beats off a load. “Thank you, and hey!”

She raises her eyebrows at me. “Yeah?”

“Wanna come watch me dance tomorrow? I mean, it’s just at a studio downtown, but they always sort of record me when I’m on and upload it to Instagram—which I never really use—”

She cuts me off. “—Beat? I know who you are on Instagram.”

“You do?” I ask, shocked.

“Yes.” She rolls her eyes. “You have a decent following, girl. Wouldn’t be surprised if one of them is my brother now.” She winks and then pauses, stepping backward and looking at me. “Actually, no, he wouldn’t, because he hardly uses that shit.”

I toss the pillow at the door and she squeals, disappearing to hopefully make it right with Kyle.

My eyes fall on the little white phone box that’s sitting on my dresser and my mouth fills with saliva, kudos to the nerves that have been constantly harassing me.

“Screw it.” I jump off the bed and grab the box, ripping the cover off and plugging it into the wall. I bite my nails nervously, waiting for it to switch on.

The Apple logo lights up the screen and I swear a teardrop of sweat rolls down my temple.

“This is stupid.” I leave the phone and go back downstairs. As long as it charges, that’s a step up

from it sitting in its box.

Landing on the bottom step, I hear laughter and quickly run into the kitchen, afraid of what I'm about to walk in to.

I find Katiya and Kyle doing the dishes and talking. "Hmmm," I murmur, leaning against the counter. "This isn't dodgy at all."

Katiya winks at me. "We can play nice."

Later that night, I'm slipping into bed beside a snoring Katiya when my phone vibrates on the nightstand. I quietly grab it and take it back to bed, being careful to not wake up sleeping beauty. She's a light sleeper—the complete opposite of me.

Text messages (125)

Voice messages (63)

Missed calls (83)

That pang of guilt hits me again when I realize I really did worry Kyle. It's not like it was my fault, what with being kidnapped, but I really hope he hasn't changed his view of me from this. I'd never do that to him—not in a million years. I wonder if deep down he knows that.

I start by clearing out the voice messages, deleting them all at once as well as all of the missed calls, then I go to the text messages. 124 of those were from Kyle, I'm guessing it was his number since I had so many messages from it, but there was another number that came up with one text.

Unknown: Remember the rules, Cub.

My heart thuds in my chest, beating so hard that it sets off my sweat glands.

"Fuck," I whisper out the foreign cuss word.

"Mmm, must be my brother," Katiya says, rolling over to face me.

I take my eyes away from my phone and look to her. "Yeah, it is."

She pauses, resting her hand under her cheek. "Do you want to know something?"

"Not really," I answer truthfully.

"Aeron is a Vor."

"What?" I ask, confusion etched into my tone.

"Listen, I'm telling you this because I know people. I read people and I'm damn good at it. Not as good as Ae, but good at it because he taught me."

"Ok, and yes, you're right." I nod, hitting the screen to my phone to create the light. "I'd never say a word."

She smiles weakly. "I know. You'd make a good woman one day."

"I'm a good woman without a man, thank you," I laugh, and she joins me, then both our laughter dies out.

"So, he's been initiated into The Family. He took the ritual. I'm not sure exactly what happens during this process, but it's not pretty—from what I hear."

"Okay, I'm listening." I roll onto my side to face her, but she goes to her back.

"My brother has endured shit that you can't even comprehend. Do you believe in nature or nurture?" she asks, her head tilting to me.

"I don't know," I say honestly. "I haven't thought enough about it."

"Well, Aeron is... troubled."

"No shit. He scares the crap out of me."

She snorts. “You have no idea. He is far from human. The thing is...” She pauses, and I watch as her throat tightens when she swallows. “He enjoys it. He tries to put up a false wall and make us all think that he doesn’t, that he hates who my father is and what life he has given us, but he doesn’t, Beatrice.” She turns back to face me. “He lives for it. He inhales the dying breath of his victims like it’s a line of cocaine.”

I freeze. “I could see that there was a darkness brewing beneath the surface.”

“It’s not a darkness, Beatrice, it’s a caged beast. He lets it out to play every time my dad has him on a job. It even has a name,” she utters, low enough that I almost miss it.

“A job?” I ask, but she pauses and then giggles.

“I’ve said too much already.”

I wanted to know more. It was just getting interesting and I wanted to know more. “You know I will never breathe a word about anything that you tell me—ever.”

Her hand comes up to my face. “I know.” She trails a finger down, but again, I don’t feel uncomfortable by her advances. “But can you promise me something?”

“I can try.”

“Don’t let Aeron have you.”

I snort. “That’s stupid because he doesn’t want me.”

She glares, and I can almost feel her eyes boring into me. “Stop being dumb, Beat. Aeron has been trained from a very young age to not feel. He will never be that guy who expresses his feelings to you, or even show an inkling of emotion—but that doesn’t mean that it’s not there, it just means that he’s very good at hiding it, and he is. Hell,” she laughs, shaking her head. “He doesn’t even kiss girls.”

I freeze, and she notices because her head whips around to face me again. “Did he kiss you?”

“No, he didn’t, just went down on me.” But, now that I think back, it is weird how he didn’t. Now I know why.

She sags in relief. “Oh, yeah, well, not surprised.”

“Should I be slightly disturbed by this?”

She looks at me. “No, but you should feel warned. He’s not a knight in shining armor. He will never sweep you off your feet. You need that kind of man, I can tell. So just save yourself the hurt and don’t go deeper than what it already is. Think about it before you reply to his message, okay?”

I nod, sinking deeper into my bed covers. “Okay.”



CHAPTER THIRTEEN



“Everybody Dies in Their Nightmares”—XXXTENACION

Manik

“Paul wants to hear what we have so far on this album,” Lenny says, leaning back in his chair. I shrug, shoving the last piece of chicken into my mouth. Keeping up with my fitness routine and my life, in general, is fucking exhausting. “Then tell him he can, when it’s ready. It ain’t ready yet.” Lenny pauses, and I can see him watching me from the corner of my eye. “What, Lenny?” “You got words down last night after going to see your dad?” I pick up my glass and down the rest of the milk. “Yeah, I did.” “You wanna talk about it?” My eyes shoot up to him. “Do I ever? And if I did, would I ever?” His eyebrows creased in confusion. “Can you stop with the mind fuck thing that you do—my brain still can’t keep up.” My face is flat, and I’m just about to ask him about the album when my phone starts ringing in my back pocket. I reach and grab it out, swiping it to unlock. “Talk.” “She’s—God, Ae...” I close my eyes. “What? What’s happening.” “No, it’s nothing. It’s just, I’m at this small studio thing in town watching her dance.” “She dances?” I ask, shocked. Beatrice just seems too mellow to be into anything like that.

Dancers usually have no problem with the spotlight or being the center of attention, where I've always gotten the vibe that Beatrice hates it. I shouldn't give a fuck what she does. Why the fuck do I care, and why do I find myself interested and wanting to watch her dance? My thoughts go back to fucking Lenny. *"Everyone has that one girl."* Motherfucker probably cursed me or some shit. It's like the law of attraction. The more people stunt talking about something, the more you think about it.

Yeah, fuck it. I'll go with that.

"You didn't know?" Katiya sounds shocked. This is what's wrong with my sister. She sees humanity inside of me that doesn't exist.

I massage my temples. "Why the fuck would I know that?"

Long pause.

"Um, I don't know, because you run checks?"

"And I did, but none of her checks showed anything about her being a dancer. What is it—jazz? Ballet? Something nice and cute? Oh, I know. Cheerleading..."

Another long pause.

"How about you come down and take a look for yourself? Then I can tell you my other news," she suggests, and I look up at Lenny, catching him watching me carefully.

I flip him off.

"Send me the address." I hang up on her and smirk at Lenny. "Want to watch ballet?"

Beat

I'm in the center, and I tear off my shirt, leaving me in my sports bra and loose grey sweatpants. "Rattlesnake" from Tsar starts playing through the speakers and I roll my body around, letting the rhythm take me over. This isn't a freestyle, it's choreographed by one of the guys who trains here. I can see the door open out of the corner of my eye, and I don't know why I notice that. When I'm dancing, I'm performing. I'm not entirely me when I'm out here with the music—it's someone else that takes over me and I allow it. It's also being recorded. I'm not famous or anything extra like that, I just like to dance, and because I've danced with some well-known people in the past, it has helped boost my following. I never claimed to be the best, but I always bring my best. Talent doesn't work unless you do.

The beat drops and so does my body. I flirt around the camera and wink at it. Tensing my abs and muscles with every move, I ignore the tight tension that's throbbing over my hip. It's still a little tender, but it works as a reminder to keep everything tight, so I ignore it. I drop to the ground, sticking my ass up and shake before spinning back around and rolling off one of the girls who is dancing beside me. It's a thirty-second slot, so we bounce out and the next group set up to do the exact same routine with the exact same song.

I'm laughing and hugging one of the girls when I remember that Katiya is here and that I better check on her.

I freeze when I see she's not alone, my water bottle stopping short of my lips.

Shit. Double freaking shit. He's here.

I start walking toward them slowly, while frantically trying to figure out why he could possibly be here. I chose not to text him back last night. Katiya was right, I probably don't need that in my life. She didn't say it, but I'm pretty sure he has hurt a lot of people before. Could the same hands that end

lives be the same ones to make mine come alive? I don't know. It feels too much like I'm dancing one-on-one with karma, and that's a dance battle I will never win.

"Hey!" I say, looking at Aeron and Lenny. "What are you guys doing here?" I suck down my water until they notice I'm sucking down *all* of my water. I pull it away, not wanting to be obvious that he may sort of have an effect on me.

Stockholm Syndrome? Maybe I need to get checked out.

"To learn how to dance..." Aeron quips sarcastically, his eyes going over my shoulder.

I turn around to follow his glance and I see everyone's face is pale, jaws dropped open. "Oh, right." I click my fingers, looking back to Aeron. "I forgot how famous you were."

His eyes cut to mine and I flinch because they're inhumane. Those eyes are not made by genetics, they're placed on this earth to mess with girls like me.

I scan what he's wearing. Casual jeans, a hoodie with its hood up and white sneakers on his feet. He looks like he has stepped out from the bad-boy sector of every ruthless neighborhood your parents told you to stay away from.

"You dance?"

I swipe the sweat from my stomach, his eyes following the movement. "Yes. Have since I was little."

Aeron tilts his head. Is he shocked maybe? I don't know.

Lenny chuckles around his protein shake. "I've gotta say—"

"—No, you don't..." Aeron cuts him off.

Katiya stills beside me so I look directly at her, who then looks directly at me, her face now pale too. "Are you okay?" I ask, reaching out to her.

"Yes," she says, shaking off her shock and giving me a completely fake smile. She looks back to her brother. "What are you guys doing today?"

Aeron's eyes are still on mine and my stomach is doing that achy thing again.

"Finishing up this song."

"How many songs in are you?" Kat asks, and I get the feeling she's trying to deflect the conversation. Why, I'd have no idea.

"We have eight. With a couple features."

"I have one more set and then we can go?" I gesture to them all.

Manik nudges his head, pulling his hoodie down and I do that breathing thing again that matches that heart thing, because he's so stupidly beautiful.

As soon as I'm back where all of the dancers are—some I've known since I've been here and some new—the questions start. I brush them all off and lie by saying that Katiya and I are close—that's why he's here.

They bought it.

I hope.

Music starts playing and I slide down to the ground slowly and then suck in my stomach while arching my back. This one is a solo, just me, and I'm pretty proud of it because I choreographed it myself. I hit every line with perfect precision, losing myself in the music.

On the way home, I turn in my seat and face Katiya. "Why did he show up?"

She smirks. "I'm assuming by *he* you mean my brother?"

I deadpan, "Yes, Kat."

She exhales. "I told him to, but that's not even the mind-blowing part."

“What’s the mind-blowing part?” I ask, a little too eager to hear what she’s implying.

“It’s the fact that he came.”

She pulls her white Maserati into the parking lot outside our loft, turning the car off.

I get out, shutting the door behind me. “Why did he come?”

She stares at me, lifting her glasses up over her head and pushing her hair back, out of her face. “I don’t know, Beat.”

Later that night, I’m getting ready for work when Kyle enters. “You’re lucky I love you and got your job back, Kermit.”

He calls me Kermit because of my bright green eyes.

“Okay, thank you for loving me.” I grin at him, brushing my hair into a high ponytail until the ends fall down and rest on my mid back.

He rolls his eyes, just as Katiya pushes past him. “I’m going to come in too.”

“Why?” Kyle asks, his eyes narrowed on her.

“Because I like to drink?”

He relaxes. “Of course, you do.”

Katiya nudges her head at me. “Wanna have a drink after work?”

“Beatrice doesn’t drink,” Kyle replies flatly. “I used to hate that she was so boring, but now I like it. It’s refreshing. How many girls do you know that don’t drink.”

I slide the wand of my lip balm over my lips, ignoring the beginning of their bickering. I know that it’s almost always Kyle that starts it with her—I just don’t know why. Kyle has never had issues with anyone—ever. He’s extroverted and has thousands of friends, but right now, I can’t be bothered getting to the root of their issues. I’m hoping they’ll just figure it out on their own.

Hopefully.

“I think it’s great, but I also think occasional partying doesn’t hurt either,” Katiya snaps back. I plait my ponytail in a thick loose braid so it falls down my back and then I slip my shirt off, pulling my drawers open to find my uniform.

Their fighting stops.

I turn around to face them, putting my hands into the sleeves of my shirt. “Well, if all I have to do is take my shirt off to stop both of your fighting...”

Katiya rolls her eyes, but Kyle winks at me. He’s always been flirty with me—the simple part of flirty—innocent. I don’t have to worry about him snapping me in half.

“I’ll meet you downstairs, Kermit.”

I nod, pulling my shorts down and slipping into the small little leather skirt that has a zipper going up the middle. At first, I hated the uniforms, but now I don’t care. Drunk people are just that—drunk. They’d flirt with an elephant if it was serving them drinks.

“Are you okay?” Katiya asks, her eyes searching mine frantically.

“I’m fine.” I yank my phone off the nightstand and smile at her. “I’ll see you later?”

She nods, but something isn’t right with her. I’ll ask her about it later, so I push my phone into my bra and head downstairs where Kyle is waiting for me, swinging his keys around his finger. “Ready to bounce?”

The music is pounding through the club, the bright neon blue and pink lights flashing to the sound. I’m pouring a shot of Grey Goose when Katiya stumbles back to the bar.

“Okay!” she yells over the music, leaning into the counter.

“What’s wrong, Kat?” I know she’s drunk, and maybe it’s shit of me to use this moment to try to extract information out of her—but I’m desperate.

She stops, her eyes glassed over from all of the liquor she’s been packing. “Lemme ask you just one question...” She puts her finger up, her other hand flying to cover her mouth.

“Okay, ask...” I flick the bottle back down, casting a quick look at Kyle to make sure he takes care of any new customers. He nods.

Katiya leans over the bar. “Do you like fairytales or Marvel comics, our little Cub...?”

“What?” I ask, my eyebrows etched in. What the hell is she talking about?

“Just answer the question.” She gestures with her hands.

“Fine.” I clear my throat. “I’ll go with Rapunzel because her life is sad.”

Triumph fills her eyes as they focus on me completely. I took the bait. “See! You need a knight in shining armor. With Aeron, you don’t get a knight in shining armor, you get a villain strapped with AK’s. Are you prepared for that? To be the girl who turns on his emotions? Because let me tell you, Cub, the thing with people who lock up their emotions? When they finally do release them, they lose control because they don’t know how to grasp everything that they’re feeling. Do you want to be the girl who unlocks that bolted door?”

I let out a long breath, my eyes searching hers carefully. She’s been keeping that in for a while, I can see it in the release of her shoulders. “Well, I—”

“—Because it takes a certain type of woman to handle someone like my brother, and Beatrice, you can’t just be all light, you also need some smoke, some darkness, and I really don’t think you have the right amount of darkness to be able to carry the light he needs.”

Ouch.

She leaves, taking her drink with her and the music pounds through my ears again, like the last minute was just her and I talking.

A hand wraps around my waist and I jerk, turning around to face Kyle.

“Wow,” Kyle says, his face worried. “It’s just me, Kermit. You okay?”

Chills break out over my skin and I shake my head. “I don’t know. I really just...” My eyes fly up to the VIP section Manik and Lenny were at the first night I saw him.

The night it all started.

My chest tightens and my breathing quickens. It’s as though there’s no oxygen, just sweaty bodies of drunk humans.

“I need air,” I mutter, shoving past Kyle and pushing open the “staff only” entrance before exiting the back of the bar. Pushing through a couple of stray bartenders and dancers, I go all the way to the back exit, shoving the door open with my eyes closed. The cool air slaps me in the face and I suck in the crisp breeze. Shutting the door behind myself, I lean back against the door and look up at the sky.

“Beatrice Kennedy,” a voice says and I still, looking ahead of myself.

Oh God. Vladimir Pakhan Romanov—aka Aeron’s dad. He looks almost exactly the same as he did that night, with the same fedora and trench coat, and with a cigar hanging out of his mouth.

“Yes?” I clear my throat as he moves forward. With every step closer he takes, I want to take one hundred back. But I don’t, and I won’t. That will only prove Katiya right that I’m weak—which is basically what she had said, if I strip back everything else and get to the essence of her words.

“I’ll cut the shit, Beatrice. You’re not to jump into bed with my son.”

My mouth drops open and then closes. Once I’ve finally regained the nerve to sort out my reply, I say, “What? We’re not... nothing has happened.”

“—Yet,” he answers for me, narrowing his eyes. He rolls the cigar around in his mouth, the bright

orange exit light and the few street lamps the only lighting I have.

“Did you come all the way here to tell me this? Why?” I ask, tilting my head. I’m intrigued by this, unless of course he means because Aeron is famous and rich and I’m a lost pirate searching for my next chest of treasure.

“How was your childhood, Beatrice?”

“Fine, mostly, why?” I ask again. What a weird question. He seems to ponder my answer for a few seconds and then shakes his head. “Interesting.”

He drops the cigar to the ground and steps on it. “Don’t get involved with him, Beatrice. You will regret it.”

He leaves, walking back to his waiting limo as I’m left cemented in my spot, speechless. This is by far the strangest family I’ve ever met, but then again, I’ve not met many of them. Tired, and feeling a little annoyed at everyone tonight, I take my phone out of my front pocket and unlock it. My finger hovers over the unknown number that texted me—the one I know belongs to Aeron.

I hit call and then bring it to my ear.



CHAPTER FOURTEEN



“Bounce”—Rittz, Twista

Manik

My phone starts vibrating on the kitchen counter and I pick it up, wiping the sweat from my face. “What?”

There’s a slight pause. “Ah, Aeron? It’s Beatrice.”

I sip my water. “I know.”

Another pause. Bet she’s fucking cringing right now. I smirk. “Somethin’ I can help you with, Cub? You know, since it’s pushing one in the morning...” I know that this isn’t a booty call, because Beatrice isn’t one of those girls. She’s nothing like those girls. Fucking wish she was, it would sure as shit make staying away from her that much easier. I hoped she was...

“What?” She sounds shocked. Cute. “No!” She then tries to defend herself.

“Alright, so what do I owe the pleasure?”

She clears her throat. “I’m really confused by a few things and I was hoping you could maybe help me out.”

I look around the kitchen. “Well, speak.”

She clears her throat again. “Um, I was hoping that it could be something we could talk about in person, maybe?”

I chuckle. “Yeah alright, Cub. Come over tomorrow and bring my sister with you.”

“Okay,” she exhales. “What time?”

I lick my lips. “Ten.”

“In the morning?”

“At night.”

She pauses. “Ah, okay. I’ll see you then.”

“Beat?” I add before she hangs up.

“Yeah?” Her voice is husky over the phone, and for a split, very delusional minute, I wonder if she wants me.

“Wear something sexy.”

I hang up, tossing the rest of my water into the sink and making my way up to my room. I know Dad has said not to go near her. I figure, if he was serious about me staying away from her and the reason was valid, then he’d tell me, but he hasn’t, which has me believing his reason is shit.

I knew that when she was here that I wouldn’t force any shit on her. I’m not that man, never will be. It wasn’t that I didn’t know she was attractive—her looks were the first thing you noticed about her, with her ass being the second, but I had zero interest in her because I knew that was probably what she wanted. To be ravaged, fucked and slapped around in bed. Slowly, she schooled my shit when it came to that and proved I was wrong. I have girls dropping to their knees in front of me at every turn—every girl but Beat. Since that night, I knew she was different. Not because she didn’t know who I was, but because she knew and didn’t care. Truly gave no fucks. So, I tested her, made a couple of subtle advances. Nothing too obvious, and even though I saw that she was fighting with what to do, the essence of her thought process seemed to want to fight me. Until she spread eagle for me on my kitchen counter. I still have her taste lingering on the tip of my tongue.

After a quick shower, I slip into bed and my phone dings with a text.

Kat: Ae, unlezs you’re serious about her, can you levvve hr alne plz.

I roll my eyes.

Me: How much have you had to drink?

My sister is a grammar Nazi. When she drunk texts all her side pieces, it’s not the content of what she texted them that upsets her the next day, it’s the spelling and the grammar.

Kat: Enough to know you’re both stupid.

I leave my phone on the nightstand and toss and turn for one hundred years until I finally drift to sleep.



“We’re up to ten songs, Ae! Fuck me, and they’re fucking good. The best.” Lenny is on his phone, texting all the people he has no doubt invited tonight. We’ve cut off the album at ten with another two for features. It’s a good number, twelve songs on an album. It doesn’t give the listener an overload while keeping them hungry for more.

“Ghetto Cowboy” by Bone Thugs starts playing and I tie my bandana to the front of my head (yeah, the very same), my somewhat short hair flopping over it. We’re all kicking it near the pool as workers start piling in with kegs and food. We always have a party after we finish an album—it’s a ritual and it’s almost always last minute because we never know how long we’re going to take to push out an album. TMZ will no doubt be the first fuckers to break the story tonight that it’s finished and then we’ll have a whole bunch of people trying to jump the fence to get in.

Lenny flicks his wrist down my body. “You working out more or some shit? You’re almost as big as me.”

I laugh, tilting my head back. I’ve got no shirt on with nothing but my loose ripped denim shorts that hang to just above my knee when they hit low-ride—not low, low, just enough to hug below the band of my Calvin Klein briefs. “Hell nah. You’re the beast.”

He shakes his head. “You say that like you don’t have a pet one.”

I ignore him and look toward the door as more people come in. I grin, getting up from my chair to welcome the people I can be fucked talking to.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN



“Sad Song”—Twisted Insane

Beat

Why am I doing this? Why am I even considering Aeron and his crazy ideas? Yes, that’s right, because I need to tell him about his dad and the stuff Katiya said. I just need to know why I feel like there’s something someone isn’t telling me. Why Vladimir took it upon himself to come to my work and basically threaten me.

I’m brushing my hair and letting it sit in natural waves down my back when Kat walks in, heels on with a little white lace bodysuit and tight jeans. She looks amazing. Her hair is straight and flat, hanging around her jaw in a perfect razor cut.

“Wow!” she breathes out, tilting her head.

“Don’t do that...” I murmur, turning back around to look at myself in the mirror.

“Do what?” she asks softly.

“Do the head tilt thing. You look like your brother when you do it.”

She chuckles and ducks behind me, her eyes coming to mine in the mirror. “Good, maybe I’ll get laid. I’m really hoping he dies when he sees you. At least that way, I’ll know how he really feels about you and quit playing a fool.”

My eyes go to what I’m wearing. Tight white skinny jeans with the knees torn open, a little red crop top that gives my boobs way too much viewing time before it ties behind my back in a big bow.

Katiya hands me my pointy toe red stilettos, and I take them from her, loosening the straps and

slipping them on my feet one at a time. “I don’t think that’s going to happen.”

She rolls her eyes. “Am I going to do makeup?”

I flinch. “Um, okay. I guess.”

She pushes down on my shoulders and I flop onto the bed as she pulls out all of her makeup from her bag.

I gulp. “Please don’t make me look stupid.”

She glares at me. “Do I look stupid?”

I smile. “No, okay good point.”

She starts on the foundation and continues with the contouring and then eyes. She wants my eyes dark-rimmed, said something about the bright green standing out more behind the black—so I allow it. My stomach nudges in anticipation, which is stupid. I’m going back to the house I was locked up in for a week, caged in the basement like a wild animal. Maybe I do have a mild case of Stockholm Syndrome. Who knows.

I let Katiya work her magic, sitting quietly as she does. “Can I ask you a question?”

She pauses, makeup brush in her hand. “Sure.”

“Has Aeron had any girlfriends?” Okay, that came out a lot more jealously than I intended.

A sly smile spreads over her mouth. “Define girlfriend...” She continues doing my makeup. “The answer is no. He hasn’t. Aeron lets girls bounce around on his dick for a while, but then he bounces them right back off. It’s his MO.”

“Huh,” I answer absently. “Not sure if that gave him points or took them away.”

She drops her hands. “Beat, please don’t—just...” She breathes out heavily, picking up the mascara. “Okay let me ask you a question. Are you okay with not having love?”

I quirk my eyebrow. “Nothing has even happened with he and I yet—and it probably won’t. He just likes playing with me and I, ashamedly, like the tricks he plays...”

“Right now...” Katiya adds, brushing the wand through my lashes. “You like his tricks right now because he has only shown you level one. Just please—don’t give too much of yourself, because Aeron is greedy, and he won’t give any part of you back.”

We pull into the long driveway, me driving Katiya’s expensive car. It took me three times to figure out how to even start it, let alone driving it here. It was a nightmare. We were supposed to bring my car, but it chose that very moment to not start, so I was stuck playing with the buttons of Katiya’s Maserati. I don’t see the appeal. Humans like to complicate things. Things like keyless entry and push-to-start cars.

We both get out and make our way to the front door. We can hear the music blaring from the driveway, but the closer I got, the louder not just the music, but the laughter and voices got too.

I can feel my social anxiety slowly seeping into my pores. “Maybe I should just go home...”

Katiya’s hand flies out and she pulls me into her. “And miss the opportunity of teasing the fuck out of my brother with that outfit? Hell. No. Come on.” I feel like maybe I’m stuck between a sibling war.

She drags me through the front door, shoving through the swarm of bodies who are walking around.

Girls. A lot of girls. Dressed in bikinis and—some with no bikini top on.

“What...the...”

Katiya squeezes my hand. “Just don’t look in dark corners either.”

Yeah, it’s safe to say that this was definitely a bad idea. Damn, Katiya. Being back here stirs something unfamiliar inside of me. Not upsetting, but...something else. Something I’m not sure I want

to look at or acknowledge right now.

Kat drags us through the large glass doors that open out onto the backyard where the music is blaring from. People are jumping into the pool, dancing, and basically acting like drunk teenagers.

“How old is Aeron?” I ask Katiya, my eyes flying around the bodies.

“Hmm?” She gazes at me over her shoulder before dragging me forward. “Oh, he’s twenty-seven.”

He’s four years older than me, which makes Katiya—“How old are you?” I continue to follow her past people until her walking slows. “Twenty-four.”

My eyes go to the group she has stopped in front of, and I freeze when they land on Aeron. He pales, his eyes going up and down my body. I feel a little self-conscious with the way he’s taking me in, like he’s trying to memorize every single bit of me. That’s not always a good thing, especially when it’s coming from him.

“Hey, boyyyyysssss.” Katiya swings her arm around Lenny, sounding a lot like Harley Quinn. “Where the drinks at?”

Aeron is still looking at me, only now he’s glaring right through my eyes. “Drinks for you? By the bar. Drinks for Beatrice—the water is in the fridge...” It wasn’t a dig, and I sort of appreciated it.

Katiya rolls her eyes. “How did you know that she doesn’t drink when I only just found out?”

Aeron grins, his hand reaching out to latch onto mine. Sparks fly through my fingers at the single touch. Even that night when his mouth was on me, he didn’t *touch* me. There are different kinds of touch. There’s the touch you do for pleasure, and then there’s the other kind. This was the other kind. Instantly, I notice there are a couple girls dancing around the back of his chair—one with no bikini top on at all and the other who may as well not be wearing one. He’s stretched out on a sunbed, wearing faded jean shorts, no top, and he’s got a black bandana tied to the front of his head.

He laughs, his head tilting back as my eyes flash back to the bandana. *That damn bandana.* Someone screams out from across the pool and then falls into the water with a splash...

“Hold her, Garth!” Mom screamed. The strong petulant smell of petroleum thickened the air so much that my throat swelled. Mom ran back into my bedroom and slammed the door shut.

She looked directly at my dad who was protecting me with his body.

“They’re here.”

I shake my head, annoyed with the latest tricks my mind was playing on me. It happens every now and then, something would appear in my head. I don’t know if they’re memories or if they’re just a fabricated part of reality that I’ve made up in my head, like my pops used to say. That one was a little more vivid than usual. I could still smell the lingering smell of the burnt ash in the air.

My eyes connected with Aeron. Yep. Why, why does he have to make me feel things? How is it possible for another human to make you feel absolutely everything by touching absolutely nothing?

He tugs me toward him and I fly forward until I land on his lap. Katiya watches the exchange, her mouth wide open. I look to Lenny who is grinning—I think I like Lenny. Probably more than I like Aeron, only because he isn’t an asshole like Aeron.

Aeron’s hand sprawls out over my bare stomach. It feels low-key possessive.

He takes a swig of his whiskey, and I’m enveloped in his smell again.

“Ah...” Katiya says, looking from me to him. “So, just to be clear, is this a new thing, a real thing, or an, ‘I’m going to fuck you then dump you,’ thing, Ae? Because I’m pretty sure we’ve—”

He glares at her. “It’s not a Katiya thing, so drop it and go get yourself a drink.”

She storms off with some poor guy hooked in her arm. I'm strangely aware of everyone's eyes on me. They're probably wondering who the hell this girl is sitting on their god—and probably placing bets on how long I will last. The thought makes me uncomfortable so I shuffle around to face Aeron, my legs dangling between his. I search his expression, my attention going between his mouth and his eyes. "I don't like being looked at."

His eyebrows shot up. "Yeah? Well for as long as you're on my lap, you will get looked at."

I nod, tucking one side of my hair behind my ear. "Mmmhmm, so maybe I should move?"

He glares. "Move and I'll bend you over that table and make everyone watch as you light up like the Fourth of July."

Another possessive flag.

I clear my throat, turning to face the party again. Some hip-hop—rap song is playing, and I instantly recognize Manik's voice. Anyone would recognize it because it's unlike anything that has been heard before. I mean, everyone has their own flow—Manik's just happens to sound sexual when needed, rough when ignited, and feral if tormented. He adapted to the music, and I think that's one of the reasons why he's the best to this date.

One of the other guys who I've seen a few times now, he has a big X tattooed over the side of his temple, cheers loudly, throwing his hand up in the air—holding a bottle of vodka. "Fucking boom!" he hollers. "This is the new shit that sounds like old shit, and that can't be copied, shit!"

I laugh, turning again to face Aeron. His face has lit up, his head bobbing to the base of the music. There is definitely more to him. I just have to figure out if getting to know him is worth losing my soul for.

He squeezes my belly, his eyes coming to mine lazily. "You sure you don't want a drink?"

I shake my head. "Nah, it's ok."

"You don't drink at all?"

I shrug. "I do sometimes, but the last time I got drunk was enough to put me off for life. Let's just say, I had a good college life."

"Good, huh?" he asks, his lips going to his glass as his eyes stay on mine. "Anything I need to know?"

I think over his question, ignoring how my ass hurts from being on his leg. "Ah... no? Not need."

He leans into the crook of my neck, his lips grazing over the skin below my ears. "So, you're not a virgin?" His low voice vibrates over every single inch of me.

My lips curl between my teeth. "Why would I be a virgin?" It's a soft whisper that leaves the question hanging, lost in the silence of the music changing. I liked the last song that Manik was on. It was slow, the base deep and dark, but the lyrics and the tone Manik used was sly and a little deranged—but it made the song. It is definitely about to be a hit. I heard the words *Sic Em* rapped up in the lyrics. Maybe that's what it's called.

I can feel his smile against my neck and I hate that everything south is throbbing with need. I know what his tongue feels like between my thighs, I know what he can do, but a side of me that I haven't explored yet also wants to see what it feels like to be full of him. Completely taken over by him. He growls softly against my skin, "Because you taste like it."

What.

That should gross me out. I always thought dirty talk was a little awkward and embarrassing, but those words coming out of his mouth, from the tip of his tongue—tongue... oh God...

I swallow. "Not a virgin, sorry to disappoint."

His hand comes up to my cheek, turning my face to meet his. His eyes search mine desperately,

but they're hooded in his gaze. He licks his bottom lip. "I bet I can make you believe you're a virgin again, Cub..."

"So much talk..." I tease, lost in the daze of his eyes. He captures me with every word, and maybe that makes me naïve, but I'd rather be naïve and see where this goes—even if it ends with me holding my broken heart—than not have tried it at all.

I want him to kiss me.

His eyes search my lips, his smirk still there. He leans forward, my mouth opening for him, waiting for our lips to touch and for me to lose my mind from the connection that I've been emotionally feeling in the physical form. His lips scrape over mine gently, and I hear a sharp intake of breath from behind me—but I ignore it. Completely trapped by Aeron. I want him so badly that it has spread like a cancer and at this point, there's no way I'd be seeking any kind of treatment, because I want it. I want to be that girl. So, he's a dark knight, I have enough light inside of me to show him the way.

His grin presses slightly across my mouth as he chuckles, his eyes going over my shoulder. He retreats, sipping his drink. "What's the matter, sis, you look like you've seen a ghost..." His arms wrap around my stomach tighter, more urgently, and when he slips me over his lap, I can feel him pressing against my ass.

Oh Lord.

Kat looks between us, her face pale yet her cheeks on fire. "No ghost, brother, just a demon, you know..."

He laughs, his head tilting back and I ease into his grip.

Katiya hands me a glass. "It's lemonade."

I smile up at her. "Thank you." I can't meet her eyes, because I know what she's doing. She's worried about me getting hurt. I don't know what I ever did to warrant such a good friend like Katiya, but I already know that I'll be going through life with her. When you meet those girls, you just know. There are friends who you know are only temporary, and then there are ones who permanently imprint themselves into your life, so even if you do end up going separate ways, they'll always be able to find their way back to you.

Katiya is one of those friends.

"Big brother, are you going to let her out to breathe?" Katiya teases, but I see the annoyance in her eyes. "I need someone to dance with, and you have plenty of other" —she flicks her wrists up to the girls who are probably still behind us—"things to entertain yourself with. Or have you lost your touch?"

"Katiya," he chuckles playfully, shaking his head with a grin. "Shut up."

I can see she's getting mad so I tap his leg. "Let me up, I won't be long."

He hesitates for a second and then lets me go. Just as I get to my feet, a girl comes to stand in front of me, blocking my eyes from Katiya.

"Hi! I'm Emma, Man's known plaything..." She laughs but she's not joking, she's trying to make a point.

"Nice to meet you." I grin, taking her hand in mine. "I'm the girl he keeps locked in the basement."

Her smirk falls.

Katiya and Lenny start busting out laughing, as well as the other guys who are around us.

"Ah..." Emma says, looking down at Ae.

I give Katiya a pleading look over Emma's shoulder, and Kat's laughter dies instantly as she

grabs my hand and pulls me beside her. Just as we walk away, Katiya leans into Emma and whispers something in her ear.

When Kat drags me to where everyone else is dancing, I start swinging to the song and lean into her. “What did you say?”

She grins, her hands coming up as she drops low to come up all sexy. “Just told her to watch how Ae watches you—that’s all the warning she needs.”

I ignore whatever is going on over there because if I see Emma on Aeron’s lap, I might make a fool of myself, so instead, I ignore everyone and dance with Kat.

The DJ booth is hidden in the distance near the dance floor. My eyes go to the DJ and I tilt my head.

Wait. I know this guy.

Laughing, I shake my head and make my way toward him, leaping into the small booth he has.

“Beat?” Jer gasps in shock. “Holy shit!” He pulls me in for a hug and I chuckle, hitting his arm.

“What are you doing here?”

“Working! What are you doing?”

I met Jer through the club. He’d do a gig every now and then, but I haven’t seen him in a couple of months.

“I’m, ahhh...” My eyes go to where Aeron is, only to see him already watching us carefully, his mouth slightly open.

I quickly look to Kat, who is looking at Ae and then looking back to me with a questioning glare.

“I’m with Kat!” I answer smoothly, smiling back at Jer.

He looks down at Kat, and then back to me. “Cool, where’s Kyle?”

“He’s working tonight—couldn’t come!”

“Well, I’ll play some sick shit for you, yeah? You show these” —he looks out to the crowd and shivers—“girls how it’s done.”

I laugh, shoving him playfully and jump off the little makeshift platform while making my way back to Katiya who pulls me into her. “You trying to get someone killed?”

“What?” I ask, but just as I’m about to ask her again what she means, “Drop” by G-Eazy starts playing. I smirk, yanking Katiya into me and start dancing, my head tilting back. As G drops his line about dropping it like it’s hot, I pause, bending over and dropping down before making my way back up.

Katiya laughs, pulling me into her, she groans in my ear. “Stop being so hot, my brother isn’t dealing well with it.”

The song mixes into Fat Joe and Dr. Dre’s “Pick It Up.”

“Kat, I think you’re jumping to things a little too fast...” I say, then lean back into her. “What’s wrong anyway, aside from him hurting me, why are you against this so much?”

I stand back to watch her face. She exhales and then pulls me into her. “There’s something I overheard my dad say, but I haven’t had a chance to talk to Ae about it yet, so I don’t know what it is. It might be nothing, but for now, I just really think it’s best for all of us if you guys slow it down.”

“I—”

“Can’t help it?” she finishes for me, leaning back to speak directly into my ear. “I thought you might say that, so just... I don’t see anything. For now. I’d kill for my brother, and die for him, but I don’t know, Beat, something just feels off.”

I look back to Manik, his eyes are already on me. Actually, all of his friend’s eyes are on me. “Hey Luv” by Mobb Depp starts playing, the strums of the beat playing in perfect synch to my heart.

I feel it. Right there, but that's what happens when you start something with someone and everything is moving fast, you reach the finish line quicker.

I know that Katiya is right. This can never end well between Manik and I—as much as I want it to. God, I want it. I didn't realize how much I wanted it until tonight, now it's like I've admitted something deep inside of me so the floodgates are flowing. I'm in trouble.

He nods his head, but I retract slowly, my steps backing up. The song isn't helping. It's deep, and I relate to every lyric being spun on a singular level—but Kat is right.

I spin around and go around the pool, pushing past the swarm of people who are dancing around the edge.

"Excuse me." I thrust past, desperate to get out. It was a bad idea coming here tonight. I was jumping into something that was so far out of my comfort zone my feet ached.

I run through the house, down the foyer and head for the front door, pulling it open. I reach into my pocket and start Google searching a taxi. I'm hitting the green call button when the phone is snatched out of my hand from behind.

I spin around to see who it is, only to come chest to chest with Aeron.

"What are you doing?" I ask, my breathing shallow. I didn't expect him to chase me out here—much less be glaring at me like a caged lion who didn't get the feast he was promised.

He clutches my phone, stepping closer to me, his hard chest grazing my nipples. I step backward, but he counters it. "Where you going, Cub?"

"Home," I answer, folding my arms in front of myself when I notice that he's not going to budge. I may as well look strong since I sure as hell don't feel it. "I shouldn't have come."

"Wrong answer," he replies easily, one of his arms wrapping around my waist to pull me in closer. He leans down until his lips touch mine, not enough for it to warrant as a kiss, but a simple brush of warning.

"There is no wrong or right answer to this, Aeron. Let's be real—" I start.

He cuts me off. "Yeah, let's, Beatrice, because I'm sort of sick of doing this song and dance with you."

"What song and dance?" I ask, my head going back. "There has been no song and dance. You kidnapped me after I saw a dead man and then you locked me in your basement for a week while you —"

"—While I what, Beat?" he asks, his head tilting and his arm getting tighter around my waist. He drops my phone into his pocket and brings his other hand up to my hair, tugging on it so my neck bends back. "What happened to you during that week, Beatrice, was nothing compared to what it could have been, but you and I both know that, and we both know that there's been some bullshit hanging between us."

I pause, then open my mouth to answer, only for it to slam closed again.

"The question is; are you game enough to do this. You're a dancer, but can you drop off that high horse like you can drop that ass?"

My eyes narrow. "I'm not on a high horse!"

"Hey." His finger hooks under my chin, bringing my face closer to his. So close our noses touch. "I didn't say it wasn't sexy as fuck, and hell, it might just be the thing that drew me to you in the first place, and trust me, I needed a lot of fucking pulling, but are you going to go with it...?"

"Go with what?" I ask, my eyes searching his.

He pauses, licks his lip, and then kisses me.

At first, I don't open for him, probably out of shock, but then he growls against my lips and my

arms hook around his neck. My mouth opens and his tongue dives inside, licking mine. He groans, wrapping his hands around the backs of my thighs and lifting me up. I clench them around his waist and let him carry me to wherever the hell he is carrying me to, because he's freaking kissing me.

Me. The man who hasn't kissed a girl since he was twelve years old has his tongue down my throat. There's a sense of power that comes with this revelation, and I don't really like what it triggers inside of me. Like a bonfire that has been retired for years has been doused in gasoline for the last two weeks and now with a simple kiss, it is ignited into a raging inferno that threatens to burn every single thing around me down.

He sits me on the trunk of his Lambo, spreading my legs wider with his hands and stepping between my thighs, all while not breaking the kiss. His lips are warm and feel full against mine, with every kiss he tugs on my lips roughly and then places a gentle kiss on it to calm the pain. It's uncanny how the way he kisses matches his personality. Maybe that's why he never kissed anyone, because he was afraid that in doing so his mouth would crack open parts of his soul.

He kisses me once.

Twice.

Then we start kissing all over again, tongues clashing together in a soft dance of pent-up energy.

He places another single kiss on my lips, then growls and yanks me into him where I wrap my legs around his waist again, needing to be as close as possible to him.

He finally stops after putting another three kisses down. He rests his forehead against mine, our breathing intertwining together in ragged intakes of air. "Yeah, you're not going any-fucking-where but my bed tonight."

I lick my swollen lips, missing the touch of his on mine. "Now? Take me there now."



CHAPTER SIXTEEN



“Beast (Southpaw Remix)”—Tech N9ne, Busta Rhymes

Aeron pushed Beatrice down onto the mattress, crawling up her little body like a hungry caged beast. He wants her more than he'll admit. He knew that from the moment he saw her in that damn bar, but he just didn't recognize it then, and right now wasn't the time he was going to think about it either. Because he fucking wanted her. Something deep inside of him craved her on a whole 'nother level. A level that no human had experienced much less reached—or conquered. It will be the level that would hit them with Game Over, but he wanted her that badly—and if he was reading her right, which he is very fucking good at doing—she wants him too.

A dark shadow casts over his eyes as he yanks the bow that ties her little red top together. He fucking loves this shirt. Red is his favorite color. Red is a strong color, it's the color that represents victory, revenge, and sacrifice—it is the color of blood. With a heaving breath, his finger traces down her breasts and over her nipples. He grins as she bucks and pants, begging him to make the ache go away.

Little did she know, he was going to make the pain worse before he'd take it away, and he won't take all of it away, he'll ruin her. He'll leave an ounce of pain still lingering on the surface every time he's with her—enough for her to crave him. To yearn for him, she will soon see that she has been poisoned and it was only him who was her antidote. No one else can cure her but him.

“Aeron...” she moans, his name slipping from her lips. He wants to put that into every fucking track that he's releasing just so the whole world knew that she called for him.

Correction, how she once called for him—before he tore her apart.

Aeron pumped his dick, a glistening sheen of sweat covering his skin. A bead of pre-cum lit up

the tip of his cock, so he swiped at it with his thumb, and then pressed it to her lips. She peered up at him all doe-eyed, and for a split second, he wanted to kill any motherfucker she ever looked at with those eyes. He still could. He hated that he felt this way. He was weak for this girl, it wasn't a good idea. But, fuck it.

She wraps her lips around his thumb, curving her tongue around the shape of it and slowly sucks. Aeron's eyes roll to the back of his head. "Again, Cub," he groans, reaching his breaking point. He needs to be fed. The hunger that's swimming inside of him is familiar, he's well acquainted with the feeling, but he's only ever experienced it during a hit. Never in his lifetime has he ever felt like this during sexual acts. Right now, every feral emotion and feeling is heightened, and he knew there was no way out. There is nothing stopping this now, she has awoken something that should only ever be awake when someone needs to be eradicated.

She's awoken the beast.

Beast

I suck his thumb again and watch as his fingers stretch me wide.

"Get on your elbows, Cub, watch."

His face dives between my thighs and I tilt my head back, a moan erupting out of my chest at the touch of his slick tongue against my clit. He grips my thighs and slams me into his face. "Watch!"

I obey, letting my attention stay on him.

Having his face between my legs again—only this time far more intimately—has my head spinning. I watch as his tongue drags up my slit, his eyes on mine, then he pauses.

"How many people have you fucked, Cub?" He flicks his tongue over my clit again.

"What?" I ask, but it comes out as a whisper, my clit aching to be ravished again.

He blows on it instead. "How many guys have had their dick in this sweet little cunt."

I ignore the C-bomb. "Why are you asking me this right now?" I go heavy on the 'now.'

He glares. "Answer the question."

"Shit, ah, three, I think. Almost, sort of four."

"How is there an almost sort of?" he asks, leaning on his elbow. The lighting is dim enough to shade most of his bedroom but casts the perfect beacon over his face.

"It just didn't go that far."

His finger slips inside of me and he remains still, his eyes on mine. "I'm trying to figure out which of the two fights that I'm currently battling with inside of me, I want to feed right now."

"How about the one between my legs?" I suggest, apparently not shy at all.

He laughs, his head tilting back and then he crawls up my body, his thickness pressing against my apex. He grinds his hips into me and my eyes roll to the back of my head as I bite down a moan.

"Don't fight it, Beatrice," he whispers over my lips. "I need you to scream, baby, so I'm going to fuck you hard." Then his cock slams into me, the tip of him smashing against the wall of my cervix. The pain and sting plows through me like an eruption, a dark intrusion, but when he pulls out and sinks back in, the pain slowly evaporates, and the gentle stir of desire possesses me.

He carries on with the same rhythm until sweat glistens between us as our bodies slap together. His kisses over my flesh become urgent, needy. His hands are everywhere, and his mouth is on my neck. He bites down, and the sting has me screaming out in pain, the mixture between the bite and the

pleasure pushing me to new euphoric heights—highs I never want to come down from. Highs I wouldn't mind overdosing on.

He leans up and wraps my hair in one fist, yanking my head back. He tilts his head as he pounds into me, his pelvis smashing against my clit.

I explode around him, my orgasm rippling through me in waves—waves I'm sure I'll drown in.

Pulling out of me, gripping onto my hips and flipping me onto my stomach, he slows his thrusting, and then pulls me up onto all fours and presses my head down onto the mattress as he sinks inside of me again and thrusts into me harder.

He fucks me hard and fast, my body smashing forward and then dropping backward against him in a rhythm that never loses its tune. His fingers dig into my hips as he pulls out and flips me onto my back. I look up at him, my eyes lazy from my orgasm and my body dripping in sweat. He grabs his heavy cock and pumps it. "You want this cock in your mouth, Cub?"

My eyes drop to it and I lick my lips. "Yes."

"Say it," he answers, biting his bottom lip as he goes to the edge of the bed and stands, all while his hand never stops. I follow him, crawling until I'm looking up at his muscled body and heavy cock. It glistens with my cum, his thumb grazing over the bead of pre-cum that forms on the very tip.

I lick my lips, peering up at him. "I want you in my mouth."

He chuckles, his eyes lazy. Then with his other hand, he grabs a fistful of my hair and yanks my head back, his muscles tensing with the movement. "Say cock, baby. Let me hear all the dirty words come out of that innocent little mouth."

Innocent?"

I lean forward, and even though his hand is buried in my hair, he allows it but maintains a firm and possessive grip. I draw my tongue out and wrap it around the base of his trunk. Instantly I taste myself and him mixed together, and it's the most exotic taste I've ever experienced.

He yanks me back, jarring my head. "Say it."

I lick my lip because I want him inside anywhere I can take him. "I want your dick inside of me, Aeron."

His eyes roll back, then he unleashes me, and I wrap my lips around his head and suck him down, bringing my hand to his base. I can't fit the whole thing in my mouth, so I spit on it and use my hand to twist and tug, like I watched him do.

He groans, and by God, that launches rockets inside of me that I never knew were there. It gave me a sense of power that I could bring someone so powerful, so beautiful, but most of all, so *dark*, to a place of pleasure. There's power in that.

I suck some more, and then lean down and lick his balls, peering up at him from below.

"Fuck," he cusses, and then loses it and his hand flies to below my chin, his fingers sprawling out over my cheeks. He squeezes, his eyes turning dark like storm clouds closing in. "I want to punish you, Beatrice. I need it. Give it to me."

I lick my lips and then nod softly. "Okay."

He wraps his hands around my thighs and yanks me down the bed until my legs are dangling off the edge. Then he grabs onto my hips, yanking me to standing until my palms land on the bed and I'm bent over. He kicks my legs open, and I try to look over my shoulder to see what he's doing. He takes the bandana out of his pocket, and I close my eyes, instantly knowing that he wants to blindfold me again. Only the scarf slips past my eyes and rests around my neck. He yanks on it and it tightens, choking me instantly. Then he chuckles and loosens it.

Oh God.

I don't have to see to know that he's looped the bandana into a quick slip knot. He leans over and then his tongue touches the base of my neck and trails up my spine until it comes to the back. His cock slips inside of me and I groan from the fulfillment, my head swinging back. He yanks on the bandana and pounds into me so hard I feel like my cervix is going to erupt inside my belly. A loud slap sounds out just as a sharp sting hits my ass and I scream out, my back arching from the pain. God, that hurt, but the sting slowly subsides—he hits me again, this time his palm feels so much heavier than the last. If he does it again, I'm almost certain my cheek will explode. His hand comes to the back of my neck and he flips me onto my back, dives back inside of me while stretching my legs wide, sweat dripping off our bodies. His mouth comes to my nipple and he bites it, just as he slams into me again, then his other hand grabs the scarf and tugs on it again, this time cutting off all oxygen.

Shit.

When I think he's going to let up, he leans into my ear, all while riding me and whispers, "You feel that, Cub. That's what it feels like to have your life in someone else's hands. To feel hopeless, out of control. Do you want to die, Beatrice?" he asks, pumping me harder and harder. My pussy throbs in pleasure but my face feels swollen from the lack of oxygen.

"Answer me."

I shake my head. Is he for freaking real?

He leans down and bites on my lip so hard I taste the tang of blood hit the tip of my tongue, groaning as his dick pulses inside of me. He licks the cut on my lip and looks back down at me, by this point he looks fuzzy, like I'm slipping in and out of consciousness.

"Fuck." He quickly releases the bandana and I suck in a wheezy gulp of breath, clutching my neck. It takes me a few seconds to catch my breath and I consider slapping him for taking that so far.

He removes the scarf and throws it down onto the ground as he drops beside me in a sweaty wall of flesh, both our breaths trying to catch up to one another. I wince at my sore ass, my sore neck, and my cut lip from his bite.

I decide right then that next time, it'll be me the one leaving marks on him. His arm comes behind me as his other hits the light on the bedside table.

"Fuck," he mutters, just as the light turns on. He looks at me. "Are you on the pill?"

I nod my head, my eyes still adjusting to the sudden slaughter of the brightness. "I'm on the pill—it's fine."

His eyes go over me and I self-consciously pull the sheet up to cover my body.

"Don't do that..." he warns.

His hair catches my attention, a mess on top of his head. His lips swollen from our kissing and from him being on a first name basis with my body.

"Do what?" I ask, trying to calm my breathing. He needs to stop looking at me the way he does.

"Like you're not the sexiest woman I've ever fucking seen."

I scoff but then squeeze the sheet again, my eyes darting around the room for the first time. It's all black walls and thick red stripes on the feature wall. There's a large window that is on one side of the room, giving you a direct view of the entrance to the house. The clean white sheets are soft against my skin, and the bed is built with a heavy leather headboard and trim, stretching the width of a full king size bed. There's a television in the corner, hanging on the wall, and there are two doors opposite the bed. One door I'm gathering, (and hoping), is a bathroom, and the other, I can see is a closet. A very big closet.

He slips back between the sheets, hitting the light and pulling me into his arms. "I won't hurt you if that's what you're worried about."

I sink into his arms, ignoring the fact that it feels easy being there.



CHAPTER SEVENTEEN



“Hello”—Ice Cube, Dr Dre

Manik

We’re looking over the album when Kat bursts through the door, her eyes directly aimed at me. “We need to talk.”

“Figured as much.” I gesture to the spot beside me. “Go on.”

Her eyes flick to X and Bo, and then come back to me. “You want to do this in front of them?”

I shrug. “Why not?”

“Fine!” She storms in, her hands placed on her hips defiantly. “You can’t do this.”

“Yeah, I can.” I ignore her, my knee jolting at the movement.

“She’s not like your other girls, Ae, she won’t survive you!”

“I know she’s not, Kat, so settle the fuck down and stay out of it.”

“You’ll hurt her,” she sighs, flopping down onto the coffee table, right beside the lines of coke.

“That’s undecided.”

Her eyes snap to mine. “She’s special, Ae, and if you don’t want to embrace her or even give her all of you, then you need to walk away right now.”

My eyes go flat, my expression bored. “Leave it alone.”

“You kissed her...” she further adds, and the guys shuffle in the background.

“What can I say, her lips are undeniable.”

She stands, flattening her skirt and making her way to the door. “I will never forgive you if this is

some sort of sick game between you and Dad, Ae. Ever.”

Then she leaves, slamming the door behind her. What the fuck did she mean a sick game between me and Dad. For all she knows, the reason Dad doesn’t like Beat is because he can see my concentration is drifting. He’s never warned me off a girl before, and maybe that’s what makes Beatrice so fucking special.

I follow Katiya out, chasing her down the stairs. “Hold up!”

She spins around, her eyes furious. What the fuck is with her lately? She usually goes through obsessions and phases but this seems like it’s a little deeper than that. “Did you know that Dad went to her work, Ae?”

I freeze. “What?”

Katiya laughs smugly. “Yeah, a couple nights ago when she was working. He swore her off you. Said she wasn’t to go near you and then asked her about her childhood. So, you tell me right now, Ae that you have nothing to do with this, because something doesn’t sit right with me...”

I think over her words. “You’re right, I have nothing to do with whatever this is, but you’re both thinking too much into it. He’s just worried I’ll stray.” I’m a fucking liar.

She shakes her head, gripping onto the stair rail. “No. This is way more than that and you know it.”

I don’t actually.

I cross my arms in front of myself.

Lenny clears his throat from down at the bottom of the stairs. “Bro, honestly, why’d he suggest we go to that particular bar that night? Why that bar out of all the others?”

I clench my jaw. “I figured he was making an innocent suggestion.” *I knew why.*

“—This is Dad, Aeron.” It’s the first time I’ve really seen fear in Kat’s face.

The front door swings open and Beat glides through, pushing her sunglasses up to the top of her head. My eyes catch hers and she smiles, but then she looks to Kat and Lenny and her face falls.

“What’d I miss in the five minutes I was on the phone?”

I jog down the stairs, needing her close to me for reasons I’m not willing to touch on right now. “Why didn’t you tell me about my dad coming to your work?”

I grab her hand and then turn to face her toward the main living room. Lenny and Kat follow closely behind us.

“Sit.” I point to the large black leather sofa. Beatrice sits down and Katiya drops right beside her. Lenny leans against the mantel above the built-in fireplace. I continue. “Why didn’t you tell me?”

Beat gazes at Katiya and then looks back at me. “Ah, I got distracted. I was planning to tell you, but then—”

“—I get it,” I cut her off, casting a quick side glance at Lenny, who is watching me carefully. “I know.”

Lenny nods and then looks at Kat. “Something’s going on. Vlad was the one who told us to go to that bar that night. He planted the idea in our heads—something he never does. He hates when we party—that should have been our first clue.”

“Why the hell did this pass you, Ae?” Kat sneers at me. Because some shit you don’t need to know...

I don’t say that though.

“Point those fucking eyes elsewhere, baby sister, and because I was loaded.”

She rolls her eyes. “Get off the snow.”

Beat looks between us all. “What does this all mean?”

Kat leans back on the sofa, her eyes on mine as she answers. “It means my dad is up to something.”

Yeah, let’s stick with that. For now.



CHAPTER EIGHTEEN



“Still D.R.E”—Dr Dre, Snoop.

Beat

“This is weird, right?” I ask as I squeeze into a pair of black skinny jeans.

Ae tosses my jacket to me and I flick my long hair out from under it. “Nah, it’s not what you think. We go almost every year when they come. It’s not actually a circus, and it is definitely not for children.”

I button up my long coat before putting my coconut lip balm on my lips. I rub them together. “And Kat didn’t want to come this year—why?” I ask, tilting my head and trying to ignore how sexy he looks in his dark blue Henley and dark jeans. Everything is dark except his polished white high top sneakers.

He tucks the black bandana into his back pocket, the same one I’ve seen him wear almost every time we’ve been somewhere. It’s always on him, or around him, or somewhere close to him. It’s only really now that I’ve noticed its presence.

He shakes his head, walking toward me and pulling me under his arm as he leads us out his door and down the hallway. “She’s occupied, babe. Why? You can’t go one night without your other half?”

I flush because he’s right. Me asking where Kat is, is stupid. This is the first night Aeron and I have been out together—ever, and it was just last week that we were all sitting around in his sitting room trying to figure out his dad’s next move. I can’t ignore the obvious. Something shifted since that night, because Kat didn’t come back to Aeron’s, she disappeared somewhere and I haven’t seen her

since. This time I've been keeping in contact with Kyle, so thankfully, I'm not a missing person case, but he says he hasn't seen her much either, but that she has been staying there.

I slide into the passenger seat of his car and wait patiently as he gets into the driver's side.

"Is there something I should know?" I ask, watching for his reaction. Sure, so he and I are very new and to be honest, I know that I won't be jumping into anything one-hundred percent with him, if ever. But for right now, I think we're both just taking it as it is—despite Katiya's reservations about me getting hurt, I'm stronger than she thinks.

"No," he answers, flooring it.

We drive for around thirty minutes, the music changing between his old music and other artists. We pull up to a long dark road where streetlights are surging, and the wind seems thicker. He slows down and smirks at me. "You ready, Cub?"

"For a circus?" I ask, eyebrow quirked.

He chuckles, but it was a deep, lazy rumble. "Yeah, babe, *just* a circus."

There are a few lines of cars that are parked on a big old football field. To the right, I see neglected seating, benches, and an old hot dog stand. Aeron parks us beside another car and I watch as people start getting out of their vehicles.

"Where is it?" I ask, confused as to why people are exiting their cars but there's no bright yellow or orange tent anywhere in sight. In fact, everything is dark outside. There's a single streetlight that hangs beside the seating and over the old hot dog stand but other than that, to the front of us where the massive field is, it's black.

I feel Aeron's hand come to mine, his thumb grazing over my knuckles. "You trust me, Cub?"

"No..." I answer truthfully. I wish I could see his face. I reach for my phone in my pocket to turn my flashlight on when his hand comes to mine, halting my movements.

"Good that you don't, but can you go with it tonight and trust me enough to do that?"

I ponder the question, a quick glance to the digital clock on the dashboard telling me it's 11:58 p.m.—as in almost midnight.

I swallow past my nervousness and nod my head. "Yes."

His lips warm over mine and my hand comes to the back of his neck, wanting more out of the kiss that he's taunting me with. My stomach is flipping and my head aches from the overload of what is happening between us, but it feels good. It feels good to swim in the danger zone, as long as you know where the exit routes are.

"Come on." He opens his door and I follow suit, catching the clock one last time before I climb out completely.

12:00 a.m.

Bright lights flash in front of me in a sudden assault. Thick tea lights are braided into the structure of the tent, rising up to showcase the tip and arches, with a thrashing of lights dangling delicately.

Midnight Mayhem reads above the door in bright white neon scripted in a cursive font. The tea lights that line the tent are a shining lilac pastel, not the conventional white. The sign **Midnight Mayhem** in itself is like a clean promise of something extraordinary.

"Wow," I whisper, in awe already.

Aeron tucks me under his arm as we follow the crowd, moving closer to the tent. "I'll ask you again," he whispers into my neck as we finally reach the front of the entry—now it looks a lot bigger than it did before, making me feel like a mere subject in their show.

Two guards stand on either side of the archway, both wearing masquerade masks, shirtless with

oil spread over their rippling chests, dark slacks and dress shoes. They look striking, yet intimidating. There is no welcome. No smiling faces to greet their guests.

Aeron is right, this circus isn't like the others. I can feel it already and we haven't even stepped inside yet.

Aeron hands one of them our tickets, I watch as his eyes widen on Ae, and then come to me before they go back. He nods, nudging his head toward the dark small bubble-shaped hallway. It's more of a greeting than anyone else got from them so that says something.

"This circus isn't like others for a few reasons—all of which you will learn tonight." Aeron directs me down the dark pathway as my eyes catch a small warm lilac and white glow at the end of the aisle, a shimmer of excitement igniting inside of me. "But the most important thing is that they don't use animals to perform. At all."

"Really?" I whisper, because I feel like any sound of a voice would be an invasion to the illusion, even though it hasn't started yet. The magic is in the atmosphere; the walls carrying the residue from all of the mystic acts that have happened in the past. It's dream-like and hypnotizing. "So, what performs?"

"Them. They are the subjects because they *choose* to be. Animals don't get that choice. Midnight Mayhem is smashing the level of mediocre that is in a usual circus."

"Two hours of trapeze? I don't know, I feel like that could get boring."

We finally reach the end, and the bright lilac light is now a soft warm glow that carries out over the seating. My eyes go to the ring, waist-high whiteboards barricading it around, but leaving the seating just on the other side.

"We're ringside," Aeron says, gesturing for me to sit at our assigned seating. The ring floor is black and there are silver stars that ring the outside rim. My mouth drops open as I take in everything. The trapeze is all assembled to the roof, locked and ready to drop, and the lilac main curtains are drooped shut with a gold rope tied to perfection.

Everything about the atmosphere feels elegant but questionable. I gaze up to the roof, to see it's plastered in black with bright white stars glowing against it.

Aeron's arm hooks around my back as he pulls me into him. "I'll ask you again..." Ae whispers into my ear, biting down on my lobe. "You ready, Cub?"

A woman comes out in a tight purple leotard looking suit over white tights and a red tight little jacket on. She seems to be in her early to mid-forties, holding a mic and wearing a high red top hat with over exaggerated makeup. You could see she was beautiful though, even more so with the onslaught of the bright lighting directly on her face.

"Hello, ladies and gentlemen and welcome to Midnight Mayhem, where witching hour is no myth. I'm Delila Patrova and I'll be here all night to make sure you're enjoying yourself. If you are new this year, might I remind you that there is a no photo rule that applies during the entirety of the show. This is to not only protect our performers and their identity but to also preserve our originality. People like to say that Midnight Mayhem is a circus, but it's not. It's Midnight Mayhem, I just hope you're ready to lose your mind..." She fades in and out, flicking in and out until eventually, she disappears in a cloud of smoke.

"What just happened?" I whisper to Aeron, who is watching my face closely.

A spotlight explodes in the middle of the ring as the heavy curtains raise slowly, giving a sneak into what might lie behind it. A sharp silhouette of a woman is there, her posture bent in a way that has my skin crawling.

Another light flashes onto her and she bends all the way into the bridge position before crawling

—in the same way—out to the middle of the ring. Strands of orchestrated piano and violin music starts playing in the most uncomfortable tune I have ever heard. A tune that reminds me of a widow in black, crying near a corpse. The music pauses, and her body slowly comes up to a standing position from the ground. She turns to face the crowd, her face still, somber and deflated. She has platinum blonde hair that flows perfectly down from the high ponytail it's in and big blue eyes.

She lifts her leg up, straight into standing splits and curls it, looking out toward the crowd.

After the blonde, the crowd goes silent as a large square cage is wheeled into the ring. Fog dances around the ground in flickering red strobe lights, I gaze at Aeron briefly, excitement coursing through me.

He grins. “Yeah, you’ll like this part...”

Then his fingers slip under the front of my jeans and I freeze at his cool flesh touching my bare skin.

I close my eyes, biting on my lip to stop a moan, and when I open them, there are two girls strapped to the inside of the cage, a MX bike, three half-naked men, and a stick that's on fire being flicked around.

Ho boy.



CHAPTER NINETEEN



“Violent”—Obie Trice

Beat

“Oh my God I’m so late.” I rush around Aeron’s room, trying to find all of my clothes.

He rubs his eyes clear and shakes his head. “What’s the time?”

“It’s twelve, I’m supposed to be at work in twenty minutes!” Most of my clothes are already here because I’ve been here for three weeks now, but last night I didn’t expect to sleep for so long. I’ve been getting good sleep here, which is the excuse I’ve been feeding Kyle every time I need to go home to get something.

Being at Midnight Mayhem was a game changer for me, and for us. Being with Aeron alone and in the open like that. People recognized him, sure, but he didn’t hide the fact that I was with him. His hand was always on mine and his arm was always draped over my shoulders or around my waist. His lips were almost always touching my flesh and then there was the cage scene, and then the trickster’s scene...

I don’t know whether to be ashamed or worried by the events that happened during the show.

He reaches for his car keys and throws them to me, flopping back down onto the bed with his arm covering his face and the sheet only just hiding his waist enough that I can see he’s naked—if I didn’t already know. “Take my car, but don’t fucking leave without kissing me.”

A big smile comes to my face, not from taking his ridiculous car, but his words. As I said, Midnight Mayhem was a major game changer for us. I realized that maybe his way of not talking about

it is his way of declaring it. Not all people are vocal with their feelings, Manik quite obviously included, but I'm willing to work with it. With him. With whatever it is that we will need.

I jump onto the bed, straddling his waist and his arm drops away from his face, his hair messy and disheveled on the top of his head and his eyes lazy from sleep.

Gosh. How? How can someone be so effortlessly flawless? "How are you so perfect?" I ask him, watching as his lips part and his tongue slips out to moisten them.

"I'm not perfect, baby..."

I nod. "Yes, you are." Him calling me baby has my ovaries exploding. I don't know if I'm going to survive this.

"No, I'm not." His hands fall to my backside and he squeezes. "The word perfect is a flawed word in itself, because perfection doesn't exist. It's a word lazy people use to describe other people."

"I think it does..." I answer, wrapping my fingers behind the back of his neck.

"You only think I'm perfect because you haven't seen my soul."

I press my finger to his lip, over the curve that dips onto the bottom. "I don't care if you've done bad things, Aeron."

His eyes narrow, searching mine. He exhales. "That's because your brain isn't capable of thinking of the horrific things I've done, Cub. If you could, you'd run and there's no doubt about that at all, but if you did run, I'd chase you, so don't even fucking think about it. Just saying."

I kiss his lips and then climb off, remembering I'm now *super* late for work. "I'll see you later?"

He nods his head. "Yeah, babe, we'll come in tonight and I'll drive us home."

I rush down the stairs, the keys dangling in my fingers as I quickly rake my hair into a messy top knot. I'm shoving my Chuck Taylors on when the front door opens and Vlad walks through.

His eyes fall on me and then drag up and down my body.

Shit.

Shoving his hands into his pockets, he tilts his head. "I thought I was clear about my message the other week, Beatrice." He's wearing a black suit with a black dress shirt underneath and a bright green tie. It's an emerald color that looks photoshopped enough to give away all of the bright pigments in one tone...

Strong hands clench together on our kitchen table. The man wore a suit like the ones Daddy wears. He has a bright green button that sits on his cuff. The green is so bright, I squeeze my eyes closed to try to block it out. I don't like that green, even though it is a lot like my eye color.

"I'm sorry, I'm late for work," I say, trying to step past him. He scares me, like holy hell he frightens me, but my flight or fight impulse is kicking in hard and I quite like living, so I'm going to try and run.

Just as I step out the door, his words stop me. "You're on your last warning, Corvo." Then he shuts the door and I'm left standing there for a few seconds, wondering when exactly he decided to give me a pet name. I rush to Aeron's car and make my way to the bar.



CHAPTER TWENTY



“The Hardest Mutha Fukas”—Kurupt

Manik

“Syn, get up.” Dad walks into my room like he fucking owns it.

“Wow, not even going to knock? Or are you getting senile in your old age?”

Dad stops and looks over my body. “This isn’t a joke, Syn. We need to talk so get dressed and I’ll meet you in your office.”

“You mean the studio. I’ll meet you up there.”

He hesitates but leaves through the door that is in my room which further takes you to the studio.

I rub my hand through my hair, licking my lips and savoring the taste of Beat still on the tip of my tongue. I don’t know what’s going on between her and me, but whatever the fuck it is, I like it, and I’m a greedy bastard because I take what the fuck I want for as long as I want, and right now, that’s her.

I get out of bed and throw my jean shorts on, going commando, grab my smokes from the bedside drawer and my lighter and then quickly dash into the bathroom to brush my teeth. I’m climbing the obscure stairs when Dad starts in.

“Syn.” He looks directly at me as I light up my smoke and inhale.

“Yeah? What’s up, old man?”

He ignores my mouth. “End this shit with Beatrice Kennedy. You’ve had your fun, now do what you’re so good at and move on.”

I inhale deeply and blow smoke out of my nose and mouth. “Not quite done with her yet, Pops,

and what's with you paying her a visit at her work?" I watch his expression, his reaction. Dad is old school Russian Bratva. I mean, his dad—my pops—was the OG Krestny Otets back in Russia and my family crime lineage goes right back to the founding brothers in the Tsars. In other words, Dad isn't human, he's not even the same race as the rest of us. No one walking this earth can decipher anything from him. If he's hiding something from you, you will never find it. He only shows what he wants to display, but I throw it out there and ask him anyway because why the fuck not.

"To tell her to stay away..." Dad says, leaning forward. He takes a seat on the sofa and I follow suit.

"Is there something you feel like you need to tell me? Because I gotta say, I got nothing. You have Kat scared too, and just FYI, you should probably have the same talk with her. She has permanently attached herself to Beatrice."

Dad is silent, which isn't something new. Dad doesn't speak unless his words are of value. I look at him. "Is there something I need to know?" He fucking knows there is.

Spit it out, old man.

He seems to ponder my words, and then shakes his head, getting to his feet and patting my shoulder. "You know what, son, no, not right now. You keep doing what you're doing."

He goes to walk out the door.

"So now you're a fan?" I ask, flicking the end of my smoke with my thumb.

Dad chuckles softly, and it's enough to raise every fucking warning flag I have inside of me.

This isn't good.

"Yeah, Syn. *Naslazhdat'sya.*"

He just Russian'ed me.

Shit.

As soon as he leaves, I take my phone out of my pocket and dial Kat.

She answers on the first ring. "Yes?"

"We got a problem."

"Oh? A you problem or a me problem?" she brazenly asks.

"It's an US problem because it involves Cub. Where are you, by the way? Haven't seen you for weeks." I put my smoke out in the ashtray and make my way back down to my room.

"Uh, just with a friend. Okay, I'll be up soon and we can talk."

I hang up on her.



CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE



“Thugs Get Lonely”—Nate Dogg

Beat

The music is pounding and the drinks are pouring. Kyle is in a good mood too, dancing around the bar as he pours drinks.

“You’re overly nice tonight,” I tease, twisting the bottle and putting it back on the rack.

He winks. “I’m always nice.”

“No, you’re not.” I shake my head, smiling at him.

The song switches to some mash-up of rap and electro house and Kyle saunters toward me, pulling me into his chest and inhaling. “Promise not to say anything?”

I cross my heart. “Promise.”

“Okay, it’s—”

“—Watch those hands, bruh,” Aeron says from the other side of the bar, cutting off whatever Kyle was about to tell me.

I roll my eyes, leaning over and kissing him on the lips. “Hey you.”

He grins. “Hey. Is he going to be a problem for me, or...?”

Katiya slaps Manik and then crosses her arms. “He’s with *me*, so no...”

“Wait!” I throw my finger up. “Really?” I look between the two of them, my smile breaking across my face.

Kyle shrugs and I laugh, hitting him with the back of my hand. “You could have texted that!”

He shrugs again, grabbing Kat by the face and laying a fat one on her.

I shake my head in amazement. I hope it stays like this and doesn't go back to them wanting to kill each other, or I'll have to kill them both. There. Problem solved.

Manik grabs my hand and I watch as Lenny leads the rest of his entourage up to the VIP lounge. "You gonna be okay? The boys wanna throw some bills around. I can stay down here if you want?"

I shake my head and wave him away. "It's fine. Go."

He leaves, and I'm left with a cheesy looking Kyle.

We're both heading to the back of the bar to restock when he asks the question. "So, you and the infamous Manik, huh?"

I wave him off. "It's new, but yes. I think. Although, we haven't exactly had the talk."

"Talk, shmalk. Kat says that she's never *ever* seen him like this with a girl. That's got to account for something."

"Maybe," I agree, but then add. "Or maybe it's a game."

He tsks me, wiggling his finger. "Not enough trust, baby."

He's probably right, but trust is earned and I'm not sure if mind-blowing sex and strange dates should be the gauge you use to measure how much you trust someone.

Then again, I'm not exactly experienced in the boyfriend department. I had one boyfriend in high school when I was a junior. We stayed together until senior year and then we decided to go separate ways before college. To be honest, it's probably because what we had died out before then. It was so easy to let Rob go. The thought of letting Aeron go? I don't like it. That alone has too much power over me.

Work goes fast, probably because I know that Manik is upstairs and every now and then, I catch him watching me. He blows me a kiss or winks or smirks, and every time he does it my body hits high temperatures. It's as though Manik is another punishment to women—thanks to Eve eating the apple. Not that I'm religious, because I'm not, but if I was, I'd say he was a punishment. Because he can make you feel things, and then take them away.

Everyone has emptied out of the bar and I'm just locking the doors when I exit and find Manik is waiting near his car.

"Ready?" he asks, flipping his keys around in his hand.

I nod, my mind swimming in all sorts of shit. I climb into the passenger seat and buckle my belt.

He must see my face because he asks, "What's up?"

I shake my head, then turn to face him. "Okay, it's just. This is the very spot we first met and you kidnapped me... Aeron *kidnapped* me. Now? Now you're like my..."

"...boyfriend?" he asks, ending my sentence for me.

"Er, I don't know? Are you?"

He exhales, leaning against the door. The light from the headlights and the radio is hitting the sharp angles of his features. "Are we doing this?" he grumbles. "Fine, we'll do this." His hand comes to my chin and he yanks my face back to his when I try to look away. He searches my eyes. "The thought of anyone else touching you makes me fucking feral, Cub. And I don't mean that in the same bullshit way that most other men mean that, I mean that as in I'll straight up murder any motherfucker that so much as looks at you for too long, so... to answer your question? Yeah, I'm your man, but make no mistake, you are mine and I don't play nice with other people trying to get into my sandbox—you feel me?"

"Ahh..." I swallow my nerves. I didn't expect something so brutally honest, but then it's Aeron,

he's always sort of honest, right? I hope so...

He chuckles. "Yeah, you get it. Now let's get food, I'm fucking hungry."

The next night we're lying in bed watching the reruns of Peaky Blinders.

"He's so hot," Kat says from the floor where she's wrapped in a blanket and shoving popcorn into her mouth.

I snort, climbing out of the bed to crawl down to grab some popcorn before she eats it all, and it's sweet and salty—my favorite—when I answer, "Agreed."

"Wait, what?" Manik snaps from behind me. I'm wearing nothing but one of his 'I'm a Maniak' shirts that his little fangirls usually wear and lace black panties. Kat has seen me in less, but you can't see much anyway because of the length of the shirt. I lean over the bed, ass in the air and grab a handful of popcorn.

"Aye!" A hard slap stings across my ass cheek.

"Yelp!" I scream, dropping the popcorn and turning to face him. "What was that for!"

Kat laughs, shoving more popcorn into her mouth. "Took the bait, Ae, I gotta say, this shit is too amusing and too easy with her around."

"What bait?"

"You think he's hot? And fuck you, Kat."

She flips him off over her shoulder. "I still won that one."

"Um, yes? Because he is..."

"Yeah?" he counters, and his face morphs into triumph. "Come here and say that, Cub. See what happens..."

"Okaaayyy." Kat stands, stretching her arms wide. "I'm drawing the line at this shit." She snatches the remote and tosses it onto the bed. "Night, lovers."

The next morning, my eyes open onto the light that is breaking through the gaps of the window blinds. I stretch my arms wide up above when I notice Manik is perched on his elbows, watching me carefully. His blue eyes piercing and bright.

"What's wrong?" I ask, wondering why he's awake before me.

"Dad's here again. This isn't a good sign, so I'll drop you off at your place for a bit so I can sort it all out."

"By it, you mean your dad?" I ask, pushing the covers off my body.

"Yeah," he growls, his voice still lazy from sleep. "I'll make it up to you later. Take you to that new restaurant over near the valleys."

I wave him off, raking my hair back from my face and walking into the bathroom. I shut the door behind me, splashing warm water over my face. I'm getting really bad at being late for work.



He drops me off at home and I rush up the steps, a smile on my face. The door swings open before I reach it and Kyle is standing there with a cheesy look on his face.

“Well, hello, lover girl!”

I push him away as I walk through, tossing my gym bag onto the floor. “Don’t start.”

He shuts the door behind himself and shakes his head. “I didn’t say anything.”

I roll my eyes, heading into the kitchen to find something to eat. I settle for pancakes, so I take everything out of the cupboard that I will need and start whisking it all up, ignoring the fact that I’m ignoring Kyle.

He clears his throat, pulling out a bar stool behind me. I haven’t turned to face him, because I don’t want to. He’s either going to tell me I’m a fool or he’s going to make fun of me. Both of which, I cannot deal with right now.

“Kermit, it’s okay to feel this way.”

I scoff, pouring the batter onto the hot skillet and watching as bubbles start to slowly pop on the surface.

“I know, but it’s not the good feelings I’m worried about, it’s the bad ones.”

“You can’t think like that,” Kyle says gently. I continue flipping pancakes, deciding what I want for toppings while doing so. “You’ve just got to chill, B.”

Great talk, I thought to myself as I blocked out the rest of his pointless words. I know that Kyle is worried, but now that he’s with Kat, I’m almost certain his opinion—a very unwanted one—is void.

Three hours later, we’re both ‘laxing out in the lounge room watching more *Peaky Blinders* when someone starts banging on the front door. It’s so loud that I jump to my feet instantly, my heart pounding in my chest. Kyle rushes off to answer it, and I don’t have to wait long to know who it is.

“Kat?” I ask as she rushes through the doors, her eyes locked solely on me. They’re rimmed with purple and red circles, tears pouring down her cheeks. Her hair is a knotted mess everywhere and she has no shoes on. “Are you okay? Where’s your key?” I ask, worried.

She swipes at her face, her movements frantic. She’s not okay. Maybe she’s on drugs. “You need to leave, Beat. Now.”

I search her eyes, confused. “Leave? To where?”

She screams in frustration and then turns and starts running up the stairs. I leap to my feet and follow her with Kyle hot on my heels.

“Kat?” I try again, entering my bedroom as she’s throwing clothes into a suitcase. “You need to leave, Beatrice. Now. You—you...”

“I *what*?” I hiss, snatching the clothes from her and putting them back down. “I don’t understand what you’re trying to say, so slow down.”

She exhales. “Listen, I have cash, I have everything you need to run, but I need you to leave, Beat. Leave. This. City.”

“What the fuck is going on?” Kyle asks, his anger evident in his tone and language.

Kat pleads with me. She looks broken. “The weird thing is you don’t even know!”

I look between her and Kyle. “I don’t even know, what?”

She swipes at her tears again but continues to pack my suitcase. “You... there’s stuff you don’t know about yourself, Beatrice. One” —she throws more clothes in—“is that your real name isn’t Beatrice Kennedy.”

I suck in a breath. “What? Don’t be ridiculous.”

“It’s Amaya Corvo. You won’t remember because it happened so long ago and you are sheltered by nature. Your father, Beat? Your father was Garth Corvo, your mother was Lauren Corvo. They were notorious in the Italian mafia and he was the capo of their family...”

My head spins, and my legs shake so I quickly grab onto the bed, taking a seat. “No, that’s not right. My parents were Jessica and Robert Kennedy. My dad worked in the mines in Perth and my mom was an artist and sold her paintings to cafes and studios all over Australia and Sydney.”

I fist the blankets on the bed. “I know this for a fact. I know my parents.”

I can’t see anything, no one looks right. All I hear is Kat’s voice and the pounding of my heart behind the deep echo in my brain. “I’m sorry, Beat, but it’s not true. I can explain more to you but can I please continue to pack your shit?”

I look at her and see the frenzied look in her eyes. Why would Kat lie to me? She wouldn’t. I trust her, so I nod my head and move away from what she’s doing. I should be the one packing, but I can’t get my legs to move. They’re cemented to the spot from shock.

“Your parents died when you were eight years old, Beat, now some of the story I didn’t catch, like what actually happened, but I caught some of it. Your parents had been on the run since you were just small. There was a war that happened between my family and yours, I don’t know the full gist of it, but I got the feeling that my father really didn’t like your dad for reasons I don’t know.”

“I can’t...” I squeeze the blankets again as tears fall down my face. “If this is all true, where is Manik? Why isn’t he here telling me?”

She pauses, and then slowly zips up the suitcase, shooting Kyle a quick look before coming back to me. “After the war which, by the way, is how you obtained that scar on your neck, your parents up and moved to Australia with no protection because they left the mafia. Your dad, who was how your mom got involved in the mob, ran from the family. They didn’t care, they knew he wasn’t going to snitch so they let them go.”

“Okay... say this is all true.” I touch the scar on my neck absently, hoping it’s all lies. *I fell off a playground swing as a child.* “Where is Manik?”

“I’m getting there, and after I tell you, Beat, you have to *run* and I mean you have to *run far*. I have friends I can get you to. For reasons I don’t know, you came back to New Orleans, where the war started, putting you back on my dad’s radar. Anyway,” she pauses. “Aeron was eleven when he made his first kill. Then three months later, he made his next ones.”

I wait for her to carry on.

“Beatrice.” Her hand comes to mine. “We need to leave and that’s all you need to know to get out of this house right now. Aeron is after you... and he’s going to come fast. Come on, I managed to slip past without them knowing I heard them.”

My heart snaps in my chest at her words, my sobbing turning to unrestrained ugly crying. “No, this can’t be.”

“Beatrice, we need to move. Now.”

I shake my head. “He wouldn’t...”

“Oh, he would. Beat, my brother may care about you up to a point, but make no mistake, my father and the Bratva come first. Always. I’ll tell you more on the way, but we need to leave.”

I have to run, I see it in the look in her eye. Run so fast and far that he will never find me.

I’ve lived all my life running, with the freedom of being able to jump city to city and town to town, I just didn’t expect to have my life being threatened act as the gasoline getting me there now.

PART 2

In the dark is where wilted flowers grow,
they get watered with the blood of his
enemies and the fluid from my broken heart.



CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO



“American Psycho 2”—D12

Manik

She has sparked a fire inside of me that has my hands shaking with the need for vengeance, needing to finish something that should have been finished a long time ago.

She is a mistake. Something that should have been caged and slaughtered.

I crane my neck, looking at myself in the reflection. My eyes are untamed, like a beast that has finally been let off its leash.

I hit the tap and let the water pour over my battered hands when there's a knock on the door.

“What?” I snap, not looking toward it.

“Back in, Ae, no fucking around.”

I clench my jaw, tossing the torn hand towel onto the soiled floor and swinging the door open.

One of the measly soldiers is standing there, his shoulders somewhat tight and his head held high with a false sense of confidence that is about... one...

His eyes connect with mine.

His fall to the ground.

Two...

They come back to me, his shoulders shake.

Three...

I grin.

Snap.

Three seconds away from breaking.

He exhales. “Okay, please just get back in the cage. You’re not done yet—you know the rules.”

I don’t flinch or blink, my hand flying up to his throat where I spin around and slam him up against the concrete wall. “One, don’t fucking tell me what the rules are, motherfucker, or I’ll throw you in *my* cage and show you exactly why they call me Zver...”

His eyes close and his face swells to an intricate contrast of purples and pinks. I laugh, tilting my head. “I might do it anyway. Excited to see you crumble under my hand, and as you know, I’ve got a lot of pent-up anger inside of me. A whole fucking nineteen years’ worth.”

“—Zver, let him go. Now.” My father’s voice claps into the atmosphere like comets crashing over the sky.

I spin around to face him, seething, my shoulders going up and down with every inhale and exhale of breath. “I’m ready.”

He looks at me and brushes off his clean suit that doesn’t belong in The Pen, because he doesn’t fucking belong in The Pen. The leaking roof unleashes droplets of sewage water onto my flesh. “I’m ready,” I repeat, putting more power into my words.

He steps closer to me, pushing his hands into his pockets. “I don’t think you are. I think you’re still my Syn and not the Zver I need you to be...”

There are four versions of me. Aeron, Manik, Syn—who is me when my father needs me as a son—and Zver—who my father, the family, and anyone else who needs it gets—that hides behind the bandana.

“I’m ready.” I try once more. This time looking directly into his empty eyes.

He glares directly back into mine and whispers. “Beatrice Kennedy.”

My lip twitches.

“You’re not fucking ready.” Then he turns back to his soldiers. “Throw him back into his pen.”

I roar forward, baring my teeth. “Don’t you fucking touch me!”

Dad leans in once six of his soldiers are holding me back. “I will take all of that humanity out of you, Syn, I’ve done it before and I can do it again.”



CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE



“Put it on me”—DJ Quik

Beat

Amaya held onto her dad’s hand as he looked back at her, worry etched on his face. He looked back at Lauren, closing his eyes. “We should never have run, Lauren. We should have stayed, at least we would be protected.”

“Protected?” she whispered, and Beatrice could tell that her mom was upset. It made fear creep up her throat. Her mom was hardly ever upset. She always had a smile on her face and always wore bright red lipstick, it didn’t matter the time of the day.

“Yes, Lauren.”

She laughed, shaking her head. A loud bang sounded on the other side of the door. To Amaya, it sounded like fireworks—even though they were banned in Australia, Amaya liked to watch them on TV and on New Year’s Eve every year.

Lauren screamed, her hands coming up to cover her ears. The door slammed open and a big man stood there with a machete hanging from his hand. He wore a dark suit and a bright green tie around his neck.

“You think you can run and we would not find you?” the man said, but Amaya started crying, crawling up on the bed to contain her sobs.

Amaya’s father stood in front of her, his shoulders squared in protection. “This is between you and me, Vlad, leave Lauren and Amaya out of it. You let them go, and you can have me...” Garth

tried to make his plea as appealing as he could. "It was me who put the bullet between your wife's eyes during that war. Just me, not Amaya, she's suffered enough from that scar."

Vlad swung the machete up and gouged it into Garth's throat. Blood squirted out everywhere, splashing Amaya across the face until she could taste her father's blood in her mouth. Lauren screamed a scream that reached the depths of hell, launching herself at Vlad, who then swung her onto the ground, beside Garth. Just then, Amaya saw two smaller legs enter just behind Vlad. Her eyes traveled up his body, taking in the suit that was exactly like Vlad's only smaller. When her eyes reached his, something crawled up inside of her throat. A black bandana was tied around the bottom layer of his face, but his eyes, Amaya thought she would remember them for years to come. And maybe she would have if what she witnessed next didn't send her body into long-term PTSD.

The boy, his eyes were like the ocean, bright blue on the surface, but you knew underneath was where the monsters swam, and where the water changed from a bright glistening blue to a dark gloomy green. He looked directly at Amaya, then down to her parents.

"Zver, go on."

The boy looked back at me, and then looked back down to the floor. He tilted his head as he watched my mom place soft kisses on my dad's lips. Her mouth never left his. The boy scoffed as if the kissing offended him, and then pulled out a dagger, not as long as the one his father used, but intimidating enough. He pulled it back with such strength it had Amaya gasping, and hoping that maybe he would slip and drop it. But he didn't drop it.

He sliced it right through Lauren's face, splitting it into two and then sunk it into her throat, ending her instantly. He then turned back to Garth, who was struggling for breath.

"That's it, Zver, take back your vengeance. Let this girl feel how it is to lose not just one parent, but two." The boy swung the dagger up in the air, and then buried it through Garth's throat, cutting his head clean off. The boy tilted his head at a small baby lion plush toy that was on the bed, surrounded by pink and yellow pillows, while swiping the blood from his blade onto his jacket.

Amaya by this point didn't speak. She sat in the corner of her bed, her eyes wide open on her mom and dad's bodies, her lip quivering and tears streaming down her face.

She wanted to scream, she wanted to scream loud enough that it brought her parents back from death, but when she tried to open her mouth, it was numb. Frozen shut. Her mind was sifting through images of her parents being alive just minutes ago. She thought this must be a joke. A movie—even. This didn't just happen.

Footsteps thudded closer to her bed, but she still didn't look at the man wearing the green tie. "Amaya Corvo, such a sweet little girl."

Amaya saw the boy step to her bed out of the corner of her eye, but she again, didn't look. Stifled on the mess in front of her eyes. Her mommy and daddy, dead. Motionless.

Vlad threw his hand up to stop the boy from getting closer to Amaya. "No, Zver. I have a plan for this one. She will have her time."

Then Amaya finally looked up to Vlad, blinking through the tears. She still couldn't open her mouth—rendered speechless.

Vlad finished what he was going to say anyway. "Your time will come, Amaya, and mark my words—your fate is always going to be in my hands."

I scream, launching myself out from my bed, sweat seeping from my skin and my head throbbing from my dream. Only they weren't dreams, they were in fact memories. Memories I had

subconsciously squashed down after the trauma of seeing both of my parents slaughtered.

My tears stream down my face and I squeeze the blanket close to me, terrified by what might happen.

“Hey!” someone says from deep in the dark. “Fucking keep it down, lady! Just because we don’t have a bed doesn’t mean we don’t like to sleep.”

I go to apologize but instead lay back down on a soiled mattress, a mattress that I was thankful to get. I’ve been living under the bridge in a small town south of New York City for coming up on a month now. He killed my parents, and now he’s going to kill me. I can’t risk using my money, or cards because that will give him access to my location, so instead, I spend my time curled up under a damp bridge, watching as normal people go for their daily walks and runs. The more I watch from the distance, the more I slipped from normality. I had taken myself out of the equation and now I’m not sure how I’ll ever get back in.

It’s damp under here. Dark and gloom is what surrounds us. There’s a small creek that runs under the bridge and the bridge itself offers us all enough shelter should we need it on the rainy days. A large garbage can, used as a fire pit, is almost completely out, the embers turning to a soft gray ash from the night before.

I stretch up, pushing my clothes down my body and head for the stream.

It’s been one month since I got in that car with Kat and let her take me away. I promised that I’d keep in touch with her, use cash and all that sort of thing. She even put me in a hotel and said she’d pay for it until we figured out a way to get my money, but I couldn’t allow her to do that. She needed to truly not know where I was in order for me to feel that she was going to be somewhat safe. I didn’t go to her friend’s place either.

It hurt, it hurt so bad to let her go, but I did, to an extent.

I splash the cool water over my face, waking me up from my crap sleep and in an attempt to wash the previous week’s sweat off my skin.

“You don’t belong here, girl,” someone says from behind me.

I turn slowly, my eyes connecting with an aged leather face and opal looking eyes. He smiles, and his teeth—what is left of them—are stained yellow and black.

“How do you know?” I ask softly, my throat contracting around the dryness.

“Because you’ve got the look.”

“The look?” I ask, my gaze going back to my small little mattress. I need that mattress.

“Yes, child, the look of Lucifer.”

What the ever-loving shit is he talking about? I rush back to my corner and sit, curling my knees up to my chest. I slowly start rocking, slamming my eyes closed.

He did this.

He killed my parents.

I keep going back to that morning when I called him perfect, and he had said that I only thought he was perfect because I hadn’t seen his soul.

He was right, because he’s a *fucking* monster.

Manik

I bare my teeth, a deep hiss escaping my mouth as I march back and forth inside the cage—inhaling

and exhaling, needing a break. To break. To shatter something—anything.

The cage door opens, and another girl gets tossed in with me.

The soldier closes the door quickly before I can kill him. Smart motherfucker.

I look down at the girl, her skin so soiled and smudged that it looks like she's been rolling in mud for days. "Ever fucked a stranger?"

She shakes her head. "No."

I crank my head, swinging my arms out. "You realize you're going to die? No one who sees my face lives."

She swallows. "I figured." She diverts her eyes to the ground, rubbing her hand over the back of her neck. "I don't really care, if I'm honest."

"And why's that?" I ask, tilting my head.

"Because I've been passed around so much that I plead for death."

"From who? They touch you without asking, I know this, but who?"

She opens her mouth. "The soldier and the man. The old man wanted to buy me. He—he—"

"Who? My dad?"

She shakes her head. "No... the—"

Just as quickly as she entered, the cage opens up with a heavy clink and she's being pulled out by the young little fucker that has been here since I got here, watching my every move. I fucking hate him and I've already decided that his blood will be the first that will be spilled between my fingers once I get out of here. I see the way he looks at the girls that come in here. These girls, they're in my pen as a service, because sex helps bring out an aggressive side of me, helps bring out the Zvet that he needs—Dad knows that. It's no secret that the mafia dabbles in human trafficking. I didn't say I liked it, but I knew it happened. Anyway, these girls are in transition to their next destination. The Pen is an underground cave that no one who isn't supposed to know about it, knows the location. It's equipped with cages of all sizes, the walls are a muddy clay. I have been here twice before.

Once when I was twelve, before my dad took me to Sydney for my second hit.

The second time when I told him I wanted to rap. He tried to dehumanize me and make me realize my roots, what my duty was as a Romanov.

It worked to an extent, but he figured out very quickly that putting me back into civilization only destroyed all his hard work. Then he started just using old school manipulation to drive the point home.

Considering I'm a Vor, and one of the GOAT rappers, would prove how well that did him. And me.

The girl screaming, cuts into my thoughts as she grasps for the hands that have her by the neck. "Let me go."

"What the fuck are you doing?" I ask the soldier, gripping the steel poles in my hand. I smirk at him, pulling my smokes out of my pocket and lighting one up. I'm not allowed anything else while I'm in here. Not even a fucking shirt. Just my jeans, my boots, and my smokes. Dad knows I wouldn't be able to concentrate if I'm jonesing for a smoke too.

"She's too similar looking to the subject. She's a trigger for you."

I give him a dirty look, my lip curling. "You think I have a trigger labeled Beatrice Kennedy?" Even as I say it, it's like acid rising in my throat. She's the vengeance to my mother's death. Beatrice was promised to me so many years ago. She was supposed to be raised in our house. Destroyed, groomed, and taunted, but instead, Dad decided to do something worse. He figured, why show her there's only bad in this world? Oh no, he needed to let her see the happiness, to obtain a cleansed

soul and a happy life...right before he ripped her away from everything and anything she had ever known. This is why people don't fuck with him. He's ten steps ahead of everyone else.

The first night at the club?

Was him.

He planned to tell me everything, but when he witnessed us together and saw little fucking heart eyes flaring all over her face, he decided why only fuck her life up, may as well break her heart too.

When he told me all of this, everything turned black. Every thought I had of her had morphed into a bleak scene filled with rage.

I hate her.

They need to let me out, I'm fucking ready.

A heavy clink sounds out from the door being opened again, and another girl gets thrown in. Blonde. Lip bleeding, hair matted with blood.

"Why?" I ask the soldier, but my eyes don't move off of the mess on my floor. She peers up at me and then freezes in shock.

"Manik?"

"Shut the fuck up." Then I look to the soldier. "Why's she here?"

Soldier chuckles then lights up a smoke. "She's actually one of the Capo's side bitches. Says she's pregnant, and he doesn't wanna deal with it. She's had a fetish for you from the beginning. Figure, we do you and her a solid and let you handle this one..."

I lick my lips and smirk. "Yeah, I gotchu, and then" —I stare pointedly at him—"you bring my father back here."

He stares at me and lets a few minutes of silence pass between us. He flicks his smoke and then shrugs. "Deal."

I start stalking toward her, cranking my shoulders. "Don't worry, baby, I'll make this just as enjoyable as it'll be hurtful."



CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR



“I know what you want”—Busta Rhymes

Beat

The rustle of leaves sway in the dancing of the wind, mixing to a messy melody of nature. I shiver, the cool weather switching down so much that I can't breathe. I sit up, twisting my neck to click it out of place. The fire pit in the middle of the dusty ground calling to me. I stand and go toward it, desperate for the heat it will bring.

I can't do this for another day. I need to make a quick withdraw, and run. I let my hands defrost over the flicker of flames.

“What's your sin?” a voice asks. I look toward it, only to see someone in a hoodie, watching the flames on the other side. I can see the profile of his face. A thick black beard, broad shoulders. He's sitting with his arms resting on his knees.

“My sin?” I ask, confused. “What do you mean?”

He stays silent for a second, and then he cranks his head up to look directly at me. “Every one of us has done something shitty to end up being here, darlin'. We don't just get dished a shitty life. The universe makes sure bad shit happens to bad people. Eventually.”

I don't want to explain how depressing that sounds, but it makes sense.

“What's your name?” I ask instead, trying to change the subject. I don't want to let my mind sink to the depths of my karma train, it might be a heavy load. “I haven't seen you around here before.”

He chuckles, his voice so deep and devilish that it has goosebumps breaking out across my back.

“I’ve been here all along.”

I don’t argue and say that I would have definitely seen him if he had been here all along. He doesn’t have a face, or even an energy, that you would just walk past.

“What’s your sin?” I ask instead, rubbing my hands together and inhaling the warm heat of the fire.

“I lost count.”

I crawl back to my bed not long after that and force myself to sleep.

The birds chirping in the trees wakes me at the crack ass of dawn. Remembering the stranger from last night, I sit up quickly, brushing my hair out of my face to see if I can find him—but he’s gone. The spot he was sitting in is empty, with nothing but a piece of paper shoved under a rock. I stand up, brushing my legs off and walk toward it. Picking up the invitation sized paper, I turn it over and in big curly cursive font reads the words **Midnight Mayhem** and then below that is the dates that they’re here.

I suck in a breath, pulling the paper close to my chest. Did the guy from last night put this here? Or did the wind blow it under a rock? I chuckle inwardly to myself.

Then it hits me.

I can dance. I’m pretty great at it and Midnight Mayhem travels all around America—they’re never in the same place that long. I could make money and travel, and never have to worry about Manik finding me.

I push the paper into my pocket, and run toward my crap, grabbing my dirty Nike bag that is filled with my belongings. I have to try. This could solve my problems, at least for right now.

I look down at the flyer and then back up at the tent. It’s not colorful like a circus tent. It’s licked in pure black with lilac trimmings that stretch up to the pointed roof tips. It’s different during the day seeing it for the first time as opposed to seeing it during the night. Everything is quiet and fainter. There are trailers that are tucked behind the monstrous sized tent, all lined up in perfect order yet spaced appropriately away from each other. It’s so quiet. The only sound from the trees that are rustling above. They chose a good location, as always, a monster-sized football field close to the city, but far enough away to not be a nuisance.

I take one step, and butterflies roar in my belly. I remember what the girls looked like that night. They looked like they had stepped off Victoria’s Secret runway, groomed and beautiful. I take in my dirty jeans that were once tight around my athletic figure, and are now falling loosely off my ass. My heart sinks. This is a bad idea. If I go in there, they’ll likely think I’m crazy and gross. I don’t look like me, I’ve lost myself. I’ve lost my spark. With that, I slowly turn back around, fighting to keep the tears from falling. I thought I had it. I thought I had a solution to my problem. I thought I could dance and feel the fire in my belly again, coursing through my veins, but it’s that exact moment that I realize I never will.

“Are you coming in?” a feminine voice says from behind me, stopping me in my tracks.

I slowly turn to face her, my panic subsiding. I’m face-to-face with probably the most beautiful woman I have ever seen—besides my mother. If I had to guess, I’d say she’s in her early forties but she looks like she could pass for being in her thirties too. Her green eyes pierce mine, her short black hair cut to her jaw in a razor sharp snip.

“Um, pardon?” I’m confused by her question. Why would she be asking me if I’m coming in?

She crosses her arms in front of herself, slowly walking toward me. “I know who you are,

Beatrice Kennedy, I've seen your videos on YouTube, so I'll ask you again." She slowly gives me a half smirk. "Are you coming in?"

I bite my bottom lip and nod. "Yes."



CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE



“Mo’murda”—Bone Thugs

Manik

“You’re not ready.” Dad paces up and down, his hands linked behind his back. He looks calm if you don’t know him, but I know him well, and although I can’t read him for shit, I know when something is bugging him.

“I am...” I answer smoothly, blood slipping down my chest. “I dropped an album a month ago, Pops, I can’t be in here as your pet beast. You gotta let me out to handle my business, and then, like I said I always would do, I will find her. I will ruin her, and I *will* kill her.”

Dad stops his pacing, his eyes coming directly to me. He steps forward, tilting his head. “Unlock the cage.”

The soldier unlocks the door with a heavy thud. I fly to the other side of the cage, grab the soldier’s throat, and squeeze it. I yank my blade out that’s tucked into the waistband of my pants, and slice his neck open before reaching inside and tearing his larynx clean from his body. His skin rips away and blood rains down all over me as he drops to the ground with a heavy thud. I squeeze the tube in my hand until his blood and fluid slip through the cracks of my fingers. It wasn’t the soldier I despised, unfortunately, but I think I made my point to the old man.

Turning to face Dad, my eyes flat, I smirk. “As I said, I’m fucking ready.”

I step out of the cage, passing through the dark doors that take you out into the under cave, and stop when I notice Dad isn’t following.

“And your sister?” Dad asks, coming up beside me.

“Will need to stay out of my way. She tries to pull feelings out of me and I might kill her.”

Dad chuckles, patting me on the back. “You’re ready.”

The limo pulls up outside my house, and my dad stops me as I’m about to get out. “Release this album, Syn, but I need you on your game. Keep those little fuckers out of your bubble, you hear me? Remember you’re still a Vor and the Bratva will always come first. Have we any reason to see you not complying to this, it’s not just your life you have to worry about. It’s every person you even slightly give a shit about, including your sister. Do you understand, Syn?” He searches my eyes.

I chuckle, knocking his hand off my leg. “Yeah, Pops. I get it. Crystal fucking clear.” I climb out and slam the door closed behind me. I’ve been caged for a month. I still don’t know what’s happened since I’ve been gone, but I told Lenny that I’d be back when I’d be back and to not worry. He knew, if I didn’t show he knew—he knew. Lenny had been around since I was a kid, and this wasn’t the first time I’d been caged.

I unlock my front door and slam it closed when I’m inside.

I can still smell her scent. My eyes close as I inhale, and exhale. Slowly, I open them and feel the hatred burning through me.

Revenge

“You’re back?” Lenny says, watching me carefully while leaning on one of the pillars in the foyer.

“Yeah.” I toss my bag down onto the ground, taking out my smokes.

“You look like shit. Again.”

I light up my smoke, inhaling and blowing out the thick cloud of grey. I don’t say anything, because I can’t be fucked getting into it with Lenny right now. The man is relentless when he wants to be.

“Are you going to tell me what’s going on when you go off for these long trips with your dad?”

I shake my head, blowing out another cloud of smoke. “Nup.” I run my hand over my thick beard, his eyes follow the motion and then he laughs. “Look cute with that beard, Ae, think the bitches will love it. Might need to keep it on for the tour.”

I flip him off and then make my way toward my bedroom. I need a fucking shower, and then a fucking plan. Just as I reach for the handle, Lenny’s words stop me.

“She’s gone. We can’t find her anywhere.”

It takes me a second to realize he’s talking about Beat and then takes me another second to remember that I didn’t actually update him on what happened with her.

I need to obviously decide whether I tell him or not. I go with or not, because Lenny, although he’s not a little bitch, I have come to realize, has a soft spot for little Beatrice Kennedy, or should I say, Amaya Corvo.

I remember that night so vividly that it conjures the most vivid pictures in my brain.

I shake my head. “She won’t be for long.”

“What does that mean?” he pushes, and I have two options here. Tell him half of the truth or all of it. By law, he already knows too much, but whether I like it or not, Lenny is my brother and I trust him more than I trust my own father.

“It means that there’s a whole chunk of information that you don’t know, and I’m not willing to tell you, so anything that happens from here on out, I need to be sure that you have my back, and not hers.”

“What?” His face scrunches up. I’ve offended him—good. That tells me all I need to know. “I’ve never *not* had your back, Ae, and yeah, I like Beat, but you’re my brother and it’ll always be you.”

“Awww,” I tease, smirking at him. “Do you suck dick on the first date? Because I gott—” He flips me off. “Fuck you.” Then leaves, storming off up one of the twin stairwells.

The next day, I make my way up to the studio to meet Lenny and X. We need to go over the final small details of my world tour.

“What’s it going to be called? I mean, you could just name it after the album?”

I shake my head, leaning back on the sofa and flicking a pen through my fingers. “Nah. I’m not in the same place I was when I wrote this album, and besides, the name really means jack shit when we’ve sold out across all of the shows.”

Something passes between X and Lenny, but I ignore them, tossing words around in my head. I hate that Beatrice has a touch on this album. She was the fucking thing that inspired me to write one of these songs and basically overall get over my block. Even though each song is, in my honest opinion, some of my best. There is still a touch of her on each song, whether I’m rapping about her or not. And I’m not—except in one song she’s dropped on a verse. Not her exact name, but the indication that there is a woman in my life and her pet name. That has never happened before. I don’t rap about money and bitches, I rap about real shit. Depression, anxiety, that feeling of wanting to jump from a skyscraper just for your physical body to explode against the cement and show whoever it is that you fucking cared all along. I knew when I started in this that I didn’t want to be a gold plated rapper dancing around saying shit but not really saying shit. I knew that regardless of how raw my words were, my listeners would get it at one-hundred-percent. None of that watered-down bullshit. This album is that still, with only that one song that has a mention of a woman, and of course, the world lost their mind trying to figure out who she was. It didn’t take long when I started carrying Beatrice on my arm like a fucking prized possession.

Leaning my back against the head of the couch, I try to think of something. Anything.

I chuckle, bringing my eyes to Lenny and X who both stopped their talking when they heard me laugh. “I got it. We’ll call the tour Raven’s Revenge.”

They both look at me, puzzled. I roll my eyes. “What’s the Italian word for Raven, boys?”

They both blink.

X whispers to Lenny. “Is he alright? Like is homeboy on somethin’ or what?”

Lenny watches me, but answers, “Still trying to figure that out, brother.”

“I’ll tell you what it is,” I smirk, biting down on the base of my smoke and flicking open my Zippo. I inhale and then exhale. “*Corvo*.”



CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX



“I don’t wanna know”—Mario, Diddy.

Beat

“Do you want to ask me anything?” Delila says, coming back to the small table in her trailer, carrying two hot mugs.

I take one from her, smiling and blowing on the warmth. I wrap my lips around the rim and take a sip. Oh God. I almost moan it feels that good. My tummy rumbles from having something inside of it after so long. “Um...” I shake my head. “No. I guess not.”

“Interesting,” she says, sitting opposite me. She tilts her head. “I must say, you’ve lost some weight since I last saw you in New Orleans.”

I pause, the mug halfway up to my face. “You saw me?”

She smiles, sipping on her own drink and then placing it back on the table. “Of course. Now, aside from the pretty face, you sure spiked our attention when Manik brought you with him. He usually comes to our shows alone, or with his big friend.”

Lenny, I wanted to say, but the mention of Aeron has my lips clamped shut. Will she still be kind to me when she finds out that he and I are no longer an item? May as well get it over with now.

“You know that we are not a thing anymore? And to be honest, I’m actually trying to avoid him.” Putting it lightly. I wonder if that was smart mentioning that. She might call him and tell him I’m here just to get in his good books. Damn my big stupid mouth.

She laughs lightly, a small smile touching her lips. “I figured as much.” Then she straightens her

shoulders. “I have to be honest with you, once we saw you both together, it gained my attention, so we researched you. We found your videos on YouTube and that was that. We knew if we passed you again that we would like to, at the very least, offer you something. We’ve been looking for a dancer for some time. I mean, Micaela and Promise are great, excellent actually.” No idea who she is talking about but I nod my head for her to continue. “But we need someone with more flare, not with contemporary and gymnastics as their learning trunk.”

I blink. “Um, sorry it’s just that there are so many amazing dancers in the world—especially on YouTube, why me?”

“I agree.” She nods, leaning forward slightly. Her lip twitches. “But none of them have the darkness inside of them to perform with Midnight Mayhem.”

I suck in a breath. “You think I do? Because I don’t...”

“No.” She shakes her head, leaning back. “I don’t think you have, but I think when you perform, you create art. When you’re dancing, you’re performing for those cameras. With each song, you’re allowing the music and the lyrics to possess you, and Beatrice, you may not have darkness inside of you, but you don’t run from the darkness around you, and that makes all the difference.”

Her words hit me all at once, and that’s when I know she’s right. Despite the fact that she doesn’t know me for nothing, she’s right. “Okay, but I don’t feel up to too much right now.”

Delila smiles, sagging back in her seat. “I don’t suppose you would. I’ll show you to my shower and then have you meet a couple of the girls. I think Promise has some room in her trailer for you until you figure out what it is you want. Tomorrow, we can see what you’ve got. That sound okay?”

“Yes.” I drink the rest of my drink that has cooled to lukewarm. “Sounds perfect.”

After my shower, I feel like a new woman. It’s like I can smell the things I couldn’t smell before, and when I lift my bag up, it reeks. Yelp, how awful did I smell if my bag alone is this gross. I leave my hair to dry on its own, flowing down my back, and leave the bathroom stall in Angela’s trailer. They’re much bigger than what they look like from the outside. She has a large king bed at one end that has a curtain that can pull over for privacy, a lounge area, the bathroom, the kitchen, and then another small room—I think. The trailer is hooked up to a large SUV.

“You ready?” she asks, walking toward me with a pack of smokes in her hand.

I nod, looking down at her hands. “You smoke? Aren’t you like, a circus and you guys are all fit?” I feel like a hypocrite because I used to like to enjoy a cig every now and then.

She laughs, gesturing for me to follow her. “We’re not a circus, Beatrice, I thought that much was obvious?”

I lick my lips, squeezing the handle of my bag. “I guess so.”

She blows out her smoke and the smell reminds me of Manik. I gulp down the memories that threaten to surface. “We’re just Midnight Mayhem.”

Promise is cute, and a little quiet. She welcomes me into her trailer without blinking at Delila.

“Thanks for letting her just dump me in here,” I say, looking around the room. It’s all white and fur. Interesting décor, but when you see Promise, you probably wouldn’t be surprised.

She waves me off. “It’s okay. I knew you were coming, we all sort of did, and since I’m the only one who will share her space, I offered to have you here.” She pulls open a mesh curtain at the end of the trailer, opening it onto a large bed. “There’s nothing to it, just a bed, as you can see.” She gestures to the small room that’s occupied by the bed. “So just keep all your loose belongings in the cupboard down the hall. The bathroom is to the left, there’s limited hot water so try to keep it short, I have...”

She looks down at my clothes. "A lot of clothes. Please borrow them. We're probably close to the same size."

I drop my bag on the floor that seems like it's intruding in this perfect space, then take a seat on the bed, gripping the dress Delila gave me to put on after my shower. "Thanks," I murmur, chewing on my lip. "This is weird, right?"

Promise gives me a look. Her pasty white skin is a complete contrast to my golden tan. Her white blonde curly hair, again, completely opposite of my jet black straight hair. "Yes, but weird is what we do." She saunters down the hallway and pulls open a door. "Voila!" She points inside. "Come take a look."

I stand and follow, then freeze when I see what's behind the door. "All of those clothes are yours?"

She nods, her face lighting up like a fierce flash of lightning. "Yup! And help yourself."

"Oh, thanks," I say, a little taken back by her generosity. When she starts going to her side of the trailer, I call out, "Promise?"

"Hmm?" she asks, tilting her head to look over her shoulder as she crawls onto her bed.

"Why are you being so nice to me?"

She exhales. "Because no one else here is going to be."

Oh, well that's very comforting to hear.

Someone is shaking my ankle. Or something. I launch off the bed, screaming.

"Woah!" Promise says, her hands up in the air. "Sorry, didn't know you were a shit sleeper. Noted! Hey, you might want to go warm up for the day. Delila is going to have you on a crazy routine no doubt."

I jump off the bed, swiping my hair out of my face. "You think?" I ask, watching as she goes straight for the coffee. She pours a cup and then asks me if I want one.

I shake my head. "No. I'll go for a run first."

She nods and then continues. "Yup. She will push you today to your breaking point, so be ready." Then she points to the closet. "Narnia is open and there are tons of training clothes."

I get busy, taking out a bright green Nike sports bra and loose grey sweatpants. I take the Calvins too because I'll need them. I slip them all on quickly. Cursing that I don't have an iPod, I hate running with no music. Being off the grid sucks.

Thirty minutes later, I'm back, sweat pouring from my skin. I didn't want to do an hour because I wanted to actually have energy to survive the day, but I'm warm enough.

"Beat!" Delila calls out from outside her trailer. "Perfect. Come on. You can start now."

I point to Promise's trailer. "Should I have a shower?"

She laughs. "No. Save it for later, you're just going to get sweaty again anyway."

I jog, catching up to her, and she stops just as she's about to open the back entry of the tent. Turning, her eyes scan my face. "I don't know what's going on with you and Manik, or why you're on the run. I know you have money, and I know you don't have to be homeless, you choose to be, so I figure whatever it is that's going on between the two of you is dangerous. But, I can't let it touch this family. I know who Manik's dad is, everyone does, so don't get comfortable here, okay? You may be in, but to become family takes a lot longer than one night."

I gulp, nerves wracking my body, but I nod because I totally understand why she's saying this. "I understand."

"Good," she chirps, sipping her coffee. "Now come and show these twats that you're more than a

hobo in hiding with a pretty face.”

The tent set up inside is nothing like it was or felt that night, and my eyes go straight to where Manik and I would have been sitting, instantly, ignoring all of the people who are in there, hopefully not waiting on me. Why do I feel sick to my stomach when I think of him? Because I let the same hands that killed my parents touch me in places I never let anyone touch me. And I’m not talking about my body.

“Everyone, this is Beatrice, as I’m sure you already know.” Delila gestures to me. “She’s going to play around for a bit, go ahead and do what you need to do.” Then she looks back to me. “I’m going to play a song in each genre and I want you to be able to freestyle for a minute from that song.”

Nerves hit me, but I know I’ve got this. “Sounds good,” I agree.

She looks up to a booth that sits over the main entrance, completely camouflaged in black. From the corner of my eye, I see people shuffling away to the edges of the stretched ring, but there are also a few people who stay seated. Nice for my nerves, too.

The first song that starts playing is something easy. “Filthy” by Justin Timberlake. I let each beat hit my movements with tranquility. Dancing is like breathing for me.

I roll my body into the song, letting my hair out of the high ponytail, walking up to the front of the ring, shaking my hips. I lift my leg to standing splits, sliding it through the air then dropping down onto my back, my legs tucked under my butt but with my arms stretched wide. When the chorus kicks back in, I roll onto my stomach and then to all fours. The next song mixes into a rap song. “Thugs Get Lonely Too” by Tupac. I slide into the song, letting my hips hit the pulse and flow with the lyrics. The next song that slips in is “Bad at Love” by Halsey. I drop to the ground, letting the strum take over my soul, crawling up and stretching my leg above my head to the music. When the chorus comes in, I twist around and use my hands to move over my body, dropping back to the ground again. I hate how much this song speaks to me. Finally, it moves to “Left Outside Alone” by Anastasia. What the hell genre is this? I go with it anyway. When the song kicks up a little, I twist on my feet with one foot pressed against my inner thigh, using basic ballet movements. Then when the chorus drops, I slide against the floor on my knees, grabbing my head and circling it around, lost in the song. It’s a good old school song. The music cuts—

Trying to catch my breath, the music stops, and my shoulders heave.

“Nice.” Delila claps, looking out to everyone who had stopped to watch me. “Right?” There were a few mumbles, and then my eyes drop to a group who were sitting near the front. Five guys. All with interesting looks, watching me carefully. None of them welcoming at all—by any means. Delila follows my line of sight and giggles, patting my shoulder. “I believe you may remember that group?”

I nod, gulping down my breath. I remember all right. I’ll remember for the rest of my life. “I thought there were six?”

She agrees. “There is. Obviously, it is the six demons, not the five. ‘Lucifer’ isn’t here right now.” She pauses, her eyes dropping to my mouth and then back to my eyes. “You’ll see him in the show tonight.”

Wait.

“I can’t perform tonight? I’m not ready—?”

She raises her eyebrows, and I get the feeling that my meltdown is entertainment to her. Gosh. I really don’t know how to read this woman. One minute she’s nice to me, the next she’s not, the next I feel like she’s manipulating me.

The six demons consist of them all, alongside the group of girls who join them in their sets, the Seven Angels of God. They’re the tricksters and the masterminds—or, you could say, magicians.

Their expertise is like nothing I've ever seen before. None of Midnight Mayhem is.

"You're ready. Now, train the rest of the day, have an ice bath, and then get groomed."

"Wait!" I call out again, turning toward her retreating back. "But, I don't have a dance?"

She grins. "Oh, you'll be freestyling."

Shit on a stick.



CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN



“Picture me rollin’”—2Pac, Kurupt

Manik

Craning my neck, I order the driver to pull into an empty spot. “You need any help, boss?”

I shake my head. “No. I won’t need any help.” Looking down at the time, I see it’s 11:52 p.m.

I need to be careful with how I execute this. If it wasn’t for pretty little Promise, I wouldn’t have gotten the tip off to her being here. The shit bitches will do to leap onto a dick.

What the fuck is she doing here anyway. Her attempt to run from me was even worse than I expected. I crave the hunt, but I live for the capture.

I get out of the limo, leaning in one last time. “Go around to the back entrance. I’ll meet you there when I get there.”

He nods, and I shut the door. Dropping the hoodie over my head, I make my way to the entrance, my head down to avoid any and everyone. When reaching the guards at the front, I hand them my ticket without locking eyes with them. I know for damn sure that they’d alert Beatrice about my being here. She has a way of making men lose their minds and women die with envy. I shuffle through the crowd of people, silently dropping down to the front seat and waiting for everyone else to enter.

As soon as the lights dim, I lick my lips. This bitch is in trouble.

The familiar sets go through, interchanging like always. From the illusionists with the six demons, right to Promise and Micaela’s sets.

Then the lights dim further and Delila comes out, holding a mic. She smirks so deep that the

spotlight radiates on her face. “We have a new girl tonight ladies and gentlemen, and she’s about as surprised as you are because none of her movements are choreographed. She has no idea what we have in store for her. Sit back, relax, and let the *Beat* take you over...”

The lights cut out instantly, and the crowd goes silent. Sinking deeper into my chair, I kick my legs out, my knees jiggling with—I don’t fucking know why. Nerves? Hell no. Anticipation? Maybe.

A slow instrumental song introduces her, and her silhouette lines out the spotlight of a black drop sheet. Ariana Grande and Futures song “Everyday” starts playing, mixing into the soft slow melody her body wraps around, her legs kicking out in ways I remember all too well, her face is heavy in makeup. Once the rap intro comes in, the song moves to a slow torturous tune, haunting and hypnotic and completely up Mayhem’s lane. Her body wraps around each note that’s strung until the song is barely recognizable. A slow piano song starts, and its then that I realize it’s Halsey’s song “Control,” a darker song that has the light hint of a bleeding heart. When Halsey says ‘I’m meaner than my demons,’ Beat’s head twists around and her body drops to the floor in a disturbing rotation, her body slicked in sweat.

My fists clench.

She’s my fucking revenge, the last promise I made to my mom. To my dad.

She finishes her set and the lights cut out. More sets happen after her, the Six Demons from Hell with the Seven Angels of God, and then Promise and Micaela’s little play around. The bike tricks, including the stunt they always pull with their man-made railway roller coaster they built.

The lights are extinguished again, and Delila comes back to the center of the ring, her eyes cutting straight to me as if she knows why I’m there. “For our final act, ladies and gentlemen, we have something special lined up for you tonight for the first time ever.”

She disappears behind the curtain and then a spotlight flashes onto the center of the ring where Beat stands again in nothing but a tight little lace bralette and sweatpants. “Pony” by Genuine starts playing, because of course it does. I roll my eyes at the mundane song of choice, but that quickly changes when I watch as her little body spins around the ring, possessing it like this is her show and everyone is just here for the ride. She completely owns any stage or dance floor that she’s performing on. She’s no longer the quiet and demure Beatrice Kennedy, somehow, she becomes fucking Amaya Corvo. The little fucking minx she was supposed to be. The enemy she was always meant to be to me.

The song hits halfway and my head straightens as the tune dips, slowing down completely, yet staying the same. “Pillow Talk” from Zayn starts playing and she turns to look over her shoulder, grinning while curling her finger.

What?

A dark figure steps out to the light. Shirtless, baggy jeans and oiled all over. He drops to the ground as the beat drops, wrapping his arms around her legs and she pulls away, dancing solo, but he comes after her anyway. When it says “fucking him” she rolls her body against him, who I now recognize as one of the six demons, Lucifer. They both dance together, wrapped up in each other, their bodies slide over each other to the song, and then Lucifer kicks it up a notch, pulling out one of his fire sticks. He takes a swig of gasoline and then blows on it, shooting sharp flames across the ring, aimed right at Beat. She dodges it with a roll of her torso, going across the ring as he flicks the stick around his arm, watching her, preying on her. I’m waiting for that flame to light up his beard.

I clench my fists, my jaw ticking. I don’t know why this pisses me off. Not because I’m jealous, but because she’s my toy and only I get to play with her like that.

The song and their show ends with a huge round of applause as they dip back behind the curtain, I get back to my feet and slowly push past legs and limbs that are in my way of the back exit. Once I’ve

reached the end, I duck behind a little corner that's hidden from the public eye and push through the curtain.

Now, I'm not just fucking pissed, she's managed to get my dick hard too. A little inconvenient but I'm not surprised. She had a catastrophic impact on me and I didn't expect that shit to go away overnight.

I see the limo parked behind one of the trailers with the driver standing quietly beside the door. He sees me and nods his head, I reciprocate it.

Where the fuck is this girl.



CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT



“Snitch”—Obie Trice, Akon

Beat

“That was insane!” I say, tying my hair up into a high ponytail. I mean, I loved dancing at the studio and I always take massive joy in dancing for the cameras but dancing for a live audience, that was something else. I can feel myself latch onto the euphoria jumping through my veins.

Lucifer, which feels weird calling him that because it’s not his real name, chuckles, running his hands over his beard. “Yeah? Glad you enjoyed it. Not many people do.”

I shake my head. “I more than enjoyed it.” I run my hand over my stomach, watching as his eyes lower to the movement. I didn’t know that he was coming out, and I didn’t know that the guy who came to the bridge that night was Lucifer either. He said that they had been watching me, and that there was a whole lot that I don’t know about Midnight Mayhem, that I believe.

He tilts his head, his taut muscles clenching with every step. “Thirsty?”

I lick my lips. “A little.”

He smiles, enough for the soft ends of his eyes to crinkle. “Meet me at my trailer, baby girl. There’s a few of us there.” Then just as he walks past me, his hand swipes across the flesh of my stomach and my abs tense.

I’m feeling reckless, so why not. And anyway, I’m almost certain my days on this earth are numbered due to my psychopathic ex-maybe, sort of, chasing me.

Or maybe he’s not.

What if he's not and this could be my life? My head swims with hope. I take the first step up to the trailer I've been staying in with Promise, but a hand slams over my mouth and yanks me backward.

I try to scream, but it's no use, because nothing comes out.

Lips come to my ear. "Aww, come on, Cubby. You don't think you can move on without me, do you?"

Then a cloth comes over my nose and everything fizzles out into the darkness of my brain.

My eyes peel open, forcing them through the glue that feels as though it has set between my lashes. My throat clenches, and when I go to pull my hands apart behind me, they lock and the light ding of chains alerts whoever it is that's near me that I'm awake.

"You sleep well, Cub?" Manik's voice reaches out from the dark corners of wherever I am and pulls all of the fear out of my soul.

I have nothing to say. This isn't a game anymore. This isn't something superficial or false like it was when I was locked in his basement. This has substance. He blames me for his mom's death, and I most certainly blame him for my parents, since he slaughtered both of them like they were animals.

Heavy footsteps thud through sloppy puddles, and that's when the smell hits me. Urine mixed with the strong metallic stench of fresh blood.

I gag, but nothing comes up.

When his dark jeans come into view, I can finally focus and I see him standing on the other side of a cage.

"You killed my parents," I mutter, grief I thought I had swallowed years ago makes a reappearance and holds my throat hostage. I thought I had grieved them and moved on, but how can you move on from something that you didn't see the full picture of to begin with.

"Yes," he answers, his voice flat and emotionless. I almost didn't recognize it because it sounds so different from the Aeron I thought I knew. Then again, I didn't know him at all. "That was after your dad put a bullet between my mother's eyes and then skinned her, sending me her remains on every single birthday I had after her death."

His words hit me like a bullet, exploding in my gut. "I don't believe you."

"And I don't care," he replies simply. Lowering himself and clenching the bar between his hands. He leans forward so that I can finally see his face. The same face that used to make me feel so many things in my soul, now makes me want to hurl.

"I hate you. You're evil."

He laughs, standing and going toward the entry of the cage I'm in, pulling it open. "I'm not evil, Cub. Right now, I'm the fucking devil walking in the flesh." The cage shuts behind him with a loud clink and he comes closer to me. I crawl backward until I'm in the corner of a soiled mattress pushed into the corner. I'm still wearing the clothes I danced in—tonight? Or was it last night?

My eyes squeeze shut. "Just get it over with, Aeron, I can't do this for long."

He laughs, and it isn't the laugh that I'm familiar with. It's a laugh that conjures every single fight or flight signal I have in my body and tells me to *run*.

But I can't. I'm cemented here like a helpless pawn in his game. Only this isn't a game, because in a game you get lives, and in this one, I only have one.

"I won't do that, *Amaya*, I'm not going to make you despise being alive, I'm going to do something worse." He leans forward until his lips are mere inches from mine. "Wanna know what that is, Cub?"

I don't answer.

His smile deepens and if I wasn't already pressed against the poles indenting my back, I'd move backward even more. Has he always been this scary? He continues. "You're going to beg me to keep you alive, to own you. You're going to hate the things I make you feel, Cub, but you're going to crave the soothing that only I can give when I make it all better. Even for a second, and that, my little Cub, is exactly why I own you."

"You killed my parents," I repeat, though I'm not sure why. To remind myself why I hate this man so much? I don't have hate in me, but my God if his presence doesn't evoke something similar.

He ignores me, tilting his head over his shoulder. "Wanna know what this place is, Cub?"

I ignore him.

He grabs my thigh, dragging me down the mattress. I can't fight the tears anymore, allowing them to drop down my cheeks.

He hovers over my body, a fist at each side of my face. "I said, do you know what this place is?"

I shake my head because I'm afraid of his unpredictability. Even when you've decided to meet your fate, you are still human, therefore you still get twitchy when someone who you think is going to kill you advances on you.

"Come." He yanks me up to my feet and starts to drag me out of the cage. I ignore his hands twisting in mine, dominating me at every turn.

We step through puddles and he pulls open another door, down into a bright hallway. The walls are thick chipped concrete, the light above us flickers on and off with every step. The smell reminds me of an old drain that hasn't seen the light of day in centuries, and is aging with every step. I can hear water dripping quietly, tip tapping through the clashing of the ground. He continues as we pass many heavy silver doors, just like the one we came out of. I try not to make it obvious that I'm watching everything, mentally taking in anything that I can. It's something my pop always said—thinking of my pop makes my heart thunder in my chest so I quickly divert my thoughts. I let my eyes scan over Manik's broad back instead. The tattoo on the back of his neck that dips below the collar of his shirt. But I know what that tattoo is, and I know what the rest of it shows too, the large demon that takes up his back.

He pushes through the final door at the end of the corridor, and an echoing of laughter breaks out. My eyes clench from the assault of light, the dirt on my flesh clinging to me at every turn.

The laughter cuts out just as Manik lets me go. He starts speaking in Russian, so I let my eyes adjust and am shocked at what I see. The walls are molten lava red, with burnt black hues smudged at the edges. There's thick mahogany wood cutting through the middle of the walls, slicked in varnish. There are around five circle tables layered in perfect order with the same red tablecloths and gold ornaments in the middle, the figures look like naked women sculpted out of—is that actually gold?

Manik turns to face me. Where the hell are we? There's a thick reflective glass that's directly in front of the tables, and when I finally allow my eyes to scan around to the men who are here, I notice them all scowling at me in disgust.

Ah, I see. More enemies that I didn't earn or ask for.

"Dance."

"What?" I ask, my eyes catching his. Is there no part of him left behind? But, even as I try to conjure some shred of humanity from him through eye contact alone, all I get back is black emotionless orbits.

"Uh, um, ok."

He gestures to a little door that's hidden beside the large pane of glass and I make my way to it, not sure what I'm going to find on the other side.

I step through, finding it empty, but full of despair, fear, and pain. It clings to the air like a bad smell.

Halestorm “Familiar Taste of Poison” starts playing softly and I close my eyes, slowly letting my body shift to the song. I take myself back to the ring, back to the feelings I felt when I was there, dancing, with Lucifer. When the music kicks up, I spin around in a ballet move, grabbing at my dirty hair, not caring at all that I probably look a mess. The chorus drops and so does my body, tears streaming down my face.

He killed my parents.

Now, he’s going to kill me.

After he makes me want to kill myself.

He owns me.

I have nothing.

The song ends and I stay on the floor, sobs taking over me. How did I manage to mess my life up so epically?

Clapping sounds from the entryway and Manik’s heavy boots come into view. “Who taught you how to dance?”

“Fuck you.”

He laughs, his head tilting back as I swipe the pathetic tears from my cheeks. “Think that’s the first time I’ve ever heard you cuss, Cub, I must admit, the filthy word looks as good coming out of your mouth as my cock does going into it.”

He grabs onto my arm and yanks me up. “Behave yourself and I might feed you.”

In a flash, we’re back in the human-sized cage and he’s in there with me, seated and pressed against it. “I have a problem, Cub. My tour starts next week, and I can’t leave you alone here. If I do, there’s no doubt someone might try to, you know,” he smirks, tilting his head. “Take you. Not that I give a fuck, but the thing is, is I’m a greedy bastard and I really *really* wasn’t kidding those months ago when I said that I don’t like people playing in my sandbox.”



CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE



“Numb”—XXXTENTACION

Manik

Conceal.



CHAPTER THIRTY



“Kill for you”—Skylar Grey, Eminem

Beat

I don't know when I fell asleep, but it mustn't have been long after Manik told me about his touring. I curled into a ball and cried myself to sleep.

I cried for the parents I lost.

The grandparents who died.

And finally, I cried for the girl I once was.

I spin around, turning to curl upward. I have no idea what time it is, but I'm gathering, because I feel more awake, that it must be sometime during the day. I got enough sleep.

“I'll be back in a second,” Manik says from the corner, getting to his feet and walking out of the cage. “Actually, I might be a while.” Then he leaves. Was he there all night?

Rubbing my hands over my face, I lean against the pole. It's forty minutes later-ish that the cage door opens again and another figure steps forward. He's young, with a white zip-up hoodie on and dark slacks. He has similar shoes to the ones Manik wears, only dirtier. His face looks young, I'm guessing around mid-twenties, but there's an ugly scar that ripples down the middle of his face and over his lip.

He hands me a water bottle. “Drink. It's an order.”

I take it. They don't have to tell me twice, I'm parched.

I take a long drink, and I don't stop. It's too good to stop. The water slides down my throat, setting

off a deep satisfaction of thirst quenched before finally settling in my stomach.

When it's empty, my arm drops down beside me, and that's when my head starts spinning. I go to tuck my hair behind my ear, my movements feeling a little heavy, echoed.

"Um," I say, but my voice sounds like I'm speaking underwater, garbled.

The boy steps closer, his body doubling and his movements fading.

I don't feel anything. My hands don't shift when I need them to.

When I feel my body float to the ground, in what I think is a slow fall, my legs don't move.

When I see his face directly above me, his hoodie dropping around his neck, I can't push him away.

I feel nothing. I'm hopeless. He tears my clothes off me in fluidlike movements, and I close my eyes, part of me thankful that I can't feel his assault or the intrusion into my body.

I don't know how long it lasts, all I know is that I can slowly feel my legs throbbing, and he's still going, emptying himself on my flesh, inside of me, and then shoving his cock that tastes of dirt and salt against the back of my throat. I go from blacking out to coming back into consciousness. Green tie. Cigar. Suit.

I see a man standing behind the boy who is on top of me. His jaw is open, shocked. "Vlad?" I try to whisper, though I'm not sure it comes out.

His face turns serious and he points to me. "Knock her out."

The boy keeps raping me.

He raped me.

My mind goes black. I don't know how long I'm out for, but when I wake, he's still on top of me.

He's not just taken my body, he's imprinted himself into my soul too, because that's what rapists do. You think it's over when he's finished? Oh no. That's just the beginning, it's living with the memories that kills you.

I slowly lift my hand, but it's still too slow. His breathing comes in heavier, his thrusts soft and slow. Not brutal or forced like I would have expected.

"Gosh you're beautiful, even when you look like you do, you're beautiful," he whispers, touching my face gently. I gag, my stomach churning and I give him a disgusted look.

He's being soft and gentle. Why.

Just as his hand comes to my cheek again to caress me. To whisper his disgusting sweet nothings as I fully regain feeling south and start to feel every thrust into me, every punch of pain, and every itch of sweat. His body is gone and a loud crash breaks through the air. I crawl up the bed, not caring that I'm naked and my clothes have gone.

I don't care. I don't care anymore.

They win.

I shiver in the corner, letting the damp smell inject itself into my tainted soul.

The boy stands to his feet, but Manik is standing over him, his back to me as if he's shielding me. "Cub," he says, turning his head to look over his shoulder. His eyes connect with mine and for a second, I see the Aeron I thought I knew, but then he blinks, and it's gone. "Do you want the honors?"

I don't answer, I don't know what he means and right now I don't care. Manik steps to him, grabs the boy's face and turns it up to stare at him in a way that is maybe not natural and could maybe snap his neck at any moment. "Who sent you in here?"

He chuckles, spitting blood out of his mouth and looking up at Manik. He grins, blood dripping around his mouth. "Not sure I owe you an explanation, Zver."

Manik's jaw clenches a few times, and then he flips the boy around to face me. He's inches away,

and the sight of his face makes me curl over in disgust. “Watch, Cub.”

I don’t want to.

I fight it, but my eyes drift back to them both.

Manik pulls out a dagger, the one I know he used on me on his kitchen counter, and the one from my memories of him taking my parents’ lives, then he presses the blade to the boy’s neck, his eyes on me. “Keep your eyes open.”

I shake my head, not wanting to watch. Horror seizes my bones and my stomach feels like it’s being slowly ripped from me.

“Cub?”

I look up. He slashes across the thin flesh, the wound splitting open and blood squirting out all over me. I scream, so loud that my throat feels like I’ve swallowed a thousand needles, and the only thing that reverberates out after my screams is the loud *thud* from Manik dropping his head on the concrete.

Manik tosses the body to the side with a thud, and then advances on me, pulling his hoodie off, he tosses it at me. “You get what I meant when I said do you want the honors?”

I nod slowly, my face wet from my tears.

“Good.” He yanks me up.

After a long drive, he leads me all the way through his house. Everything is semi-blurry and I can’t find anything inside of me to really care. Pushing open his bedroom door, he shoves me inside. “Wash and sleep. We leave tomorrow morning.”

“Leave?” I manage to ask, turning around enough to catch his eyes on me. “Leave for where?”

He runs his hands through his hair in frustration, swallowing hard enough for me to notice the Adam’s apple bob around in his thick neck. “The tour, Beatrice.”

Right. I continue toward the bathroom, shutting the bedroom door in his face.

Hitting on the faucet, I drop the hoodie from my swollen and bruised body, looking back at myself in the mirror. My tanned skin looks smudged in dirt, my lip is split, there are dark circles around my eyes and my cheekbones are sunken. I’ve not just lost my spark, there’s something inside of me that has died completely and won’t return. I don’t recognize the girl staring back at me, I don’t recognize the eyes that are peering back at me.

I scrub my body in the shower, seeing everything is exactly as it was when I left, only it’s not. My mind is a maze of confusion and I don’t know where the exit is.

Wrapping a fluffy towel around me, I squeeze the excess water from my hair and make my way back out to the bedroom. There are clothes laid out on his bed. I don’t see what it is, I just put them on. Everything moves slower, lifeless and dull.

I flop backward onto the bed, my eyes drifting closed.



CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE



“Black Cotton”—2Pac, Eminem

Manik

“Yo, I mean, I don’t know. This is risky business, Ae. I mean, bringing her on tour?” Lenny asks, pacing back and forth in front of the mixer table. He pauses, swinging around to face me. “What do I do if she gives me that look?”

I sink back into the sofa, my hands coming to my hair. I tug at it. “I don’t think that will be a problem. The girl isn’t functioning properly.”

“—And that’s what you wanted, right?” His tone is heavy on the accusatory side.

I lick my lips. “It’s what I should want. It’s what I’ve been trained to want since I was a fucking kid and her piece of shit dad took my mom, started one of the biggest wars to hit this era, and he tried to kidnap me when I was a baby, so fucking aye I wanted her to hurt. She needed to burn in the blood of her parents’ so I can fucking dance on her grave...”

Lenny sighs. “But?”

Conceal.

I chuckle. “It’s cute that you think there’s going to be a *but*.”



CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO



“Hip Hop”—Dead Prez

Beat

As soon as I'm curled in his blankets, I close my eyes and try to force myself back to sleep, but every time I do, I'm back in The Pen.

Caged.

My limbs feel numb and soft, my mind sinking deeper into subconsciousness, and then just when I think that's it, I'm finally going to sleep, I can't feel my legs again and I launch off the bed, sweat pouring down my face.

I yank at my hair, tears pouring down my cheeks. I feel invaded and dirty, like every person who looks at me now can see that I've been tampered with. My mind races a hundred miles an hour, but when I bite down on my lip, the pain calms me.

It calms me because I can feel—the complete opposite of how it was in The Pen.

Laying back down onto the pillow, my hair sprawls out beneath me and I clench my fists so tight that crescent moons carve into the palm of my hands. I was raped, but I won't make myself a victim. He took my choice away from me, but he will never take my soul.

The bedroom door cracks open and my eyes fly to the clock on the nightstand. I think about pretending to be asleep, but why. I find myself not really giving a shit. The bed sinks beside me and my eyes go to the shadow that's sitting there. It's strange that I feel safe here, considering this house is what set off so many events just months ago, but I feel...safe.

“Want me to sleep on the couch?” His voice interrupts the silent night like a feral animal.

I answer quickly. “You’re actually asking me?”

He pauses, and then I feel the bed move again, the blankets pulling back. “Figure you’ve been robbed of your choices lately.”

My throat swells. Those words may not mean anything had they come out of any other man, but this was Manik, and he doesn’t do sweet, and that was sweet. “Thank you.” Then I quickly add. “And you can sleep in here.”

He doesn’t answer, so I flip over to face him, tucking my hands under the pillow. “I—”

“—Shut up, Cub and go to sleep.”

When I was a little girl, I used to dream about traveling. I’d always talk about how I wanted to make sure I saw as much of the world as possible. My pops said that I had an unsettled spirit, but I think I just knew what was out there and wanted to take it.

This wasn’t exactly how I envisioned it though.

“When can I have a phone again? Why hasn’t Kyle tried to get hold of me?” I ask, clipping my seat belt on.

Aeron leans back in his chair, his eyes coming to mine. “Because he thinks you’re still on the run.”

“But,” my eyebrows cross. “I haven’t used any of their sources. I didn’t even stay with Katiya’s friend.”

He chuckles. “When are you going to get it, Cub?” One eye opens and then he sighs, leaning forward onto his elbows. “The clock may tick, but I’m the handle, numbers, and the sound it makes. You don’t move unless I say you move. You don’t live anywhere unless I say you can. Did you all really think you could outsmart me? I mean, my sister, yeah, she’s always tried to go up against me, but you and Kyle?” He laughs again, leaning back into the chair and closing his eyes. “Sleep. We’re starting in New York.”



CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE



“Right Thru me”—Nicki Minaj

Beat
New York

The dip of the plane descending shifts me from my deep sleep. As much as I tried to fight it, I did end up getting some sleep.

“You alright, baby girl?” X asks from a few rows ahead of me, his hoodie over his head and his shoulders slumped inward. X and I haven’t spoken much, not as much as Lenny and I.

I give him a small smile. “Hmm.” I don’t really know what else to say. Am I okay? That’s probably the most overused question or expression known to mankind. *Am I okay?*

No.

“Sure,” I lie, it falls from my mouth as effortless as the smile that accompanies it.

My fingers tingle and I squeeze them together to gain feeling back in them. Sweat drips down the side of my face, my breathing labored. *You’re not there, you’re here.*

You’re here.

On a plane.

Not in a cage.

The heavy thunk of the wheels meeting the asphalt jolts me completely, echoing to the sound of the lock sliding from the cage.

My eyes scrunch shut, my breathing not working. My mind slips into the dark, where small

splashes of color dances in little dots.

“Beat? Hey!” A voice snaps my eyes open.

His voice.

Not exactly my savior, since it is sort of his fault I was in there to begin with, but for a reason I don’t want to touch right now, his voice soothes the deep panicking in my head.

My eyes go to his, his face mere centimeters from mine, fuzzing in and out.

“You okay?” His question comes into full focus. My eyes drop to his hands that are on my knees before I pin him with a glare.

“No. I’m not.”

Turns out, I don’t care with Aeron. I can tell him anything truthfully and not feel anything about it. As the plane is shifting across the runway, Aeron leans back again, his face blank.

I tilt my head, noticing his eyes zone out. He’s looking at me, but *not* at me. He’s looking through me, and I’m not sure I want to really admit how that feels either. I know exactly how it is to be on the receiving end of Manik’s angry stare, but there’s something different about him this time. It’s like something has switched off inside of him, and just when I think I see a glimpse of the old Aeron, the Aeron only I got the pleasure of seeing, experiencing and... feeling, he snatches it away again and locks it up.

It’s exhausting. I’m exhausted.

I quickly take my belt off and rush to the end of the jet, colliding with the pilot who was exiting the cockpit. “I’m sorry,” I murmur, brushing around him.

My mind has been in shambles since everything blew up. I haven’t even had enough time to sit down and really think about the revelations.

I’ll do that tonight.

“Where you going, Cub?” Manik asks from behind me, and I hear a few chuckles dance in the air.

I lean against the door near the exit, not wanting to turn and face him. “Wherever you tell me to go, Zvet,” I seethe, suddenly feeling very hot and both—

A body presses against my back and I fly into the wall in front of me, my nose smashing against the fiberglass. His arm wraps around my stomach, clenching me so tight I sink into his chest. I feel his warm breath against the side of my neck as the tip of his nose runs against my earlobe.

“Call me that again and I’ll kill you.”

I gulp.

Then he loosens his grip around my stomach, his hand traveling up to the front of my throat. “You got that, *Amaya*?”

I grit my teeth. His point is taken—clearly. “Let me go.”

There’s a loud whistle from behind us. “This what it’s going to be for the whole three months? Because fuck me, I’m going to need to call the wife and get her ass sent here.”

Manik releases me, and I turn back around to face him, his eyes hooded in disgust.

I don’t like being looked at like that either, I decide. “Get the fuck off this jet. Now.”

I nod, my lip trembling softly. When did I turn into such a weak woman? Maybe it has something to do with reflection. Maybe if I sit back and think about everything that has happened and been said, I will feel a little bit stronger. Strength comes with knowledge, and right now, I have none.

I drop my bags onto the bed and sink backward until my head hits the mattress and my eyes are locked on the ceiling. He didn’t give me my own room, because of course he wouldn’t. Instead, he has me locked in his penthouse suite of some upscale swanky hotel in the middle of New York City,

while he hits the gym. His first show is in two days, a sold out show at Madison square garden. Am I surprised? No, but I also haven't heard all of this new album, aside from the one song I heard at his party all those months ago.

I twist my head to the side, watching as the clock ticks slowly, the only sound in the room. My thoughts go back to his comment about the clock and him calling all the shots.

I can't focus.

Twisting to the other side, I push my hands underneath my head. There's obviously a bathroom and a massive walk-in closet. Down near my feet is a large window that gives me a direct and clear view of the busy city.

Exhaling, I shut my eyes.

My father was in the Italian mafia. That makes me Italian. My name is Amaya Corvo.

Corvo.

I shoot up from the bed when I remember Vlad calling me *Corvo* all those months ago. I lean back down, shaking my head. I know that Aeron will know everything that I want to know about my past and my parents, but does his words hold substance? I don't think I can trust that what he tells me will be very truthful. I was eight when my parents died, so I don't remember much from before then. I do remember my mom and dad always laughing and kissing. They loved each other very much, and I think they loved me too. The thought stings the corner of my eyes as tears slip out and fall on the blanket.

I wish I knew more. I wish I could know more from their side instead of learning from the enemy. But wishes are pointless. A wish is just a sentence that's said aloud in the hopes of it coming true. They never do. That's just what they want you to think.

I hear the sound of the door unlocking, opening and closing and I grab the blanket, wrapping it around my body.

The sound of keys hitting hard marble is the next thing I hear, but I try to block out his presence so I can roll around in my self-pity for a little bit longer.

"Hungry?"

I don't answer.

"You just not going to talk to me? You're really going to make this fucking hard, aren't you?"

Anger ripples through me and I tear the blanket off my body, shooting to my feet. "You!" I point.

He laughs, his eyes lighting up with amusement.

I scream and launch myself at him, my fist flying toward his cheek. He dodges it, grabs both wrists in his hands and then swings me against a wall. His eyes are on fire, his chest rising and falling and his teeth bared behind a snarl.

I ignore the smell of his sweat mixed with cologne. He's wearing nothing but grey sweat shorts with his shirt tucked into the waistband, hanging out the back.

You will not look at his chest, Beatrice.

Amaya.

God!

"You done?" he asks, his eyebrows shooting high. My eyes drop to his lips and then back to his eyes.

"Not even close," I snarl, trying to snatch my wrists out of his grip but they're still pinned above my head.

His knee comes between my legs. "You hate me?"

"I despise you," I answer quickly.

His smirk deepens, then he lets go of my wrists and licks his lip. “Good. Channel that feeling, Amaya, because that’s the only thing you will ever feel while being around me ever again.”

The words stung as they left his sharp tongue and sliced me in the heart, but I didn’t show it. I have too much pride to give him the satisfaction. “Name’s Beatrice.”

He laughs, turning and disappearing into the kitchen. “Nah, boo. It’s Amaya now.”

I wrap my arms around my body as I slide to the ground.

I really hope this tour doesn’t last as long as I feel it’s going to.

I refuse to go to the show, flat out putting my foot down.

Manik is leaning against the doorframe to the master bedroom of the suite, his arms probably crossed. “You’re not coming, cool, I fucking get that, but I’ll be tying you to that bed and just so you know, there’s a party happening here after—so don’t expect to sleep.”

He goes to walk out of the room when I say, “You’re going to tie me up again, Manik, so I can be at anyone’s disposal? I mean, why not. It’s not like I have anything else left inside me since you’ve taken everything I ever had and made it dirty.”

He must’ve flown across to me so fast because in a blink, his body is hovering over mine and his hand is buried in my hair. He tugs on it so my face tilts up to his, his eyes frantic.

Holy hell.

“One?” he asks, baring his teeth. “Don’t ever fucking go down that road, Amaya. You having a fit because you didn’t *ask* for this life is fucking bullshit. No one asks for the fucking life that they have, but we work with it.” He breathes in and out, his chest pressing against mine with every intake. He closes his eyes, his fingers clenching again, somehow getting a stronger grip on my hair. “Zvet is what my dad called me because I’m a beast, Amaya, I’m not a monster.”

“There’s a difference?” I challenge him softly, my eyes going between his lips and his own eyes.

He searches mine, and his face is so close to mine that I can feel his warm breath fall on my lips. I can feel the heat radiating off of him and pressing into the pores of my flesh. “Yes,” he finally answers. “There’s a difference.”

I keep quiet, wanting him to carry on.

He doesn’t.

He jackknifes off the bed and stomps toward the doorway. “Changed my mind. I won’t lock you up, I’ll just keep one of the boys here to keep an eye out, and Amaya?”

I crawl up the bed, tired of fighting him on the name issue. “Yeah?”

“You might want to crash in the spare room tonight.”

“What?” I answer quickly, just before he takes another step. “Why?”

He tilts his head back. “Because I’ve got a lot of anger to work off.”

He leaves, shutting the door behind himself and leaving me to obsess over his final words.

Does that mean he’s going to...?

I tilt my head on the headboard and bang against it softly. It means he’s going to be bringing someone home tonight.

I shouldn’t care. I don’t care. But the thought of him touching another girl makes my skin crawl and my stomach ache.

I need to get out of this hotel. I need to run. I’ve run from him before, I can do it again. My life, since meeting him, has been a series of me running. Maybe I could go to an internet café and log into my Facebook and message Kat and Kyle.

I slide off the bed and tiptoe toward the bedroom door, cranking it open softly. I step out into the

small hallway and lean over the railing, just slightly, enough so I can see who is downstairs. The TV is on, commentators screaming about a football game. I inch farther until the cream couch comes into view and the top of a head. Black hair, big body, black slacks and traps that could give bodybuilders a run for their money, I instantly know it's Lenny.

"Shit," I cuss under my breath, quickly scuttling backward when his head leans up as if he's heard something.

He probably has. Lenny is always alert. He's always aware of what's going on around him, which is why Manik probably left him with me.

I chew on my lip, crawling backward into the bedroom again and diving toward the end of the bed.

I'll have to wait until an opportunity arises. Even if it's not tonight, I now have enough of a plan brewing inside of my head to start a plan of action.

I just really hope that he doesn't sleep with anyone tonight.

An idea pings in my head. Lenny and I have always been on good terms. Actually, if I'm being honest, I've always felt like he understood me more than even Manik.

I smirk to myself, going to Manik's suitcase and taking out one of his shirts. I haven't worn this shirt since we were together. I shuffle out of my own clothes, leaving my little black boy-short panties on, but ditching the bra. The shirt is a plain white crew neck with the words **MANIAK** scrawled out on the front, then on the back it reads, *Raise Fucking Hell*.

Basically, Manik is apparently a god to these people. I tie the front in a little knot, so my stomach is displayed, and then I tiptoe out of the room, taking my hair out of the high ponytail.

"Lenny?" I ask, making my way down the stairs. "Why are you here?"

He clears his throat when he sees what I'm wearing, his arms twitching a few times. "Ah, Beat, you might want to put some clothes on?"

I laugh sarcastically, ignoring him and going straight for the alcohol that's on the bench. There are already bottles and bottles of hard liquor sprawled out across the counter, with juices, sodas and all sorts of red cups.

Snatching the tequila, I brush my hair out of my face and plonk onto the sofa beside Lenny, ignoring the TV and looking straight out of the large glass window directly ahead of us.

"I need to drink, Lenny."

I don't turn to face him, but I can sense his unease. He shuffles in his seat and then turns to face me. "Fuck," he murmurs, and then turns to face me. "Why?"

I crack the lid and then whack it off with the palm of my hand. I catch him giving that movement a questioning glare, and before he can ask me what the hell move that was, I add, "I went to college."

His shoulders slacken slightly, but then they straighten again. "You don't drink."

I roll my eyes. "As I said, Lenny, I need to drink. That's the difference with me. I'll only do it when I need to do it, and Lenny?" I whisper, my eyes coming to his as my lips wrap around the rim. I take a long pull and wince as the hot liquid burns the back of my throat before it settles deep in my belly. I swipe my mouth. "I should add that I can be a bit of a bad drunk, so, will you please join me? It's sort of not fun if I do it alone..."

He looks at me warily, as if he's having an internal battle with himself. I know Lenny likes me deep down, but not just likes me, but I think he respects me, too. I just hope that after tonight is over that his perception of me won't be too warped.

He takes the bottle and drinks. "What happened with Ae, Beat? He won't talk about it."

I chuckle, taking the bottle back and hitting another long pull. "Oh, he didn't tell you? Hmm, I

wonder why that is.”

The bottle continues to shift between the two of us.

“I don’t know. That’s what I keep asking myself because he tells me everything.” Lenny pauses, his eyes zoning in on me. “But whatever happened, is something he won’t talk about, and trust me, I’m pretty sure I’ve seen him at his worst.”

The adverts start playing on the TV, pizza coming on. My stomach grumbles, but I snatch the tequila bottle. Have I not eaten today? Shit.

I press my knees up to my chest, laying my head against them. I need to slow down, or this plan isn’t going to work. I look at Lenny. “Something bad happened.”

“Bad as in bad or bad as in...really bad.”

“Mmm.” I close my eyes. “Not sure I know how to scale those two options, Len.”

He laughs, rubbing his hand over his chin.

I don’t want to talk about it either, in fact, I’d really love to never think about that again.

“So, you’ve known him for a while, huh?”

“Who?” Lenny asks, his eyes glazed over and heavy.

Hello tequila.

“Manik!” I laugh, hitting him with the back of my hand.

He clears his throat, laying backward on the sofa until his head is resting on the top. “Oh, yeah. I’ve known him since elementary school, but we became best friends in high school.”

“Ah, I see. You were both the untouchable cool kids?” I quirk an eyebrow at him.

He snorts. “Hardly. I mean, Ae? Yeah. No one messed with him. He was always the dark, brooding bad boy that everyone just loved, even though he did bad shit. Me? I was a fucking nerd. Me and the toilet were on a first name basis, ya know?” he murmurs, and I take another drink.

I really should slow down, but truth be told, I’m quite enjoying the talk with Lenny.

“Sorry, no, I don’t know.”

“You were a cool kid?” he asks, smirking.

I scoff. “Nah, I just didn’t really care. I lived right near the beach in Australia. If I wasn’t dancing, I was surfing. I had a best friend, Bindi, and that was that. We did everything together. When I moved back here to the states, we obviously lost touch. I’d really like to catch up with her one day,” I whisper off aimlessly.

“You were doing all of that before you were eight?” He doesn’t believe me, and I guess a lot of people wouldn’t.

“Yeah,” I murmur, setting the tequila on the coffee table. I need to cut myself off before this ends badly. “I carried on when I got here, too though. I don’t get out as much as I’d like, but dancing is my number one.”

He nods his head, his eyes searching mine like he’s truly interested.

His arms stretch out, just as he reaches for his phone in his pocket. He puts it to his ear.

“What?”

There’s silence, and then his eyes come to mine. “No.”

Silence.

“Kat, I’m leaving now.”

I have two options. I could yell and say that he has me here, enough to get her attention, or I could leave it. I decide to leave it, because if Lenny is really going to chill out and open up enough to relax, he’s going to have to believe that I’m not trying to run away.

He hangs up his phone, watching me carefully. “You didn’t want to out yourself?”

I bite my lip, looking away from his penetrating eyes. “No.”

“You got Stockholm Syndrome or some shit? Like I ain’t gonn’ lie, baby girl, you and Ae have a twisted bond.”

I run circles around my knees with my fingertip. “Do you think it’s possible to feel something for someone, but really hate them at the same time?”

Lenny laughs, standing, stretching his arms above his head. “Yeah, Beat, I do, but that’s not what this is that you both have. I don’t think he hates you.”

That earns a full rumble of laughter. “You are kidding, right?” My eyes go up to him.

His face is serious. “No, Beat, I’m not kidding. I’ve known him for a long time, and the thing about Ae is that he doesn’t give a fuck. Drama going on? No fucks. Clingy bitch that won’t get out of his bed? No fucks. His dad sending him off on hunts? No. Fucks. Breaking girl’s hearts? Zero. But you?” He pauses, and my feet ache. I need to stretch them, run, or just walk out of this hotel. “You’re different, you always have been. I called it the second I saw him look at you in the parking lot.”

“Interesting,” I murmur. “I don’t believe you.”

He snorts, walking to the kitchen. I hear him rummaging around in the cupboards before he comes back into the lounge with a bag of chips and some cold pizza. He places them on the table, taking a handful and sitting back beside me.

“You don’t have to believe me, but that doesn’t mean it’s any less true.”

“You have a good point.” I lean over to grab some chips, slowly eating them. When I notice him watching me still, my eyes go up to his. “What?”

“What happened, Beat?”

I scoff the chips into my mouth and then pick up the tequila again, taking a long swig and swallowing. Mmmm, Cheetos mixed with tequila—nope. “Something bad happened to me and I don’t want to talk about it.”

He pauses, and when I peer up at him, I see his face soften. “Was it taken care of?”

My mind flashes back to the blood, the...all the blood. I gulp, clearing my throat. “Um, yes, he took care of it.”

“I rest my case,” he mutters, taking another drink. “Listen, I’m sorry that that happened to you, and if Ae didn’t take care of it, I sure as fuck would, but that further proves my thoughts on Ae and you.”

“What do you mean?” I tuck my legs under my butt and his eyes fly to them before he closes his eyes, as if he’s in pain, and opens them again.

“I mean, him being your knight in shining armor.”

I laugh, shaking my head. “No, that wasn’t it, either. That’s not what that was. He just did something I guess any human would do if they walked in on—” I freeze, my fists clenching together. Sweat thuds down my temples and my breathing slows.

“Beat?” Lenny’s voice is echoing somewhere in the back of my brain, but all I can hear are *his* words. *His* voice. “*You’re so beautiful. I’m going to make love to you.*”

“Beat!” Lenny barks through, his hands clenched tightly around my upper arms.

“What?” I ask, coming back into the now.

“Jesus.” He shakes his head, his eyes searching mine. “Maybe I should put you to bed.”

I pull my arms out of his grip. “I already have Aeron telling me what to do, I don’t need you doing it too. I thought we were friends.”

He exhales, pulling at his hair and leaning back into the sofa. “You’re right. Fuck it. Let’s get drunk. But as I was saying, little Cub, you’re different with him. And no, he wouldn’t usually help girls.” He pauses and then whispers, “He’s done far worse.”

I ignore it and drink.

We've turned the music on and now I'm so far drunk that even just staring at the main door has my mind fuzzy. It's spinning in circles that I can't seem to catch.

"I'm so drunk," I murmur, massaging my head. The song switches to something else and we laugh, dance, drink. Lenny whispers sweet words into my ear that makes me cringe.

Why do they make me cringe? Usually, that would make me blush. Too drunk to touch that right now, I lace his fingers with mine and cling onto his chest. "Lenny," I sigh into his shirt. His arms wrap around my waist, his nose diving into my hair.

"You're going to get us killed if you carry this on..."

I chuckle. "You're so silly. He doesn't care, Lenny!" I yell, just as the song goes to change and the front door slams open, displaying a very angry looking Manik.

I laugh. Again.

Then I stop laughing because crowds of people push past him, yelling, hollering and carrying drinks. Manik doesn't move from his position, his eyes focused on me. He's wearing no shirt, loose dark denim jeans, white sneakers, and a gold chain that's glistening against his rippled chest.

My mouth waters.

No seriously, my mouth is watering. My hand flies up to cover it and I dash quickly for the bathroom downstairs, kicking up the toilet bowl and emptying all of the Cheetos, pizza, and tequila into it.

Pushing my hair out of my face, I groan, sinking onto the floor. Tears gather in my eyes.

"Really? You don't drink but you get drunk with Lenny?"

I let out a harsh laugh, standing to my feet—I almost drop back to the ground when Manik's hand flies out to steady me. "Fuck you're a pain in my ass."

I shove him away, grabbing the mouthwash that's on the counter. "Well, that could be solved if you just let me live my life." The lid isn't opening, and I get frustrated, pulling it and tugging it.

Manik snatches it out of my hands and opens it on the first go. He hands it back.

I take it from him, ignoring the spark of fire that passes between our touch. He quickly backs away.

I gurgle some mouthwash, feeling a little better. "How was the show?" I ask, dabbing a towel over my mouth. I try hard to focus on his face, but I can't. Everything is spinning around me in a blur and for the life of me, I can't take him in.

"You need to go to bed," he answers, pulling me into his chest where I relax instantly. I'm annoyed with myself on levels I didn't know that I had.

"You need to go to hell," I answer through a slur, while leaning into him as he takes me out of the bathroom.

"Been there, got kicked out." He continues to lead me toward the stairs, and then pauses. I try to ignore all the people who are in the lounge, dancing and chatting. I will no doubt one-hundred percent regret this in the morning.

"Up the stairs, Cub, don't make me throw you over my shoulder again."

I take the steps two at a time. If he even tries to do that, I know I'll spew everywhere and what's worse than famous people seeing you in your underwear? Famous people seeing you in your underwear, ass in the air and spew coming out of your mouth and nostrils.

I start walking toward the spare room when his hand catches mine and he tugs me back slightly. I turn to face him, confused. If he needs space to do whatever the hell it is he was wanting to do, there

is no way I'm going to stop him. I know when I'm not wanted, or needed, and aside from the mere fact that he does have a hit on my head, he did see me get...

Get... well, he witnessed it.

He brushes my hair out of my face, his eyes narrowing. "Why do you fuck with my head so much? I'm sorry, Cub."

"Hmmm?" My own head starts spinning, his face fading in and out, smudged with a complete blackout, and then I'm out.



CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR



“I like it”—Cardi B

Manik

I can count on one hand how many people I give a fuck about.

My mom.

My dad.

Katiya—even though she likes to use my patience as her skipping rope.

And Lenny—who shares that same rope.

Everyone who knows me knows this. In fact, you don’t even need to know me, because my reputation speaks for itself. But there’s something Lenny doesn’t know and Katiya just never talks about.

There actually was a girl once.

I don’t know if my feelings were like *that* for her, and I definitely know she never got my dick hard like Amaya does, but nevertheless, there was a girl.

“Yo!” Lenny tosses a drink toward me as I walk down the stairs after putting Amaya to bed. Yeah, I’ve started calling her Amaya, because it helps silence whatever things her mere presence raises inside of me.

My mind plays tricks on me when it comes to her, and I’m fucking lost to its games.

I catch the drink and twist the cap off, taking a long gulp. “You and I need to talk.” I’m not fucking happy with whatever the fuck I walked in on tonight, and I know it’s going to bother me until I get to

the bottom of it.

“Figured as much.” Lenny rolls his eyes and then gestures to the room he’s staying in. I follow him through, dodging all the handshakes and hellos on my way. The party is full of people who work behind the scenes on the tour, their girlfriends/boyfriends, a few little Maniaks and some A-listers who were invited.

I shut the door behind myself. “What the fuck did I walk in on tonight?”

Lenny sobers. “It was harmless. You know I’d never do that to you—”

I laugh, cutting him off. “Lenny, that’s not what I’m talking about. Yeah, I know that you wouldn’t do that to me, but I also know that girl, and she isn’t some easy, dramatic slut that throws herself into anyone’s arms when she doesn’t get her own way.” I pause because the fucker is smiling at me.

“What the fuck are you smiling about?”

He chuckles, leaning back on one elbow on the bed. He’s putting distance between his face and my fist. “Oh, just that you really need to quit playing games. You like her, she likes you, why the fuck don’t we just move on from that? This family will be a much better place to be around.”

I tense, stepping backward until I’m leaning against the door. “I don’t have feelings for her.”

He shakes his head, glaring at me. “Wanna try that again? Maybe with a bit more conviction.”

I take a long pull of my beer. “I don’t.”

He rolls his eyes. “So, if you don’t, then why did you kill some fool who messed with her the other night?”

I still again, my hand clenching tightly around my beer bottle. “Don’t fucking repeat that again, Lenny. Ever.”

Lenny raises his eyebrows at me.

I flip him off. “Fuck you. I said I didn’t have feelings for her, I didn’t say I wasn’t fascinated by her.”

“Define fascinated?” he asks, sitting up and crossing one leg over the other.

“The fuck is this? A fucking therapy session?”

He bats his eyelashes like the little fucker that he is.

I flip him off again. “Regardless of how we used to be, or how we could be together, it doesn’t change the fact that I can’t.” Dad caging me up to bring out Zvet lasted fine—until I saw her. Not only does she not run from my beast, but she pets it, caresses it, and soothes it.

Fuck. This is dangerous ground.

“Why? Because the Bratva?”

I glare at him. “That, yeah, and I don’t know, the fact that I slaughtered her parents? Yeah, that could be it too. And then there’s my dad, her background with the Italian mafia, which she still hasn’t asked me about, and that’s just scratching the surface, so no, Lenny, I don’t have feelings for her.”

“Do so.”

I let out an exasperated breath and pull the bedroom door open. Before I leave, I turn my head to look over my shoulder and pin him with a glare. “Don’t get too close to her.”

He replies with a bored expression.

Lenny is like a toddler in a big body.

I head into the kitchen and grab another drink, flipping it open. The show blew up tonight. I love what I do, but being on tour sets off fires inside of me that I didn’t know were there. They last for the entire time I’m touring, almost like a blur.

This time is different. Everything moved fast. Usually it takes me two years to pull out an album, but this one poured out of me and there was no stopping it. Three months and we were done, ready to

tour. It's surreal, but also unnerving how much power a girl can have.

I'll give credit where credit is due, and she inspired eighty percent of this album.

I unlock my phone and open up iTunes, the cover staring at me as it continues to sit at number one. **F L U K E** by MANIK is number one in album releases. I bet if I opened Spotify, my shit would be blowing up there, too. But everyone's favorite song? *Methodical Madness*. Which just so happens to be the song that Amaya is in.

"Manik?" A voice swerves in behind me, arms snaking around my torso.

I tense, and then turn to face who I know will be Stella Jay. Stella is an actress and just so happens to jump on my dick every time I'm in New York. I don't remember inviting her tonight, but whatever.

I brush her hands away. "Sup, girl. How you been?" I keep it friendly, because as much as I am known to be an asshole to people in general, I don't really want to be one to Stella.

She waves me off, turning to jump onto the counter, her legs dangling off. "Same old, same old." Her brown eyes peer at me, and then drop down my chest. "Who's the girl?"

"What girl?" I ask, teasing her with a wink.

She laughs, shooting back her drink. "Aw, that's not a very gentlemanly thing to say..."

"I think you and I both know I'm no gentleman."

"True!" She raises her finger. "But, who is she?"

"A girl," I add, feeling fucking tired. I'm not up for the partying tonight and would rather just climb into bed with that crazy fucking raven.

"You're being cryptic."

I shake my head. "Nah, I'm not. Hey, I'm going to shut this down soon, so you might want to collect all your shit." That could have come out a lot harsher than she took it, if I'm going by her flinch.

"So, she's a girl who you're kicking me out for?" She flips her blonde hair over her shoulder and jumps off the counter. "Must be some girl." She bounces off and I have to fight the urge to fuck her just to prove a fucking point. Just because I don't want to fuck someone outright doesn't mean there's a special girl. It just means that I can't be fucked.

Not long after the encounter with Stella, everyone leaves and it's just me, Lenny, X, and Bo.

X blazes a joint, handing it to me. I take a long hit, holding the smoke in my lungs before slowly blowing smoke rings out of my mouth.

"Where's the little Cub?" Bo asks, taking the J off me and putting it to his mouth.

I cough, clearing my throat while flicking a lighter between my fingers and reaching for my pack of smokes on the coffee table. I bite one out of the packet, blazing it up. "Asleep. This fucker got her drunk." I gesture to Lenny, who was dancing with his J in his mouth until he figures out we're talking about him and he feigns innocence.

"Hey! It was her idea. She came downstairs looking all sexy and grabbed the tequila."

"Ohhh," X mutters, chuckling. "The girl doesn't even drink and she hit the worm?"

"My point exactly," I reply, puffing on my smoke.

"What's the go with her?" Bo asks, which is valid because Bo hasn't been around much. He's never around much anyway, usually only when we're touring or working on an album.

"We don't even have the time to explore that shit. That's a whole ocean of issues that you don't want to hear about," Lenny chuckles.

I flip him off *again*.

This time his lip curls and gives me one back.

Fucker.

“It’s complicated,” I say instead, brushing the subject off.

“I like complicated,” Bo adds, lining up the coke.

I laugh. “Ho, no, not this kind. Trust me, brother, you don’t want to know.”

“—Or can’t know?” Bo asks, eyebrow raised. He leans forward and takes the line.

I like Bo, enough to keep him around. He’s fairly new, jumping in with us a few years ago.

Whereas Lenny has always been here and X was my boy who I used to shoot bars with in the garage of his house in Compton. I ran away from my home a lot, and X was who I used to stay with. It was a place I could be myself without having the shadow of being a Romanov cast over me.

X and Bo have known each other since they were kids, it’s how Bo got in with us, through X’s reference.

My eyes connect with his. “Bit of that too.”

He nods, shrugging. “I can respect that.” Which is exactly why he fits in with us. He never asks questions about some of the shady shit he sees, and he respects my blood and loyalty to the Bratva—which I have been ignoring since leaving New Orleans. Dad is going to want an update on how I’ve been making Amaya pay, when truthfully, I personally fucking haven’t. I had every plan to do all sort of dirty things to her. I wanted to fucking ruin her, make her despise her life so much that she knew I was the only one who could give her any power.

But when I walked in on Jesse raping her, that all flew to shit, because I realized something that I’m not man enough to look into right now.

I just have to burn time with my old man.

I stand up, declining the line of coke. “Nah man. I’m going to hit it. Got another late flight tomorrow night.”

They all roll their eyes and shove me away. “Yeah, sure that’s why.”

I flip them all off this time.



CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE



“Pick it up”—Fat Joe, Dre

Beat

I can feel it in my soul. I feel what has happened to me every single time I breathe. When I breathe, I can hear his deep sounds, his words being whispered into my ear and his thick thrusting.

I launch off the bed, running straight for the bathroom. I kick the lid up and spew into the bowl.

“Ahh, I feel like shit.”

After one last power chuck, I flush and then shut the door, hitting the shower on. I don’t know what time it is, and I don’t care. I feel, and no doubt look, like shit.

I can wash away the dirt on the outside, but I can’t do it for the inside, and the inside is what is haunting me most.

My soul is tired, soiled and worth nothing. No one will want me after that, and furthermore, I don’t want anyone.

I slip under the pelting hot water, pouring soap into the palm of my hand and spreading it over my skin.

After doing a once over on my hair, I slip out and grab my towel, wrapping it around my body. I push open the door, hoping to tiptoe out to grab some clean clothes, only I’m met with Manik’s bare muscled back. The tattoos that cover the entire canvas warping under his movements.

He inches his head to look over his shoulder. “You good?”

I squeeze the towel. “Feel like shit, actually. Sort of reminded myself why I don’t drink.” I step

deeper into the room. The large glass wall has one big blind that's shading out the morning—or afternoon—sun.

I go to my bag and rummage through it, taking out some new panties, some yoga pants, and a 'I'm a f*cking feminist' shirt. I skip the bra because I'm in such a hurry to put clothes on.

He shifts off the bed, his ass tightening in his brief shorts. I gulp, drying my hair with the towel. "Where to after this?"

He turns, a smile on his face. "You talk like you're not here against your will."

"What can I say," I mutter, unable to hold back the sass. "I'm getting used to it."

He tugs on his jeans, leaving the button undone and all thoughts evacuate my brain.

This isn't fair.

He killed your parents

That did it.

"What time are we leaving?"

He pulls his smokes out of his pocket and lights one. "In about five hours."



CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX



“Here comes the rain again”—Hypnogaja

Beat
Detroit

“You’re coming to this one?” Lenny asks, his eyes going over my body.

I shrug. “What else would I do? Hang around here? No thanks. Detroit is no New York.”

Lenny chuckles. “Do you know where we’re touring?”

I shake my head, adjusting the lace crop top I’m wearing and running my hands over my jeans. They have little rips across the knees and look slightly washed, despite the fact that I bought them early yesterday before we left New York. I took Lenny with me, and I also dipped into the account I really didn’t want to dip into, but I knew I needed clothes, tampons, and all that sort of stuff, and I have more pride than sense. There was no way I was going to ask Manik. ‘Oh hey, captor, so can I spend your money too?’ No.

I run the wand of my lip gloss over my bottom lip, pushing my boobs up higher. Lenny’s eyes narrow. He’s slouching on the bed that Manik and I share. Penthouse everywhere we go with at least four bedrooms, but Manik is always just tossing my stuff into his room so I follow. It doesn’t bother me as much as it should, and annoyingly, I get a good amount of sleep when he’s in the bed with me.

“Ae knows you’re coming?” Lenny confirms, his eyes locking with mine in the full-length mirror.

I don’t meet his eyes. “Yup.”

He doesn’t.

“Alright,” Lenny says, slamming my book closed. Yes, I stopped at a bookstore too, picking up a Stephen King novel. “You have ten minutes then we need to roll out. We’re going through the back entrance, but expect all the cameras and shit—” he pauses, then smiles. “But I guess you’re used to that by now aren’t you, Cub?”

“Wait!” I say, annoyed at his jab. “What is that supposed to mean?”

He raises his eyebrows and then clicks his fingers. “You don’t have a phone. Hold up!” He pulls out his iPhone and taps it a few times. He grins and then passes it to me.

I look down at it and my cheeks flare instantly. Thousands of photos of Manik and I together.

“How? What? We weren’t parading around in public that much?” I go back to search results instead of photos and read the headlines.

Mystery girl has been seen with the infamous Manik, named

I scroll again.

Manik’s new love interest Australian girl with US roots!

MANIK has fallen for a girl from down under...

She’s a well-known dancer, her YouTube channel has over twenty-thousand subscribers! *No doubt this will triple overnight—if not break YouTube!*

WHO IS THIS BEAUTY? We must admit, the Australian beauty is a catch, but this is MANIK!!

I throw his phone back to him like it has a disease. “Shit.”

Lenny laughs, tucking it back and putting it into his pocket. “Shit is right, but nevertheless, your subscribers have skyrocketed.”

“What do you mean?” I ask, tilting my head.

“Well, you had two-thousand, and now you have...” He pulls his phone out again, tapping on it a few times. His eyebrows shoot up in shock.

“What?” I go to grab the phone, snatching it out of his grip.

289,546 subscribers

“No way...” I whisper, throwing it at him again, this time hitting his face.

“Ouch, Cub!” he scolds me, but I’m already stepping backward.

“That’s insane!” I whisper-yell.

Lenny shrugs. “You just need to remember the influence you have now. You’re not playing with an underdog, baby girl, you’re in bed with the fucking alpha.” He casts a glance at the bed. “Literally.”

I shiver. “Is that supposed to make me feel better, Lenny?”

He sighs. “I’ve been feeling so much like a damn therapist lately. If only you both just stopped the bullshit and talked about it.” He sinks into the bed. “Keep getting ready.”

I do, turning back to my mascara. I love makeup, but unfortunately, I have no idea what to do with it. I flick it through my lashes.

“How do you feel about Ae?”

I snort. “I feel like he’s supposed to kill me, because he slaughtered my parents *in front of my eyes* then he kidnapped me *twice* and then, some ass-fuck raped me. So, I don’t know, Lenny, how am I supposed to feel about him? Oh, and he’s a *Vor*, Lenny. As in the shitting mafia! As in his father is the most feared individual walking this earth!” Tears I didn’t know I had slipped from my eyes falling onto my collarbone. I swipe them away angrily.

Lenny’s mouth opens and then closes, and then opens again. “I’m done. You both need to sort your shit out because I have nothing else to say here.”

He leaves, and by this point, I’m ready to drink again. But I don’t, because I can still taste the after effect of the tequila coating the back of my throat.

Gross.

I walk out of the bedroom, landing directly in the sitting room where another man is. He’s in a dark hoodie and dark jeans. His eyes come to mine and I almost lose all train of thought.

He’s... hot. More than hot, I think. Not quite on the level of Manik, but close. He has dark skin, dark eyes, and thick eyelashes.

Then he smiles, and his white straight teeth radiate in the room.

Holy cow.

He nudges his head. “Hey, baby girl, you must be Cubby.”

I cringe at the stupid nickname Manik started, but nod. “I am.” I start walking toward him.

He takes my hand. “Name’s Bo.”

We shake hands and I watch as his big hands cover mine. I’m quite brown because of—now I know—my ethnicity. “Nice to meet you, and you can call me Beat if you like.”

“You’re from Australia?” he asks, shocked.

I shake my head. “Well, I moved there when I was small and then left when I was eight. I guess it still hangs off some syllables.”

He nods. “Yeah, yeah it does.” Then he gives a look to Lenny. “You guys ready?”

Lenny massages his temples. “Why am I always on babysitting duty?”

I pat his arm. “Because you love me.”

I think nothing of the words I just spat out, and it’s not until I leave the room that I realize they’re not following me. I turn back to face them. “What?”

I roll my eyes when I figure out it’s because I dropped the L word. “Oh, it’s a frigging word. Chill out.” Then I storm down the hallway. I settled on Doc Martens with my skinny jeans, because Docs are awesome and because If I have the urge to run—I won’t have trouble. Taking heels off can mess with plans.

The drive to the arena isn’t long, and within thirty minutes we’re pulling up to the back of a large stadium. There are bodyguards and security everywhere, as well as some police. More than that, the paparazzi are *everywhere*.

“Do they not know that he’s not actually outside, like he’s performing? Who are they hoping to catch?” I mumble, annoyed as I step out of the back seat. Bo and Lenny crawl out behind me, both taking me in their arms and turning us away from the flashing cameras. “You, baby girl. They’re hoping to get you.”

As they both lead me to the back door, the security guard opens it quickly so we can slide inside, Bo looks at Lenny. “Does she know how much buzz is around her?”

“I’m right here, you can just ask me, and the answer is no, I don’t.”

“How do you not know?” Bo scoffs, grabbing my arm and turning me down the long corridor. The

thudding of a heavy base fills the space, but not enough for us not to be able to hear each other speak.

“Oh, because my master took my phone privileges away.”

Bo pauses, then laughs. “Damn, homeboy plays hardball.”

“You could say that,” I murmur.

Just as we reach a door where another security guard is standing, Bo pulls me back slightly, his eyes coming to mine. He seems to be thinking about something, so I egg him on. “Ask me.”

“Fuck it,” he says, licking his lip. “You seem like a smart girl. Why do you allow this to happen?”

I smile weakly. “Because there are some messes that you just can’t walk away from, or tidy.”

He looks confused, so I leave him there, following Lenny who has now taken my hand. The guard nods his head, opening the door and instantly the music pours out in beautiful waves of therapy.

I recognize the song, it’s one of his old ones called “Reform.” He’s rapping about being between two lives. Where Jekyll and Hyde are both evil and no matter what choice or path he takes, he’ll still be taking that other with him. The song ends with him killing himself because he isn’t able to take the pressure anymore. The song after “Reform” on the album is about suicide. As I said, Manik is a lyrical genius, a god in the industry, and he didn’t get there by talking about ho’s, bitches and money. It’s also what got him respected too, and his flow? Unmatched.

The dark lights lower as the song ends and the crowd loses their minds. The screams and yells from his fans break my eardrums and I quickly cover them, looking up at Lenny, who’s pulling me to the front of the stage, past the VIP section. I don’t even look to see who’s in the VIP section, but my eyes drift over the girls at the front, when out of hundreds and thousands of girls, one catches my eye.

Hoodie over her face, her arms not above her head. She’s not moving, her blonde hair going over her shoulders.

It’s ghost girl!

I tug on Lenny, but he ignores me, picking me up at my waist and putting me over the rail. He jumps it next, taking me to the corner but at the front—basically where the security all stand to guard.

“What?” Lenny asks into my ear.

“There’s this girl! Since I got to New Orleans, she’s been follo—”

The light flashes onto the stage and Manik is standing there, a mic to his mouth. He smirks out at his fans, and the song starts. I haven’t heard this song yet. It has a slow, poetic rhyme to it. It’s different, the beat slow, but the rap fast. The tune is hypnotic, and then the base drops and takes my heart with it. Manik starts rapping fast, spitting the lyrics smoothly.

In the first verse, I think he’s talking about something new. Confusing. Then the chorus comes in and he motherfucking sings. My legs shake so hard that I almost lose balance, gripping onto Lenny. He laughs, his arm snaking around my waist to steady me.

“You like this song?” Lenny asks, searching my eyes with mischief in his.

I nod, biting my lip. “He can sing too?”

Lenny leans back into me. “Yeah, girl, he can.”

I inch up on my tiptoes. “What’s the song called?”

Lenny licks his lip, his eyes going up to Manik and then coming back down to me. He leans into me. “Methodical Madness.”

“New?” I mouth up at him.

Lenny nods, his eyes speaking a thousand unspoken words. “Yeah, Cub, it is.”

I bob my head to the beat as he dives into the next hook. Then the ball drops because I hear my name. Not my actual name, but...

“That’s it baby, do the damn thing and take it slow. You’re fucking running this show, little

Cub, just give me some of that methodical madness and I'll take away your sadness...”

A rock forms in my throat. What?

Lenny pulls me in closer, leaning down my ear. “Don’t think too much into it. He wrote all this when you and he were together.”

I knew that, but it was still something that hit me deep in my heart and my belly. I’m so confused by everything. Lenny is right, we do need to talk. I’ve never been a girl who was into playing mind games with guys or anything like that.

Manik stops rapping and it’s then that I look up at him and his eyes are directly on mine. He’s breathing heavily, his bare chest on display for everyone to look at. In an instant, I feel hundreds of thousands of eyes on me. They must have all followed his sight.

His snarl turns into a grin, one so evil and so dark, that I know I’ve done something bad. He brings the mic to his mouth. “Whatcha doin’ here, Cub?”

The crowd lets out a loud gasp.

Oh great, so everyone knows my nickname too.

“Ah,” I whisper, and then I want to smack myself because of course he can’t hear me.

He leans in, his hand cupping his ear. “What’s that, baby, I can’t quite hear you.”

My mouth slams shut. I want to flip him off, but I don’t. I swear to God, if he—

“—So I don’t know if any of you know this, but my girl is a dancer. She has a YouTube channel of all sorts of sexy shit. She says she’s not a fan of hip-hop and rap, she prefers old-school jazz.”

“Lenny,” I whisper harshly, nudging him with my elbow. “I will kill him if he calls me up there.”

Lenny laughs, his head tilting back. “He won’t.”

“Come ere’ Cubby. Come show everyone what you’re made of.”

I shake my head. “Nope.” I give him a death-glare too.

He shrugs. “First warning.” Then turns back to the band and nods his head as the next song plays.

I’m sweaty, so sweaty that my skin is pelting with heat. He moves through each song and dances, too! He’s so talented it blinds me. When he wraps it up, Lenny pulls me toward backstage, shoving the curtains out of his way when we bang into Bo again, who is clearing his nostril and swiping the white powder off his finger by sucking on it.

We’re about to leave when Manik’s voice stops me in my tracks. “What the fuck are you doing here, Cub?” he asks from behind me, his angry tone bouncing off the empty concrete walls.

I slowly turn around, ignoring Lenny’s pleas for us to not start a fight right now.

“I wanted to come and watch instead of being locked up in a hotel room,” I answer smoothly, only a hint of annoyance in my tone.

His jaw clenches, his chest rising and falling as he, I can imagine, tries to tone his anger down.

He slowly starts walking toward me in a way a lion stalks toward its prey. “You had one thing to do. Stay your ass there.”

“I didn’t want to,” I challenge him, ignoring everyone in the corridor.

His eyes narrow. “Get the fuck out and I’ll see you later.”

“No!” I say, crossing my arms over my chest.

“No?” he asks, but it wasn’t him asking me, it was more him confirming with himself that I really did just say that.

“We need to talk.”

“I’m not a talker.” He looks to Lenny. “Take her ass home. Now.”

“If you think for on—” Everything tips upside down and I’m face-to-face with Lenny’s ass. “I swear to God, Lenny! I will hate you if you don’t put me down right now!”

His steps speed up until we're at the end and a door cracks open. "Sorry, baby girl, he's right." Cameras start flashing and people are yelling. My hands cover my face in absolute horror as he opens a car door and tosses me inside before quickly sliding in beside me. The limo takes off, but I shoot to the other side, as far away from Lenny as I can get. "That wasn't fair."

"Life's not fair, and Beat? Don't force the words out of him. He'll just get mad. Save the talk for the right time, and the right time is never right after a show."

We remain silent all the way back to the hotel. With every mile, my anger subsides and by the time we're pulling up to the underground parking garage of the hotel, my guilt is in full-blast mode. I grab the door handle, my shoulders slumping. "I'm sorry, Lenny."

I open it and climb out, him behind me.

"You don't need to be sorry, baby girl, but let's get you into bed."

After cleaning up, I slide into the silk sheets, moaning at how it slides off my skin. Or maybe I'm feeling ultra sensitive—who knows. My eyes drift closed eventually, falling into a deep sleep.

The bed sinks, jolting me awake. The strong smell of something toxic like whiskey fills the dark space. My eyes go to the little alarm clock on the bedside table, telling me it's just after three a.m.

Should I say something? Or should I leave it. Lenny is right, I have to wait until he wants to talk. I may be okay with expressing my emotions, but he isn't and isn't familiar with it.

"Tomorrow," I say, clearing my throat. I feel his movements halt before he drops down over the top of the covers.

"Not tonight, Beat, not fucking tonight."

"I was going to say I want to know about my parents..." I add quickly before sleep takes hold of him.

He chuckles, but it comes from drowsy lips. "You wanna know? Okay, let's do this," he murmurs, and then burps, and then clears his throat. "Your mom used to date my dad—she actually fucking met your dad through mine. She was a rat and a disloyal fucking chipmunk. Your dad? He's a piece of shit too. He killed my mom when I was six, on my sixth birthday. I watched him do it, and then every birthday after that until I killed him, he had a parcel sent to my house, a body part of hers gift-wrapped for me, and even before that, he tried to kidnap me as a baby, so yeah, Amaya, you may have valid reasons to hate me for killing your parents, but I was an angry twelve-year-old boy who was trained to taste blood and hunt. You were nothing to me. Are nothing to me. But, even more so, why the fuck wouldn't I end two people who caused me and my family so much pain?"

His words are so harsh that I didn't even realize I was holding my breath, tears drowning my face. "That's awfully cruel, Manik. I can't believe my parents would do that. I saw another side..."

He pauses and then shrugs. "You saw them as parents, I didn't say they were shit parents, I said that they were shit humans, and that means jack shit to me, baby. It is the truth and there's nothing I can do to sugarcoat it for you."

"But, that first night that we met?"

He pauses. "My dad set that up. He wanted you on my radar. He pulled the plug when he saw that we had become involved with each other, though he said he wasn't all that surprised. He has been following you since you were a little girl, Beatrice. You think that you were ever free? You will never be free. Your fate is in my hands, and I gotta say, my grip isn't very firm these days."

He drifts off to sleep after that, leaving me to marinate in my own thoughts. I knew this would happen when I asked him, but that didn't take away the sting.



CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN



“Bad at love”—Halsey

Beat
London

“But why only do two US shows?” I ask, peeling open the cookie dough. Store bought, because I just need it.

“Because it makes my presence worth more or some shit. I don’t know, my PR sorts that out.”

I haven’t met his PR, but I know his producer’s name is Paul.

“What are you doing?” Manik asks, pointing at the cookie dough.

My eyes fly around the lounge where Lenny, X, and Bo are lounged out, watching some crime show on TV about a serial killer.

“Because I’ve been traveling for what feels like days and I feel like it.” I curl my feet under my butt, sucking the cookie dough off my fingers.

Manik shuffles beside me, snatching it out of my hand. “If you’re going to be sucking on your fingers like that, I’ll throw this shit out right now. Probably save you fucking food poisoning.” He opens it properly and gives it back to me, his arm falling over the top of the sofa.

“Thanks.” I smile weakly at him, biting out of the log.

“That’s nasty, baby girl.” X shakes his head, taking a hit off his joint.

I shrug. “It tastes delicious. Want some?”

He shivers. “No.”

Everyone goes back to watching the TV when Manik says, “There’s an artist here that I see every time I’m in town. You want anything while we’re here? He always cancels his schedule for me.”

I almost choke on my sugar and carbs. “Sorry.” I clear my throat. “Who is he?”

“They call him Raptor. Google him if you want.”

I roll my eyes. “With my imaginary phone? Okay...”

He gets up from the couch and disappears into our bedroom, coming out a few seconds later with my phone in his hand. He tosses it to me. “Don’t pull anything slick, Beat, I will not think twice about punishing you, and before you ask, no, this doesn’t mean anything has changed.”

I squeeze the phone in my hand as he flops back down beside me. I look at him, watching as the flashes from the screen highlight his sharp jaw and prominent cheekbones. I like his nose ring too, a lot. I think it adds an edge to his almost pretty features. I say almost because you can’t really call a man like Manik “pretty.”

“Stop looking at me like that, Cub and just take it as it is.”

“Okay,” I whisper, honest to God shocked that he’s giving it back to me. “Aeron?”

His eyes lock with mine. A second passes between us, an unspoken conversation between the silence. My heart thunders in my chest and my legs shake from the angst. “Thank you.”

He finally drags his eyes back to the TV. “Yeah, no problem, Cub.”

“God, I always wanted to come to London,” I admit as we enter the tattoo parlor. A small girl pops her head up from the counter, and then her face freezes as she drops back down.

“Ah,” Manik mutters, confused where the girl went. “Here to see Raptor.”

She slowly bobs her head up again, a shy smile on her face. “Sorry, he didn’t warn me that you were coming in today.”

“Man?” a deep voice says from one of the booths at the back of the store. They’re all open, so privacy is a no.

Manik walks toward “Raptor” who is a mid-fifty-year-old, and what I would call a DILF. He has grey hair and tattoos all over his skin, a long beard and a very tidy cut to his hair, the rest of the top slicked back.

“This is...” Manik seems to think over his words. I don’t blame him, I’m confused as well about my identity. He shrugs. “Beatrice. She’s getting something today too.”

He looks me up and down, his eyes fixing on my sleeve. “You got anymore other than that beauty on your arm?”

I nod. “Yeah, and this.” I turn around and lift my shirt, revealing the small little phoenix on the side of my lower back.

“Nice,” Raptor says. “So, you got something in mind for today?”

I turn back to face them, nodding my head. I did. I knew what I wanted, because after I googled my last name last night, I found out a lot. First of all, it’s Italian for raven, and second of all, I think, judging by the news headlines that showed up on Google, my parents were bad people. The one thing I haven’t added up is where they got their nasty behavior from because my pops and nona were amazing.

“I want to get raven wings across my shoulder blades.”

Manik freezes, but I don’t meet his eyes.

Raptor grins. “That’s a biggie, will take a couple sittings, you up for that?”

I nod. “Yeah, I am.”

When I look back to Manik, his jaw is clenched, and his fists are tight on the side of his body.

This is my way of taking back some of the control I feel like I've lost over the past few months that my life has turned upside down. If he doesn't like it then tough shit.



CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT



“Control”—Halsey

Beat
Sydney, Australia

Being back here brings back memories I don't want to raise. Driving over the bridge that I felt so warm toward is now giving me flashback memories of burnt ash and flesh.

Manik doesn't come back after the show, either. I'm annoyed that I've found myself tossing and turning in bed waiting for him like a housewife.

They all went out, too, not just him. He left me unattended for the first time. I think he's still mad about the wings—that are now finished and amazing—because he hasn't spoken to me much since then. Even at the show in London, he ignored me all night when he usually would lock eyes with me for a couple seconds every now and then during a show. At tonight's, it was the same. He flat out acted as if I wasn't there, and he wasn't the only one who did this. Lenny, Bo, and X also ignored me.

I felt like an intruder now and everything was slowly starting to become clear.

I sit up in the bed, clutching the blanket with me. Maybe he wants me to leave? It makes sense because none of them can speak to me now. I feel unwanted and like a pest. I've overstayed my welcome even though I didn't ask for it in the first place.

I drag myself out of the bed, checking the time on my phone. I texted Kyle and Kat when I was in London, filling them in on bits that I could. They were both happy to hear from me, but Kat wanted to kill her brother. Again. I'm so thankful for their friendship.

I flick the light on, noticing it's just before midnight. Dragging my bag out from under the bed, I go to the bathroom, dumping all my stuff back in. My heart feels heavy and my head thuds with sadness.

Why do I feel sad! He captured me, hunted me, and locked me up. Twice.

I quickly zip my bag up after taking out a hoodie and some yoga pants, putting them both on. I squeeze my feet into my runners and then make my way out to the lounge. I take one more look around the place, at all the items I've come to know.

Lenny's cap sitting on the kitchen counter and the night we got tequila drunk and I wore it.

Bo's rolled up dollar bill. Unfortunately—cue the sarcasm—I don't have a personal memory with that, but it still is Bo's.

X's Nintendo DX is on the counter, no doubt with Fortnite on sleep mode or PUBG. The night he tried to teach me how to shoot people on Fortnite, but I got shot instead. He had said that I wouldn't last long in the hood, and he was probably right.

I step out to the foyer, shutting the door behind me and quickly make my way out onto the busy streets of Eastern Sydney.



CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE



“Shameless”—The Weeknd

Manik

“Do you know what you’re going to do?” Bo asks, his eyes staying on the stripper who’s rubbing her shit all over him. She makes her way toward me, but I shake my head.

“One, I push her away and work on Dad. Two, I keep her, figure shit out with Dad, or three, I give her some fake passport, some cash, and tell her to run and never come back again.”

“And have you made a decision?” Bo further asks, his head tilting on the stripper as he tucks dollar bills under the strap of her G-string.

Lenny still hasn’t said a word to me after our disagreement in London.

“Yeah,” I murmur, my eyes going to Lenny. “Got her passport and shit ready.”

Lenny tsks under his breath, shaking his head and sinking the rest of his drink as he gets to his feet. His glare cuts to me. “It’s the wrong fucking thing to do and you know it, Ae.”

He leaves, slamming the booth closed on his dramatic departure.

The boys stay quiet.

X clears his throat. “You gonna tell us why exactly this is so dangerous having her around?” he asks, flicking a toothpick around his mouth.

“I can’t get into it, bro, but it’s a bad thing. This is the best I can do.”

We leave not long after that, dragging Bo away from the strippers. I’ve been cold on Beat since London because I realized I had fucked up and Lenny was right. I had grown feelings for her, and I’m

finally able to admit that, but that doesn't take away the fact that I can't have her.

Admitting my feelings for her is step one on a list of unlimited reasons why this won't work.

We walk into the hotel room and I instantly know something is wrong. If Lenny didn't come storming out of the room in a beeline for me, I would still know.

"She's gone."

I close my eyes, clenching my jaw. "I know where she'll be."



CHAPTER FORTY



“My Love”—Justin Timberlake

Beat

The loud crashing of waves ripple over the sand, unleashing salt to dance in the air. I shiver, running my hands up and down my arms. I don't know what I'm going to do, and for all I know, Manik is already about to kill me. Living my life in fear has become tiring, more tiring than I ever expected it to be.

“Beatrice?” a soft voice says from behind me and I take my eyes away from the dark waves, turning my head to look over my shoulder to see who it is, when my eyes fall on the ghost girl I've been seeing every now and then since becoming involved with Manik.

What. The. Hell.

I quickly get to my feet, swiping the sand off my pants while brushing my hair out of my face. “Who are you?” I ask skeptically.

“Ah.” She clears her throat.

“Drop the hoodie and show me your face.” I squeeze the strap to my bag. What an absolute idiot coming to the beach on my own.

“I can't, I'm sorry, but Beat I don't have much time...”

Her voice sounds familiar in a way that I can't quite put my finger on.

“I'm listening,” I take the bait because she's been following me for so long, I guess she has something important to tell me.

“You’r—”

“—Cub!” Manik’s voice ripples through the urgency of her tone.

I turn toward him, my eyes popping open. Shit. I look back to the girl, but she’s gone.

Damnit.

“What the fuck are you doing?” He steps up to me, grabbing my hand.

I pull it away. “I’m leaving.”

He chuckles, snatching my hand again and dragging me back toward where he came from. “Yeah, you are, but not like this.”

I pull my hand away, fed up with the cryptic mess. “Aeron!” I scream, frustrated that he’s listening to me but not hearing me. “What is going on?”

He turns to face me, his eyes flying around frantically and then he exhales through a dark chuckle. Pulling at his hair, he bites his fist. “Fuck it.” Then takes two steps into my space, grabs my face between the palm of his hands and smashes his lips against mine.

I’m so shocked that it takes me a few seconds to register what is happening, but by that time comes, my mouth has opened and my tongue is in his mouth, his in mine. I moan slightly, my legs shaking. My feet feel weightless, like I could take flight any second.

My hand comes to the back of his neck and I push into him more. It’s explosive. He lights an inferno deep inside of me and I don’t care if I burn.

He pulls away slightly, his hands still against the sides of my head. He presses his nose to mine, shaking his head slightly. “You have to leave, Cub, this won’t work, and I need you safe, you feel me?”

I swallow, relishing the feeling of being locked in his arms again. “I’ve changed my mind. I don’t want to anymore.”

He smiles, and goddamnit it’s beautiful. Full white teeth stretch out from under his perfect semi-swollen lips, his dimples creasing into his cheeks. “Right person, wrong time, Cub.”

I chew on my bottom lip, my heart sinking in my chest. “I think I love you, though.”

He lets out a breath that sounds so pained I feel it stab right through my chest, then he drops to the sand, pulling his legs up to his chest, his eyes going out to the ocean.

Maybe I shouldn’t have said that.

Why did I say that? Oh my God, I’m messed up.

He killed my parents.

But, after all the researching, the stories I had heard and taking into the fact that he was a twelve-year-old boy. Combining all the facts I have, I find myself not taking what he did into consideration.

My heart doesn’t care what he has done, because Delila was right.

I may not be a dark person with demons inside of me, I may not even have the right amount of darkness to show him the way like Kat said either, but every bit of what makes me, me was handcrafted to fill his emptiness.

“I’m sorry,” I choke out, taking a seat beside him. “Maybe I shouldn’t have said that.”

He shakes his head and snorts. “Nah, babe, it’s not that you said it...” he starts, then leans back on one elbow, his eyes coming to mine. “It’s that I fucking felt it when you said it. You’re lethal for me, Beatrice. You’re not just a switch to my humanity, you’re a goddamn trigger for my rage too.”

I hide my face behind my arm, trying to squash the butterflies roaring in my belly.

“I can’t say those words back to you right now, Cub, not because I don’t feel them, because...” He pauses, shakes his head and then looks back out to the ocean. I try to ignore the way his jaw clenches and his dark eyelashes fan over his high cheekbones. “Because if there’s anyone who could

ever make me say them, it's you, but I can't, Cub. I can't say it to you right now because those words are the key to a future I can't offer you."

It's a verbal punch to the gut, but I know he's right.

I sniffle, swiping the tears away from my cheeks. "I hate this."

"Come here." He wraps an arm around my waist and pulls me into his chest. I curl into him, my leg going over his as he lays down on his back. For a few seconds, we stay there with nothing but the sound of crashing angry waves. I can't help but compare my feelings to the ocean right now. Calm from behind, but raging and angry once they hit the ground.

His arm squeezes around me and he buries his face into my hair. "I'm fucking sorry about what happened in The Pen, Cub. Fuck." The way he said *fuck* yanks at every nerve I have inside of me.

I shake my head, my hand finding his. "It's not your fault."

He kisses my head again, lacing our fingers together. "I've done some bad shit. I don't mean bad, I mean fucking evil shit. Shit that will make you think I was made by Satan himself, and maybe I am because look who my dad is, but nothing, and I mean *nothing*, will ever haunt me the way those split seconds I saw you like that. I want to bring him back to life just so I can kill him all over again. He has a family, maybe I can start there to ease it back a little." He almost murmurs the end of that sentence, like he's sort of giving himself ideas.

I sit up, pressing on his chest so I can look down at him. "No. Don't do that, it's not their fault and besides, look at how messed up our families are."

His eyes are on mine, his face passive. "Okay, baby." He pulls me onto him, his face diving into my neck. "One last time."

I swallow past the pain, my tears streaming down my cheeks. I nod, my lips coming to his. He licks the salt off my lips and then continues licking up my cheeks. "Don't cry, it wakes my beast and I'm trying to be gentle with you for once."

I kiss him again, unzipping my hoodie. "One last time."

But even as the words leave my mouth, I can feel my heart snapping in my chest.

Aeron Romanov-Reed is undeniably the best thing I never had.

Ghost Girl

Beatrice Kennedy knows everything while knowing nothing at all. She thinks she's special to him? She's not. I thought I was, once upon a time. There's so much I know that she doesn't, but not for long. She will know it all soon. All in good time, and maybe he will come back to me.

I'll find her behind his back and I'll tell her everything.

Dried leaves crack under the sole of my shoe as I peer back at them on the beach.

Beat is on top of him, her chest is out, her tits in his hands, and then in his mouth. She runs her hands through her long jet black hair as her hips rock over him.

He kisses her.

He kisses her.

Then his arm wraps around her waist and he yanks her down on top of him. I smirk. He's still a little rough with her even though you can see he's trying to be gentle. He bites on her nipple and tugs on it between his teeth. Her moan is enough to set birds flying out of trees. He wraps his hand in her hair, and tugs on it, but then he shoves her mouth down onto his as she rides him. They never break

their kiss and the slapping of their bodies plays as a backdrop to the soaring waves.

My face falls. He loves her.

He's already so obviously given her more than he ever gave me. I can't turn her against him. It's too late. I will just have to let them be and take the next best thing.

Her.

I take off on a sprint, running as fast as my legs will take me. I pass trees, streetlights, and cars in a whiz. I don't know where I'm going and don't know how long I've been running until I come to a stop.

Sweat drips down my face, my clothes are drenched. I look up at the house I'm standing in front of, swiping my mouth.

Three sixty-five River Ridge Road.

Memories flash through my brain.

"No! I have the better one, see?" I say, laughing and pointing toward my surfboard. "My aunt gave it to me." I ran my hands over the smooth board, and when she doesn't answer me, I looked over my shoulder.

My eyes land on hers.

With long black hair and the brightest green eyes I had ever seen. Beatrice Kennedy stood there with a grin.

"Shut up, Bindi. Mine is retro."



CHAPTER FORTY-ONE



“Cinema (Skrillex Remix)”—Benny Benassi

Beat

“I can’t do goodbyes. Ever,” Lenny says, pulling me in for a hug.

I don’t answer. I can’t. Last night is still in my mind. How can the best night of your life also be the worst night of your life? We stayed at the beach all night until the sun started to crack the sky.

Manik is standing against the Escalade. His hoodie is over his head and his hands are in his pocket.

I look up at Lenny, a rock in my throat. “Please look after him.”

Lenny’s eyes soften around the edges, and he squeezes me again. “I’ll try my best, though history would show I’m not very good at that.”

I shove him playfully. “You’ve practically known him all your life, Len, of course you can.”

He shakes his head, kissing me on the top of my head. “Nope, I’m afraid only one person can do that, and she’s about to go AWOL.”

He steps backward, out of my reach and my face falls.

This sucks. I hate goodbyes.

Bo and X both give me brief hugs, and a small nod from Manik’s driver-slash-whomever he really is.

That leaves one more person.

Manik pushes off the SUV, looking to the side briefly before taking me in his arms. I bury my head

into the crook of his neck, where his hoodie meets his skin.

“I love you,” I whisper, my lips trembling. Then before he can say anything else, I push away from him and run onto the plane.

I take two steps into the jet when my legs collapse and uncontrollable cries rip out of me.

I stay there until the flight attendant Manik uses for his jet comes down to help me, touching my arm. “Come on, Beatrice. Let’s get you in your seat, we’re about to take off.”

I nod, swiping the snot from my nose and falling into the seat where I have sat for the last month that we’ve been touring. This whole jet is laden with memories, raw memories I never want to touch again.

The flight attendant helps me put my belt on—because I’m apparently incapable—and then leans down next to me. “Aeron wanted you to take this. Everything you need to know is in this box. Please read it on the trip, take out the passport and the money, but everything else needs to be burned.”

I nod, taking the small black box from her. She disappears behind the drapes and as the jet gains speed on the runway and my stomach aches in pain, I open the box and my eyes land on a photograph.

It’s a very young looking Vlad, and my mother. They looked happy. She sat at a table on his lap while other men in suits sat around them. Vlad had a cigar hanging out of his mouth and a fedora on, grinning at the camera. The photograph is black and white, with grain and scuff covering it. My mom has her long black hair tucked behind one side and her smile is innocent, looking up at the camera.

I can’t help but smile. That’s how I knew my mom, only wrong lap.

I drop the photo back into the box, revealing the one behind it. It is a photo connected to a letter.

The photo showed my mom and dad standing over a dead woman’s body, blood seeping from her head while a little boy stood in the background, his face pale and eyes dark. He looked lost, heartbroken, and stripped of his innocence.

Aeron.

New tears ran down my cheeks. He wasn’t lying.

I start reading the letter, even though the mere thought of what it could contain brings me so much pain that I can’t move.

Vladimir Romanov.

We had fun with your wife. Next time, this will be your precious son, daughter, or that girl you keep bonded to your house.

Signed.

You know who.

I throw them back into the box like they contain some disease and then grip onto the passport and thick envelope.

I feel sick. How can my grandparents be so sweet, so loving, when that was their daughter?

I open up my new passport and my eyes fall on the name instantly.

Amaya Romanov-Reed

Air leaves me as I slam it closed again. Was that smart? Putting his last name on it? Maybe it was, because maybe Vlad will never look at the obvious.

Those damn possessive flags...



CHAPTER FORTY-TWO



“Can’t C Me”—2Pac

Manik

“You’re smart,” Lenny says as we make our way back to the hotel.

“Questionable.” I run my finger over the top of my lip.

“Tell me you have a plan because there is no way that I can never see her again. She became a part of our family, Ae, you can’t—”

“—Lenny? Shut the fuck up. As you said, I’m smart.”

He exhales in relief, leaning back against the chair. “Thank fuck. So, tell me, what’s the plan?”

“First of all, cancel all the remaining shows. I need to get back to New Orleans.”

“Done,” Lenny mutters, pulling out his phone and typing. Probably to Vanessa, my PR. She’s a fucking pain in my ass, but she does her job well.

Landing back in New Orleans isn’t easy, not without Beat, but I’m focused on what the fuck I need to do. I need to call a meeting with the Bratva and get to the bottom of whatever this is, and then make sure they don’t chase Beat. That’s my main concern right now, is making sure she is safe. I have eyes on her at all times anyway, but I need to deal with my dad. He’s a threat to her, which means he’s now a threat to me.

On our way back to my house, I hit call on his name.

He answers. “Syn, give me some good news. I saw you canceled your shows, I’m gathering this

means everything is going well.”

“We need to talk,” is all I say, my tone flat. “Call a meeting within the family.”

There’s a long pause. “You don’t want to test me on this, Syn...”

“I’m not. Call me with a time.” Then I hang up and dial Kat.

She picks up instantly. “Ae? What’s going on? I saw you canceled your trips. By the way, Lenny needs a punch in the dick for manhandling our girl like that and in front of paparazzo, nonetheless.”

My girl...

“Yeah, we need to talk. How soon can you be over?”

Silence. “Give me twenty minutes.”

I massage my temples, the jetlag means jack shit when I have the stress of Cub’s safety in my head.

Fuck. And she’s not even mine anymore because I fucking let her go.

Fuck that, she’ll always be mine.

“Penny for your thoughts?” Lenny says, an eyebrow arched.

I flip him off.

Buttoning up my jacket, I rest my head on the headrest as Jason drives us toward Severyane restaurant, where Dad has called the meet. Not sure why he chose this place, aside from the fact that it is now, and has been, under our protection since it was built twenty-or-so years ago, but we usually have *vstrecha* at his house. Not here.

I crane my neck as the limo pulls into the parking lot. Seeing the Bratva always brings back memories for me—not so much bad. But, one that I haven’t touched on for some time is the night of my initiation when I became a Vor. There were three of us, and the room we entered was dark. It was at an underground club and the only beam of light was the candles lining a large round table.

There laid an old dagger and .50 pistol. You live by the dagger and pistol and you die by the dagger and pistol. It was made vehemently clear that you don’t quit the mafia.

Beside my dagger and pistol, items that I would now own, that were once my fathers, laid a card. On the card was a saint. Mine had the sacred heart of Jesus on it. My eyes flew up to my father, who sat at the head of the table, his hat shading his eyes so only his jaw was on display.

He smirked.

I knew the meaning of this, because he was a god. He was the boss. To his left was the consigliere, then to his right was the Underboss, who is also my uncle (not by blood) Aslan Ivankov. He was my father’s best friend since they were young kids. Then beside both of them were the three capos and their favorite soldier.

I ignored everyone else in the room, including the two who were getting initiated in with me. Rolling up my sleeve, I gave the dagger, handle side, to my father, who raised it to my lip and sliced it across lightly, enough to draw blood. I then squeezed the blood onto the saint card and handed it to my father, who then set it alight. As he passed it around the table, I pledged my loyalty to the Bratva until the end of my time. When the card finally got back to me, I quickly said the final script of my pledge and blew the flame out.

Herein lies my problem, no one leaves the mafia without a bullet. There has been a couple of exceptions, but none of those who did were the son of a boss. I had big boots to fill, and letting go of the family would mean letting my father down. I know without a shadow of a doubt that my dad would put a bullet between my eyes if I ever thought of leaving the Bratva. He loves me, but he loves his pride more. Which is why I needed to step around this very carefully if I still wanted to be able to

hold my balls in my hand by the end of it.

Getting out of the car, I make my way through the front entrance and head straight for the back, staff area, not paying anyone any attention. Pushing the doors open, my eyes go straight to Dad who's sitting at the head of the table, a cigar in his mouth.

I lick my lips, bobbing my head at him because as much as I'm a king out there to most of the world, in here, in the Bratva, I'm just a fucking prince and Vladimir is the king. Respect is the only way you get anywhere in life, and I know when to give it and when I should be getting it.

"Syn," Dad says, gesturing to the seat on the opposite side of the table.

I pull the chair back, unbuttoning my jacket and flicking it out.

"We're all here for your news on the Corvo girl. Update me, Syn, because I'm not feeling very confident in your decisions as of late."

I pull my cigarettes out and bite one into my mouth, sparking the end. I blow out a thick cloud of smoke. "The Corvo family was my hit. My job, correct?"

Dad leans back in his chair, his face is relaxed and calm, but his eyes are like hot lasers shooting right through me. There's a silent conversation going on there that only he and I can get on level with.

"Syn, say what you're going to say, and if it has the words Amaya and staying alive in the same context then I'd tread very carefully on the reasoning behind it."

This would all be better if the old man dropped dead. I'm not the underboss, but Aslan has always been on my side one way or another. I'm hoping that's still the case.

"That's exactly what I'm sayin'. I'm going to say the next words to you as a son, and not as your Syn..." I pause, waiting for him to nod.

He does.

I carry on. "Word has it you were in The Pen when Jesse raped her—you know, right before I slit his fucking throat open."

I grin.

Dad's jaw clenches a few times. "Yes. I was. Even though she's the enemy, that's not why I was there. I was there searching for one of our other subjects and just so happened to see it go down. I stopped it and left, but, son, I think you're forgetting, that she's the enemy and what her family has done."

"You didn't stop it. He only stopped until you left and then he continued."

Pause. "Why are you telling me this? Again, she's the enemy."

I flick the ash off my smoke. "And what if I claim her."

Dad exhales, shaking his head as his eyes come to mine. "You're seriously fucking asking me this?"

It's the first time I've heard my dad cuss under a slightly emotional strain.

"Yes," I answer instantly, my eyes not wavering from his. "She's suffered enough. Hell, she didn't even know her damn parents. I'm sick of punishing this girl for shit that she didn't do. I get loyalty, and I know what is asked of me from the Bratva—"

"—Do you?" Joseph, the consigliere mutters, but I don't look toward him. I can't fucking stand Joseph, never could. He's an old fucker who needs a bullet. I'd gladly be the one to do the honors too.

I bare my teeth, turning my head toward Joseph. "Yeah, I fucking do. What have you done lately other than scratch those sag bags between your legs, fucker?"

"Syn!" Dad snaps, and I slowly drag my eyes away from an angry looking Joseph and back to Dad.

There's a chuckle coming from Aslan and I have to fight the grin kicking up in the corner of my

mouth.

“Where is she right now?” Dad asks, running his index finger over his upper lip. It’s a trait we both have, pretty sure I picked it up when I was a young pup.

“Safe,” is all I say, tilting my head.

“No can do, young one,” Joseph says, leaning back in his chair, his eyes going toward me and Dad. “This isn’t just a simple someone not paying money.”

Dad is still watching me, and I him. Neither one of us are paying Joseph any attention and I think old Joseph knows this, which is why he stands from his seat, his arms going up over his head. “Don’t tell me you’re actually thinking of granting this brat what he wants...”

“That brat is my son,” Dad murmurs, not even giving Joseph a glance.

“—And my nephew,” Aslan adds, cutting Joseph a glare.

I chuckle, because why not work the old man up. Besides, I kind of always liked rubbing this shit in Joseph’s face when they’d all side with me.

“What exactly are you proposing, Aeron?” Benny, one of the capos asks. I like Benny, he seems to always sit on the fence with decisions because he has no bias view on anything. Aside from the loyalty, he always sees right through what everyone wants.

“I’m talking a truce, now hear me out,” I snap at Joseph, blazing up another smoke. Being in here stresses me out. I used to love it, but somewhere along the line of finding my passion I’ve started to lose my way within the family, and Joseph has probably picked that up. That’s not to say that I’m not loyal or don’t do my bit, because obviously, I do and I have, but it’s just my loss of interest in it. Having most of the police in our pocket can be complicated at times too because they know me as an artist and as a Vor.

They just don’t really know what happens. I mean sure, they have their suspicions, but for generations now we have hidden behind the fact that we’re not as bad as everyone thinks. If you take away the Castellammarese war, the Second Mafia war, and then there’s the constant war that’s been brewing between the Italians and the MS-13 and us and the Yakuza. Everyone seems to assume that we have the most beef with the Cosa Nostra, but that’s just not true. Before the shit blew up between my old man and Beat’s parents, we were civil—allies even. The MS-13, on the other hand, have a beef with almost everyone. They tend to back up from us, mainly because we know where to shit and where not to. The Yakuza, though? Yeah, I’d blow those fuckers up courtside and not blink. We’ve been at war with the little fuckers since as long as I can remember, no thanks to their lack of respect where turf is concerned, and then there’s the issue of them trying to hijack one of our biggest weapon shipments circa 2011. However, this beef with the Costa Nostra is more on the personal side with my old man, so Joseph’s outrage is really not warranted.

“We’re waiting, Syn...” Dad urges.

I flick a bit of nicotine out of my mouth. “Beatrice doesn’t know any of her family. Her crime family, as you know is the Corvo family that are based in New York. They don’t know anything about her, probably think she’s dead. They didn’t send retaliation for Garth and Lauren because they both chose to walk away, they knew the risk in doing that. But there is her pop...”

“Ah...” Dad grins, rolling his cigar around in his mouth. “Now here’s where we’re going to hit a rough patch.”

“What?” I answer, eyebrows creased. “How? This will be a good thing to finally have some peace between the two families so we can go back to being allies. How could that be a rough patch? Her pop is the Godfather.”

Dad leans forward, grinning at me. “There’s something I didn’t tell you.”



CHAPTER FORTY-THREE



“Girls”—D12

Beat

I’m back in New York, in the same hotel that Manik put us in when we were on tour and the sun is shining through the large floor to ceiling windows. I’ve not been told much since leaving the jet, only been driven to places by one of Manik’s men. I thought that when he had said goodbye, that it meant he was letting me go—freely. But it’s not like that at all, it’s more a string that has been given more slack.

There’s a knock on the door and I launch myself toward it. My fingers wrap around the knob, as I inch up on tippy toes to see who it is.

“Holy crap!” I gasp, yanking it open to Katiya and Kyle. I fling my arms around both of them, throwing my full body weight into them.

They catch me, laughing. “Woah, little Cubby, how about we get you back inside.”

I nod, stepping out of the way to let them through, closing the door. “I’m surprised to see you both here, and a little confused as to what’s happening right now.”

Kat takes a seat on the couch with Kyle beside her. They look cozy so I take it they must be a couple now. “That’s my brother for you. No one knows what he’s doing until it’s done and we’re praising the royal ground he walks on for his brilliance.”

Kyle scoffs.

I take a seat on the single La-Z-Boy that’s opposite the corner lounge. “So, you don’t know

what's happening either?"

Kat shakes her head. "I don't. All I know is that he called me to tell me there's a jet waiting to bring me and Kyle here. Said you might need us."

I clear my throat. "I'm confused because I thought we had said our goodbyes."

"Wait." Kat waves her hand around the front of herself, a smile on her mouth. "You thought that my brother was going to let you go? Girl, you're crazy."

Kyle grins, leaning back on the sofa. "I love you, Beat, but I'm with her on this one. There was no way Manik was going to let you go. The psychopath has kidnapped you twice, and yes, I know about the first time." Cue dramatic pause. "Pretty sure that's more proof than you need that you're not going anywhere."

I sigh, burying my face in my hands. "I'm so sorry, Kyle. I wanted to tell you. I hope you don't think any less of me." He glares at me as if I'm stupid, and I carry on. "There's also so much about me that you don't know. What you heard that day is just a snippet into the crazy."

Kat must have gotten up because her hand lands on mine. "Honey, nothing can change the way Kyle and I think of you. We may not know much, and it's up to you if you want to tell us, but you have to know that I will never, ever think any less of you."

I split my fingers so my eyes peer out at her. "Okay," I exhale. Am I doing this? I'm doing this. "This is going to sound really, very bad, and I don't know if telling Kyle is a very good idea right now." I shoot a quick glance at Kyle. His attitude toward Manik is already a little on the edge, and even though everything that has happened is in the past and was justified—in a way, though murder is still never okay—I believe he will still flip out and won't see the truth through the anger that he will feel.

Kat leans over her shoulder. "Out big boy. She will tell you when she's ready."

He throws his hands up in defeat. "No problem at all." Then disappears out the front door.

"Okay," I exhale. "There are still some things that I don't know, like who my parents' family are and all that because I only ever knew my pop and nona, but, here goes..."



CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR



“Trapped”—Proof, Eminem

Manik

“Jesus fucking Christ.” I shake my head, launching out of my chair and pacing back and forth like a caged lion. “She’s going to lose her shit when she finds out.”

“Oh, I know,” Dad says, putting out his cigar. “But I also don’t care, Syn. That’s not my issue. So, as I said, if you want to keep her, I guess I can warm to it with time. You pose a good point and a position that’s hard to argue. By keeping her alive, we can rebuild the lines between us and the Corvos, but obviously, she is going to have to come to know about this truth.”

“Yeah,” I murmur. “I think I can work with it, though.”

“This is bullshit,” Joseph spurts out, launching from the chair he’s in.

I stop, shoving my hands in my pocket to stop my fists from accidentally flying and hitting him in the face.

“Exactly what is bullshit, Smirnov?” I call him by his last name because I know he hates it.

“The fact that we are even considering throwing up flags for Corvo when they have caused you and your father so much pain, as well as the tension between both families since that happened.” He looks back to Dad, pleadingly. “I have a better idea. We could align with the MS-13 and take them down once and for all, and you get your revenge.”

Dad laughs.

I snort.

Uncle Az roars out a laugh.

I end up putting Joseph out of his misery because, well, I'm an asshole and I like to be the bearer of bad news. "Who the fuck let you into the Bratva?" I shake my head, blazing my smoke again. "First of all, fuckface, can I call you fuckface? Too bad, I'm calling you fuckface. First of all, your suggestion we align with the MS-13 is so humorous because of your lack of knowledge. Who are the mafia, fuckface?"

He sits back down, his eyes going between my dad and I. "We are a family."

"Ehh, wrong, I mean, yes, we are." I make my way toward his chair because I can see his submission. "We are the motherfucking Bratva, we have alliances with politicians, the government, the goddamn President of the United States, motherfucking CIA agents. We also have alliances with Putin, I mean, I'm not saying that he's in the mafia..." I look up at Dad and grin. "But I'm not saying that he isn't."

"What's your point, *boy*," Joseph seethes.

My hand flies to the back of his neck and I squeeze tightly. "My point," I whisper, dropping right down to his ear. "Is that we *don't* meddle with street thugs and people who are, for lack of a better word, inferior to us. Because that's what the MS-13 are, Smirnov, they're *street thugs*. For you to have the audacity to even suggest we lower ourselves to such an alliance has my trigger finger itchy to dance over my Desert Eagle, you feel me?"

Joseph freezes, I can feel his goosebumps dance over my fingertips. "Not really."

I chuckle, shoving him forward and swiping my hands of his filthy stench. I look to Dad and then back down to Joseph. "Are you going to make this an issue, Joseph? Because if you are, speak now or forever hold your peace."

There's a long pause that drags out between all of us, and my eyes lock with Uncle Az. He grins up at me, massaging his goatee. I see the flash of pride from him and I wink at him.

Uncle Az played a major role in my upbringing, and Kat's.

Joseph slaps back. "No, Aeron, I don't."

"Good!" I button up my jacket and nod at Dad. "I'll do what I need to do, as long as you have my back and I can trust that I have your word?"

Dad nods. "Yeah, Syn, just make sure she knows about her pops."

Beat

"Seriously!" Kat says, running her hands through her hair, standing from the coffee table and pacing up and down. "Gosh. Okay. It's fine, we can do this."

I watch her with nervous eyes.

She spins back to face me. "Are you okay with letting go of what he did to your parents, Beat? Because even to me, that's fucked up."

I nod, chewing on my lip. "I love him, Kat. And I think the love I have for him trumps every single bad thing he has ever done to people. Whether they deserved it or not. *I love him*. I'm a better woman when I'm with him and I think he's a better man when he's with me."

Kat drops back to the coffee table and brings her hands to my cheeks. "We can leave. Right now. You know I'm bisexual, right? Fuck Kyle and fuck my brother. Let's just run away together. We can fuck each other and let dick in when we need it."

I pause, my eyebrows shooting up in shock. Then we both burst out laughing. I tilt back, clutching my stomach and she giggles until she's lying on the floor. "Sorry," she murmurs. "God," she exhales, wiping the tears from her eyes while trying to calm her giggles. "I've been trying to tell you that for so long."

I swipe the dampness from my own cheeks. "It's okay. I totally needed that right then."

My laughter slowly dies out until my body is jerking from the after effects. "You know I love you too, right?"

She tilts her head to face me, a smile on her mouth. "I know. You just love him more and that's okay. Truthfully, I probably wouldn't be able to handle being away from Kyle anyway."

"You guys?" I ask.

Laughter finally cuts out, her hand coming to her stomach. "I don't know. It's a little strange. God, I just want to kill him, and I've missed you. I don't know if you've realized this, but I don't have many friends."

I snort. "Who would have guessed..." Though truthfully, I get why she doesn't. Katiya as a person is everything you could ask for in a friend—if she likes you—which is where my problem lies. She doesn't let many people in, but I think that's why the people she does let in take their place in her heart so seriously.

She throws a cushion at me. "I'm serious! I have no one I can talk to about this."

I sigh, leaning back in the chair. "Okay, well, shall we go out for some drinks, then? Maybe that'll make you feel better? We can leave him here. Since you're obviously not running from my brother, what harm can a little drinking do..."

Her eyebrows wiggle then she shoots up from the ground. "Sold!"

There have been times in my life where I put in a lot of effort into my appearance, and other times I didn't. Don't get me wrong, I love feeling good about myself but it has always been a confused satisfaction when I think about why it has to be when I *look* good is when I feel good. They go on about feeling good and how it's an inner self-love sort of thing, but it's easier said than done.

I run the comb through my hair again until the ends flick inward toward my breasts and waist. It's really long, I should trim it sometime soon.

"You ready?" Kat comes bouncing into the master bedroom, carrying a couple of shots.

I lick my lips, taking one from her and shooting it back. "Yes," I say around a hiss of breath. "What in the hell was that? Satan's semen?"

Kat laughs and then gives me a smirk. "I don't know, did it taste like my brother?"

"Oh." I scrunch up my face. "That came out so wrong."

She chuckles, hooking her arm in mine as we both toss the empty shot glasses onto the bed. "We're going to have so much fun!"

I bet.

We pass Kyle who's laid back on the sofa eating Lucky Charms. "Have fun."

I wonder idly if he's mad at me for not including him in

Tonight

And

The discussion earlier this afternoon.

If he is, he's not displaying his annoyance and that's something Kyle is very good at doing.

I smile at him and just when I'm about to open my mouth to ask him if he's okay, Kat is dragging me out the door.

This bar is pumping. It's one of the well-known clubs in NYC, but of course, we bypass the line and get let through straight away. Usually, I would say that's because of Katiya and her fame, but the way the bouncers straightened their shoulders as soon as their eyes fell on me has me thinking maybe they watch more E! News than they care to admit.

We make our way into the club, the flashing lights buzzing around us. There are cages hanging from the ceiling with dancers inside.

We head straight for the bar and Kat orders drinks. We drink them, one at a time and sometimes two at a time, and then she drags me to the floor.

"Cinema" by Skrillex and Benny Benassi starts playing and my body moves, pushing against Kat.

The room is spinning, and nothing is making much sense as far as atmosphere goes, but I don't care. I'm feeling completely reckless. My hands go up above my head and I drop to the ground in front of Kat as the hook comes in. When the base drops, I let myself go completely.

I love this song. I don't think I've ever loved this song as much as I love this song right now.

Kat hands me another drink and I take it, shooting it back.

"Easy, little Cub!" Kat growls into my ear. "That has absinthe in it, and not the shit kind, it's the kind I got off the black market in Mexico."

There're so many things wrong with that, but I'll leave it for another day, because the song mixes into another Benny classic.

That's right. "I Love My Sex."

Kat screams, running her hands up her bare stomach and then pulls me into her. I laugh, my head tipping back. I think I needed this. To be with someone who isn't Manik or Lenny.

We both dance to the music. God save Benny Benassi. He's like crack for all girls buzzing on alcohol. He's a setup. He does this so guys in the club get laid because as soon as this song comes on, clits are singing.

That was awful, I can't believe I just thought that. I'm drunk.

When the song ends, Kat pulls me into her, gesturing to herself. "I need to go to the restroom."

I nod, needing to go too. She begins dragging me toward the back of the dance floor where a light flashes above the entry and M and F letters light up.

We carry on, pushing into the women's and then wait in line. There are only a couple of girls, thank God.

"I needed this," I voice my inner thoughts, looking back at Kat. "Seriously, I'm going to love having you in my life as well as your psycho brother, as Kyle says it—by the way, what is his problem with Manik other than him stealing me twice."

A couple of the girls raise their eyebrows at me in judgment, or as in "you're dreaming, sis." Unlike the bouncer, they obviously don't watch E! News.

Kat laughs. "It's hard to explain, but basically he liked you."

"Who? Aeron? I know." Again, the girls glare at me. One of them disappears into a free stall as the other one bounces on her toes to try and contain her pee.

"Not Ae," Kat says, rolling her eyes. "I'm talking about Kyle. He liked you...like, liked you liked you..."

"Oh no..." I mutter, gazing off into the distance.

"Oh, yes..." Kat further continues. "But it's okay. He's semi over it now that I've been keeping him occupied."

The stalls become available and Kat and I both squeeze into one, taking turns at peeing. "So,

what's the problem between you two anyway?" I ask, scrunching up toilet paper.

"You're a scruncher?" Kat scowls, her nose pinching.

"Yes," I hiss. "Stop trying to distract me. Continue, it's why we came out tonight."

"So, I don't know."

I wipe and then flush, pulling my skinny jeans up and buttoning them.

Kat takes a seat. "I mean I have an issue because I very much like him and I don't like anyone, and I don't like how liking him makes me feel."

I pause and then burst out laughing. She wipes and flushes, scowling at me. "Don't laugh!"

"Gosh, you and your brother are so the same."

She shrugs as we exit the little stall, washing our hands. We head back out to the dance floor, but the entry is far more congested. Bodies are pressed up against us and at one point, we lose touch.

It's then that I realize I'm actually getting shoved toward the back exit and not actually toward the center of the club.

I exhale in relief when I see Kat pop up beside me, as confused as I look. "What the hell?"

"I know, right! Someone must be here."

"One guess." Kat rolls her eyes. "Starts with M and ends with cunt."

I laugh, and then just as we're about to walk forward, a harsh load of cold air hits my back and I turn, seeing the exit now open with a van backed up to it. My eyebrows pull together in confusion, but before I can voice that, we're both being shoved into the back, landing with a heavy thud and the doors are being slammed closed.

I try to launch off the floor but something hits me square in the face and I'm out cold.



CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE



“Renegade”—Jay Z, Eminem

Beat

“*Ring around the rosie, a pocket full of posies, ashes, ashes, we all...fall...down...*” a voice sings sweetly from the corner of a room. My head thuds and when my hand goes up to touch it, wetness seeps through my fingers.

“Creepy, isn’t it, that children sing that nursery rhyme without a thought of what they’re singing about... sort of like your love...” the voice adds, but her words come through broken, jumbled and dismembered.

“Wha—”

“Shhh,” the voice says, coming closer. A warm cloth presses to my head and I hiss from the sting. I still can’t see the owner of the voice though.

“No need to talk, I can fill you in. So, the song, is actually about the Bubonic plague, also known as The Black Death. You see, *ring around the rosie* is talking about the red ring that would raise as a symptom around the sores associated with the plague. *A pocket full of posies* is the ritual in which they would place posies in the pockets of the dead, and even the people alive because, in their heads, it helped stop the spread. Was probably total BS though. *Ashes, ashes*, is about how they would dispose of the victims, and *we all fall down* means that we’re all going to die.” She finishes patting my head, and it’s then I see the long strands of her blonde hair, waving above me.

Her oval jaw and frumpy cheekbones. She had a babyface from this angle.

Then her eyes locked with mine, a dark smile curling over her face. “You’re fully awake now I see. Good, because we have unfinished business.”

I suck in a breath. “Bindi? You’re—you’re ghost girl?”

“Ghost what—what?” Bindi asks, tilting her head. She’s changed so much since I last saw her, but of course she has because we were only eight at the time, but the years have not been kind to her. She’s pretty, don’t get me wrong, just like she was when we were little, but there’s something in her eyes that’s raw and touched.

“Get the fuck away from her, Darya!” Kat spits from the other side of the room.

Darya—no, Bindi—laughs, her head tilting back. “How about no, Katiya. I don’t have to take orders from you!” Her face scrunches in anger, then she looks back down to me and she softens. “Do you love him?”

“What? Bindi, what are you doing?” I go to yank on my hands, but they’re constricted by heavy cuffs that are closed over a couple of thick plumbing pipes. We look to be in an old warehouse of some sort, with nothing else in here but us, and a few old tables and chairs.

“My name is not Bindi, it’s Darya, and I was a *Romanov* before you had the name attached to your fake passport!”

Ohhh, she’s very angry about this.

Maybe I’m still slightly drunk, too.

“This makes no goddamn sense and someone better spill what the fuck is going on because I’ve had enough of being kept in the dark while being fed half-truths!” I look to Katiya. “Kat!”

Bindi sits back, crossing her boot-clad feet and crossing her arms. “By all means, you do the honors.”

Kat scurries up to a sitting position, bringing her knees up and resting her arms on them. I do the same, sitting up enough to face her. I feel a little more in control in this position, which is good. I might need it.

“Darya used to live with us when we were little. My dad actually rescued her—sort of—”

That earned a scoff from Darya. Bindi. Goddamnit. But I don’t miss how Darya’s eyes go up to behind my shoulder, slight worry flickering through them. It’s so obvious that I turn around to see who she was looking at, only my eyes meet darkness.

Kat continues. “You see there’s a whole world that you don’t know about, Beatrice, and you will never fully know about it because as a woman of a Vor, it is not your duty to know about it. I don’t know about it either—just FYI...”

“Oh, but I did,” Darya murmurs, flicking her fingernails.

“Fuck you!” That’s Kat again. “We did everything for you and you shit on it when you *fucked* my dad, became obsessed with him, and then tried to blow the rape whistle. Fuck you very much, but you are what is wrong with this world. It’s bitches like you who scream your lies, that have silenced the truth of *real* victims like *Beat*. Fuck. You.”

“Ah—” I try to add that I’m not a fucking victim, but Darya cuts me off.

She starts laughing, her head tilting back to lean on the concrete wall. “One, I don’t care, he sent me to befriend this twat until he burned down her house and then set her on the doorstep of—”

“—And hang on, so you weren’t an orphan? Those people—”

“—were on the Bratva’s payroll. Yes, they took me out of a shit situation and put me into a better one, but only for so long. I would have rather been sold, or kicked to some trafficking center...”

“You better watch your next words very carefully before I cut your motherfucking tongue from that mouth.” My head snaps up to the doorway to see Manik standing there. He’s wearing dark jeans, a t-

shirt and his hat is flipped backward.

He also has his black bandana loose around his neck.

“Aw, look who cared to show up,” Darya says mockingly, and then laughs. “You don’t really think I got these heffas into the back of that van on my own, do you?”

“—Bitch, did you just call me a *heffa*?!” Kat looks feral, and if the situation wasn’t so serious, I would laugh.

“No, I don’t,” Manik says, coming farther into the room while stretching his neck.

I gulp. I’ve come to know the little giveaways he has that set off signals of war.

One is the neck crack.

Two is the slow exhale of smoke.

And three is the glint in his eye right before he takes your final breath from you.

“Do come out, Joseph, don’t be shy. I’ll deal with you soon.”

Darya mumbles again. “Finally.”

He lights a smoke, inhales while his eyes stay on her and then slowly exhales through his lips and nose.

Oh shit.

“Seems you’ve lost touch with who the fuck you’ve just messed with, D, and although I didn’t come alone either,” he gestures to the back of him where a couple of men, one I recognize slightly from the first night at the bar, but the other two I don’t. The final one as Vlad.

I gulp through my fear. Vlad’s eyes come to me, and just when I think he’s going to give me that icy look he usually does, he gives me a curt nod and then takes his attention immediately back to Kat. A silent conversation passes between the two of them, but I catch the corners of Vlad’s eyes softening. It is only for a second, and in a blink, it’s gone and he’s back to being the boss he always is, but it was there.

Manik continues. “I think you and I both know I don’t need them and they’re just here so I could prove my point that that fucker there,” Manik points to the shadows behind me and chills set off over my flesh when I see a figure step out of the dark wearing a long trench coat. “Has been infiltrating the MS-13 for a couple years now.”

I’m suddenly aware of how very serious this situation is. I could die. I wouldn’t, surely Manik wouldn’t allow it, but I could. Oh God, something could go very wrong right now and it would be game over.

Sober up, Amaya!

Yes, I think I like my old name a little bit more.

Manik whispers toward Darya, but loud enough for us all to hear. “You’ve done a good job, young buck. Now get the fuck out of here.”

Darya suddenly relaxes, and then her eyes change as they come to me. “I’m sorry, Beatrice. It had to be done to get him here. I’ve been working with Joseph for Manik to get intel taking down someone in your family isn’t easy.” She exhales and then continues. “Joseph hit them pretty hard in the van, Ae.” Then she looks back to me. “There were times when I wanted to tell you, but I love—and Manik, Manik has been planning this since—”

“—Since before you planted that set up of a killing in the back of the club, Pops!” Manik straightens, his eyes going to Vlad.

I stiffen. What the hell is going on right now?

Vlad’s eyes slant, and then he shakes his head in awe. “You knew?”

“Knew what?” I say, confused as all hell.

“Did I know that she was Amaya Corvo all along? Yes, and I needed to prove to you that for years now, this fucker has been going behind your back and doing shady shit that you didn’t know about. I was hoping to kill two birds with one stone.”

Manik slowly backs up, pulling out a pistol, he points it, and the loud shots hit my ears right before my arms are set free.

He shoots a look over my shoulder, raises the gun, and pulls the trigger.

Pop!

A scream reaches out from behind me and plays like an electric guitar inside of my head.

Manik turns back around, only with me now pressed firmly behind him. “I knew, Pops. I knew who she was the second I laid eyes on her in that club. I knew that it wasn’t a coincidence that you had suggested that club. The dots started connecting in my head pretty quickly, but I went with it because I had my own plans.”

Vlad stepped closer to us, grabbing Darya and snatching the keys from her grip. He unhooks the cuffs from Kat’s hands, who is standing and watching with eager eyes.

“Why, Syn? Why’d you go with it?”

“At first? It was because I wanted to ruin her. I knew what my mission was. I wanted my revenge and I went about it in ways that were probably questionable to people who didn’t understand the bigger picture. Then she happened. We happened, and I couldn’t fight it. I fucking tried to fight it, but I couldn’t. When you came to me and told me that she was Amaya Corvo, I knew I had to make you think that I didn’t know, because I knew that if you knew I had known all along and I still let my feelings get involved with her while knowing who she really was, that you would shoot me on the spot. In regards to the other bird, I needed to kill.” I look over my shoulder at Joseph. “Initially, I was doing it because I wanted the consigliere position. I always wanted to make you proud, but I knew I’d have to prove myself more than anyone else because I’m your son.”

“Done, it’s yours.”

Manik squeezes me. “I don’t want it anymore.”

“So, what do you want, Syn? Tell me.” Vlad looks hopeful.

Manik exhales. “I want out.”

All four of the men who are in here freeze, and there’s a blood-curdling laugh coming from behind us.

Manik continues. “We all know I’ve lost the fire for it. I want to rap, that’s where my future is, especially if I want one with her.”

Vlad still hasn’t answered.

The silence is loud.

Manik continues. “I know—”

“—Let him,” one of the men says. He’s handsome for an old guy, too. He steps closer, tilting his head to Manik. “Come on, V. It’s his time, he has served well.”

Another long stretch of silence. “You can’t quit the Bratva, Syn. If I don’t kill you, someone else will.”

“Dad, you are The Boss, no one will undermine you, and everyone knows I won’t snitch. It’s a matter of your approval.”

Vlad seems to think over something, and then his hand disappears beneath his jacket, and everything starts to slow.

He slowly pulls his hand out, and just when I see the handle of a pistol, I scream, throwing myself in front of Manik. A loud *Pop!* goes off and something smashes into my chest, and then everything

goes black.



CHAPTER FORTY-SIX



“Me and my girlfriend”—2Pac

Manik

“What the fuck were you thinking!” I roar as soon as we have Beat in the hospital. The first minutes after that happened, nothing mattered but her, but now that I’m standing here, drenched in her blood while doctors try to save her life, I’m fucking feral.

Dad yanks me down to one of the chairs in the waiting room beside Kat who hasn’t stopped crying, and Kyle who just came in a few minutes ago, looking like he wants to knock me out.

“She wasn’t supposed to fucking jump in front of a flying bullet. It was aimed at your arm, because no one walks out of my goddamn Bratva without at least a fucking bullet! Son or not! But because she jumped in front, it became a direct line to her chest!”

I sink lower into the chair. “She jumped in front of a mother-fucking bullet for me.”

I see dad lean forward on the corner of my eye, his elbows coming to his knees. He lowers his voice. “Syn, I’m willing to let you have her as a reward for all that you’ve done for me and the Bratva. And aside from that, I understand that damn Corvo pull—” I glare at him. He chuckles, and then continues. “—All I’m saying is that her jumping in front of a bullet and you willing to leave the Bratva for her, and everything you both have put each other through. I can live with the satisfaction that it’s enough. I want you happy, Syn. You’re still my son. I may not be comfortable with her right now, but I will learn to accept her.” He leans back, muttering, “It’d be easier if she wasn’t a splitting image of her damn mother.”

I lunge to my feet when sitting still doesn't help. I can't hear what dad is trying to say to me right now. I start pacing up and down the waiting room, watching as Kyle pulls Kat into his arms, rocking her gently. Darya catches my eye when she comes in through the doors with Uncle Az and Benny.

Kat launches off her chair and clips Darya square in the jaw. Dad pulls her back, arms flying everywhere as Darya tries to stand from the ground.

I give them both a blank glare. "Can you fucking not right now?"

"Fuck you, D! You need to crawl back into the hole Aeron pulled you up from."

"That hole would be your dad's bed, sweetie!"

I sigh, massaging my temples. Truthfully, we all fucking know the real reason why Kat has never liked D. It's because Kat is used to running princess.

Kat gasps. "You take that back!" Then she looks at the old man, and if he didn't just cap my woman, I'd feel bad for him. "Daddy, tell me she's lying!"

"I can't fuck with you all right now." I leave them, heading toward the twin doors I saw the docs take Beat through and slide down the wall, drawing my knees up.

Running my palms over my face, I count to ten.

One.

Beatrice is in hospital.

Two.

Beatrice is shot.

Three.

Dad shot her.

Four.

She might die.

I launch off the ground and start walking back and forth again, my thoughts like a train going toward a brick wall at a hundred miles an hour.

"Brother?" Lenny whispers from behind me, and my shoulders instantly sag in relief. I turn to face him, my eyebrows pulling together. "She's going to be fine."

"And if she's not?" I ask, even though the words feel like they're carved with razor blades, slicing through my throat.

"Then we kill your old man." Lenny shrugs, taking a seat on the floor beside me. I join him. Maybe this will make the time more bearable.

"The paparazzi are all outside. You'd think they'd have happier things to follow since it's so close to Christmas."

I didn't even realize we were close to Christmas and Thanksgiving.

The doors swing open and a woman dressed in scrubs stops abruptly, looking down at both of us. "Hello."

She looks young. "No offense, but if you tell me you just had your fingers inside my girl, trying to save her life, I'm going to have to ask to see your credentials."

"Well, you're right, that is offensive," she replies and then straightens. "But yes, I'm Natalie Stephens, the assisting surgeon, and I believe we did, in fact, save her life. After we removed the bullet from her ribs, where it just missed her heart by a few inches, and then closed the wound. She will be moved to ICU where you can see her when she wakes. Please, close family only."

She disappears down the corridor and Lenny looks on in awe.

I shove him. "No."

A dark cloud has slowly shifted from over my head and I let out a deep exhale. "I gotta go and tell

everyone.”

I’m walking into the waiting room, ignoring the nervous glances from the staff—probably because of my old man—when I pause in my tracks.

There, standing directly in front of me—in the damn flesh—Is Antonio Corvo. He brushes his hands down his suit, and gives me a once over, before finding my dad instantly. The air grows cold, and I swear I see a few of the staff scatter. There are guards and police at the entrance of the hospital to stop the paparazzi from piling in, so I know this can’t get ugly, but it’s still unnerving.

“Where is my granddaughter, why didn’t anyone tell me she was still alive, and why the fuck am I only just hearing about this now?”

I make my way farther into the waiting room. “Long story. Take a seat and I’ll fill you in.”

I’m a piece of shit because as soon as Beat opens her eyes, there’s a big chance she’s not going to want to be with me.

Some secrets are just too poisonous to ignore, and she is about to swallow one of them.

Beat

I don’t know how many days have passed when I finally open my eyes. It’s the morning, because I can hear birds chirping and feel the sun blaring into my room. Flowers and cards are scattered everywhere that I can see, but there’s no sign of living people. Which is good, it gives me a second to collect my thoughts.

Thirst.

My mouth feels filled with cotton and I reach slowly for the jug and cup on the table beside me, pushing away the flowers. My side pinches in pain, but I ignore it, continuing to pour the water. I’m bringing the cup to my mouth when the door opens, and Kat walks through, her eyes rimmed red and her frame frail. When she looks to the bed and sees me, she freezes, dropping her cup of coffee. “Oh my God! Aeron!” Then she runs into the room, pulling me into a hug, and hurting me in the process.

I hiss, and she steps back, apologizing profusely. “I’m sorry, Beat! Oh girl. It’s so good to have you back. I would have been an orphan if you didn’t make it back to us.”

I freeze. “He shot me—why?”

“Hey, baby,” Aeron says, walking deeper into the room.

I smile at him, my heart filling with warmth. “Hey.”

“And to answer your question, it was an accident,” Aeron continues, coming closer to my bed. “The bullet was meant for me, yes, but it was meant for my arm, nothing deadly. It was dad lashing out that I was leaving. Means nothing, I swear. If it were anyone else, that bullet would have been between my eyes.”

I sigh, sinking into the bed.

“And he’s sorry,” Aeron adds.

I’m not sure how I feel about how casual it is to shoot members of your own family, but I’ll think on that a little later.

“There’s something else I have to tell you, baby, and I’m really sorry about this shit timing, but I think it’s important you know everything right now so you can have some time to think on how you’re going to proceed.”

“Proceed?” I ask, inching up my bed and wincing again when the side of my injured ribs sting.

“With our relationship.”

“Oh,” I answer wistfully, unsure what could possibly be worse than everything I’ve already endured to warrant me walking away.

“Your granddad wants to see you.”

I still. “He’s dead, what do you mean?”

Aeron’s eyes go to Kat whose face can only be described as broken.

“He’s not dead, baby, because the one who raised you wasn’t your *real* granddad.”

It’s like a semi-truck smashes into me and I gasp, desperate for air. “No. That’s not true!” I hiss. “You cannot take away the only person...” I pause, remembering my nona. “People who ever meant anything to me! I won’t let you!”

“It’s true, babe. After that shit happened with your parents, my dad needed to put you somewhere where he could keep a good eye on you. A place where no one would question you, with people who are sacred, because” —he clears his throat, his eyes coming to mine “—because they were my grandparents who raised you.”

Tears stream down my cheeks, my heart physically snaps in my chest. “They were all I had, Manik, and now you’re telling me that they were never mine to begin with and that they were actually yours?”

His hand comes to mine, but I yank it away. “Yes, but I didn’t know until my dad just told me. I swear to you, that was something I *did not* know.” He carries on, because who cares about tearing someone’s world apart when you damn well own it. “I’m sorry, Cub. But, the feelings and the bond you had with my nana and pops? It was real. They’re my mom’s parents and I fucking love that you had such a strong connection with them—”

“—Don’t!” I snap. “So, they knew all along? I felt so wanted by them. It doesn’t make sense.”

“That’s because that’s the kind of people they were, Beat,” Kat says, putting her hand on mine.

I pull away, glaring at Aeron, my feelings for him so warped and confused that I don’t know whether to run or hide. “And who is Darya? If you tell me that she’s my long-lost sister or something I swear I will hit you.”

“No,” he adds, shaking his head. “All of what you learned about her tonight is real. They just left out the sick bond her and my old man have. Before him, she was in my bed. She was raised with us, I broke her heart and shit, and then she went to Dad to mend it. Been with him since.”

“This family is toxic,” I whisper, my eyelashes fluttering through the wetness.

My harsh words hit the intended source because Manik flinches. “And where is this man who was with her now?”

Manik falters. “Taken care of. That’s Bratva business, baby, you don’t have to worry about it.”

I exhale. “Get out. Both of you.”

“Cub...” he warns, but I don’t want to hear it.

“No. Just, leave, Aeron.”

They both get up and shuffle out of the room.



CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN



“Hennessey”—2Pac

Beat

Three Weeks Later

“Just hand me the damn things, Kyle!” I yell over the cheesy Christmas carols. I went back to my home with Kyle under one condition.

Katiya wasn’t to come to this house while I’m here.

I don’t know how I feel about the revelations that have happened over the last eight months.

I don’t know how I feel about *them*, either. All I know is that I’m a little more broken now since they walked into my life and I know that the only way this will ever work with Aeron and I is if I’m the one who puts me back together.

Not him. You cannot expect the same hands that broke you to be the same ones to fix you. I think that’s where relationships fall apart, through the cracks that are left behind, because not one person truly knows the damage of one’s soul and all the little hairline cracks that can be easily missed unless you are that person.

I’m not saying never, I’m just saying not right now.

My phone vibrates in my pocket and I fish it out, opening it to a phone call from an unknown number.

“I’ll just take this,” I mutter to Kyle as he flips the cookbook.

“Hello?” I answer.

“Amaya Noemi Corvo...” a voice breathes into the phone. The voice is dark and mysterious, the kind that has aged by throwing orders.

I want to say that it’s actually Romanov, but think better of it. “Who is this?”

“I’m Antonio Corvo, your grandfather. I don’t want to bother you, and before you hang up, hear me out.”

I lean against the kitchen counter, my eyes glassing over. It still stings, like an old wound that has been sliced open again, this time it’s more tender. In my mind, and my heart, my grandparents still died all those years ago.

They still left *me* some money. Though now that I think of it, they probably had a lot more and I only got a cut of it to make it all seem real. That’s not what hurts, I don’t care about the amount of the money, it’s just another lie and another fabrication of a false life.

Who am I?

Am I Amaya Corvo, or am I Beatrice Kennedy?

This is what I need to figure out.

“When you are ready, I am here to talk. You are still a Corvo by blood, and I take care of my own.”

“Like you did my parents?”

He chuckles, and if I wasn’t hidden by the safety of my cell phone, that chuckle would scare me. “Your father was an issue as a young child. As I said, when you are ready, my door is open. If you find yourself in New York, I’ll send you a number you can have to contact me with—only you. How does that sound?”

It sounds like I don’t trust him one bit, but what’s that old saying, trust is earned. “Ok.”

“Good.” He seems relieved. Maybe this is step one in the trust earning thing.

“I better go. My best friend is trying to cook.”

He laughs softly. “Ok, kid. We’ll talk when you have time.”

I hang up and push the phone back into my pocket.

“Who was that?” Kyle asks as he starts pulling out eggs, flour, and other ingredients from the pantry.

“No one special.”



Thanksgiving went fast, and it was good to just have Kyle and I spending some time together. I’ve had a lot of time to think on the Aeron and Katiya thing. I miss Aeron, so I do need to figure out how I’m going to go with that. He might be sick of me, but I’ve got to at least let him know my feelings. The weeks have been torture without having him near me, and same goes for Katiya. They feel like my family, and sometimes, it takes absence to find that out. Kyle hasn’t been pressing the Aeron and Katiya drama, he has actually been staying out of it for the most part, which I respect. One thing he

hasn't stayed out of, though, is the Antonio drama. Oh no, he had to push me to do that, because in his words, *'You have a chance to have family, Beatrice. When I met you, you had none, you were a drifter. Now you have so many people who love you, you'll always have a family, a home,'* which is part of the reason why I've found myself here. Where I am right now. Standing outside of one of the biggest skyscrapers I've ever seen, right in the center of NYC.

I look down at my phone again, tightening the warm scarf around my neck. A single snowflake drops on the tip of my nose and I push my phone back into my pocket.

"Fuck it."

I take one step, about—"You aren't going in there without me, Cub," a voice whispers so softly over the back of my ear.

I shiver, even though the mist from his breath is pure warmth against the frosting of my flesh. "Aeron?"

I turn around and come smack bang face-to-face with his chest.

A suit is clenching his body snugly, as if he's been pumping more iron since the last time I left him, and when my eyes travel up past his neck and land on his jaw, I catch the tightness.

"Why are you here?" I ask, fog coming out of my mouth. I squeeze my hands tightly, well aware that if I wasn't wearing gloves that I'd be digging new crescent moons into my palms.

"You're a Romanov now, Cub. There's no way I'm letting you walk in there alone."

He won't look at me. His face is fixed over my shoulder, his jaw still tense.

I shrug. "Fine, but please don't kill anyone. I actually am interested in what he has to say." Because I am. I've been texting back and forth with Antonio since Thanksgiving. The trust tree is looking rather healthy.

We start making our way into the building, shuffling past suited men and women as they exit. I go straight to the elevator, punching the "up" button.

"You know where you're going?" Aeron asks, again, not looking at me but ahead.

"Yes," I answer, a little bit confused with how he's acting. Maybe he doesn't hate me, and this conversation will go better than I had made it out in my head.

We step inside once it pings open and I press the "P" button for the penthouse, and then further punch in the pin that I remember by heart.

Aeron whistles. "Oh, he trusts you."

"And I somewhat him."

"That's cute," he snaps, and I finally turn to face him, my arms folded across my chest.

"What's cute?" And it has taken less than five minutes for him to piss me off.

"The fact that you trust him after barely knowing him for two weeks but you've known me for almost a year and you still second guess my shit."

I clench my jaw. "Those are two completely different situations, Aeron, and you damn well know it!"

He shrugs, blowing me off.

And I'm mad.

I shove him as hard as I can, but his body doesn't budge. "Screw you, Aeron! You came into my goddamn life, flipped it upside down, ruined me, destroyed everything I ever thought I knew, made me fall in fucking love with you, and then made me think you were leaving me, and then made me fall in love with you again, and then you take my whole world away from me! So, fuck you, Ae, this is different, and you fucking know it!"

This time he spins around, his hands flying to my arms as he pushes me against the wall, banging

on the stop button.

The elevator jolts abruptly and his eyes finally come to mine.

I flinch because they're blazing angry. I've never seen such anger seep from him other than when...

Oh no. Please don't tell me that...

"One," he growls over my lips, his hand unbuttoning my jacket. "You belong with me and you damn well know it. Now, fucking accept it so we can get on with our life. Two, don't you ever for a fucking second think that I don't hate myself for some of the shit that went down with you. If I could fix it all, Beatrice, I'd fucking fix it, alright? Now stop being a fucking brat. Thirdly," he pauses, his hands shoving down the front of my pants.

I pant like a deranged bitch in heat.

"This is fucking mine and I'm done waiting."

His mouth comes to mine, his tongue slipping between my lips. He swirls it roughly and then extracts it. I grind on his hand as his finger slides inside of me.

"Come, baby," he mutters against my lip. "Or you still prefer when I talk to you like shit?"

I bite on his bottom lip and he groans, shoving himself into me so hard my body flies up the wall. I wrap my legs around his waist, my hands coming to his cheeks. And then I explode all over his hand, seeping into my panties. He withdraws as my body pulses on my shut-down.

Taking his hand out of my pants, he licks me clean off his fingers and then places a soft kiss on my lips. "You done being a brat, or do I need to do that a few more times?"

"Maybe a bit of both." There are obviously some things that I still need to get over between him and me, but I had decided before I had come to New York that I was willing to start making things right with him again. I missed him so much it felt like he had literally taken my heart with him. That kind of pain is unbearable because there is no way of calming the hurt.

He hits the red button again, releasing the elevator and we continue up to see Antonio Corvo.



CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT



“Demons”—Jelly Roll

Beat

The white walls of his office are a stark contrast to everything I expected to walk into on my way up here.

There’s one large glass wall that overlooks the lively city of NY, a large marble desk, and an equally large bookshelf that houses, well, books, and memorabilia.

“Take a seat.” Antonio gestures to the sofa and Aeron and I both follow his instructions. “I must say,” he murmurs, heading for the liquor table. “I’m not all that surprised to have you here, Aeron.” He pours three glasses and then carries them back.

He passes them to each of us and because I don’t want to be rude, I accept with a smile. “I’m sorry. He jumped me on the way up here, I didn’t know he was coming, or I would have told you.”

Antonio looks to me, and his eyes soften. Sort of the same way Vlad’s did when he saw Kat. It sets off a swarm of tingles in my chest. “I know, kid. So,” he leans back, putting his foot over his knee. Then he looks at Aeron. “I am aware of your truce to get our alliance back on track, and I agree with them under one condition...”

Aeron seems to think this over, removing his jacket and placing it on the back of the chair. He’s Aeron right now, not Manik.

Manik is hood, Aeron is suit and tie, someone is about to die.

I just hope he doesn’t try anything with Antonio because not only would that be it for me, but also

for him because I feel like killing the Godfather of the Corvo family, one of the five Italian families ever known, would put a direct hit on your head.

“What is it?” Aeron asks, sitting back down beside me.

“You let Amaya make the decision on if she wants this life with you.”

“Done,” Aeron murmurs, and then looks to me.

They’re both looking at me.

I swallow my drink in one movement, clearing my throat. “I do. I mean, I do want this life with Aeron, whatever life he has. Truth is, I always knew it was what I wanted, I just needed to heal from past pains. It turns out though, funny thing.” I stand up and make my way to the liquor. Pour and shoot. I spin around once I’ve poured one more. “It turns out my wounds will never fully heal without him. I can fill in all the spots I need to, but the final binding ingredient is him. You, Aeron.” I exhale, defeated. “It’s always just going to be you.”

He smirks, his lips catching between his teeth. “Come here.”

I make my way back to him, sitting on his lap.

My eyes go to Antonio, who then rolls his eyes. “Alright then.” He smirks. “Let’s talk.”



CHAPTER FORTY-NINE



“Gangsta’s Paradise”—Coolio

Christmas

“I don’t know.” Kat shakes her head, her eyes opening wide on the plate of chicken Kyle is handing her.

“Just eat the damn thing.” I roll my eyes, digging into it. I’m way too hungry to pass up any food by this point, and no, this isn’t the part where I say; Yup, I’m pregnant, because I’m still on birth control and it’s not something we have even discussed yet.

The smell of spice, roasted turkey, sweets and fresh pine invades my food venture.

“Katiya, stop being a twit, please, for once in your life.” That is Vlad, who I’m still unsure about since he shot me. Aeron cleared up why he was in The Pen that night and what had actually happened, which I appreciated. Gosh, talk about messed up families.

Kat gasps. “Oh well, Daddy, I’m never! That place is taken by the girl, heavy on the girl, you share a bed with.”

And here we go.

Darya, whom I still don’t like either and I’m sure it has absolutely nothing to do with the fact that Kat absolutely despises her and everything to do with her lying to me when we were so young, rolls her eyes, taking a sip of wine. She’s at one end of the table and Vlad is at the other, with Aeron and I on one side and Kat and Kyle on the other.

Happy family.

I zone them out when Aeron’s hand comes to my thigh and his mouth comes to my cheek. He

smiles, and it presses against my flesh. "I love you, Cub."

I freeze. My heart does summersaults inside of my chest and then bounces down to my belly.

I look to him, an expression of shock no doubt spreading over my face. "Are you sure?"

He laughs, flashing me all his perfect teeth and dimples. He brings his face back down, searching my eyes. "Yeah, I'm pretty certain..."

"But—"

He kisses my mouth gently. "Shhh," he whispers over my lips. "Don't talk."

The rest of dinner goes how I expected it to go. Not uncomfortable, just annoying because of Kat and Darya both taking shots at each other.

It's when we're doing the dishes that D turns to face me, leaning against the heavy stone counter at Vlad's house. "I'm sorry, Beatrice, for what it's worth. I didn't know right from wrong—"

"—Still don't, apparently..." Kat adds, and my foot slides out, kicking her to shut her up.

"Carry on."

"I'm just sorry. I know that we may have only been young, but I did like having you as a friend."

"Oh, I bet, she's awesome," another mutter from Katiya as she places the plates into the dishwasher.

I cut her a glare.

"It's fine, it's whatever. I've decided to move on from that. I just have one question..."

"Sure," she answers, relaxing slightly.

I straighten my shoulders. "Do you still love, or have feelings for Aeron? Because If you so much as come near him with those filthy hands, I will chop them off and bury the rest of your corpse in places people will never find. I sort of have a grandfather who can make this happen now, and also, I don't think your existence is worth breaking an alliance between two mafia families so I wouldn't go running to Vlad either."

There's a long pause, and then Katiya bursts out laughing. "My sister actually is a little crazy, turns out she just needed a little Manik in there to stir the pot."

D's mouth drops open and then closes and then opens again. "No, I'm not still in love with him, I do actually love Vlad. Yes, he was hard to get over at first, mainly because I know what he feels like inside."

"—Hands," I warn again, drying a knife and placing it into the drawer.

"—But!" she adds quickly. "I wouldn't do that. Not to him, not to Vlad, or to anyone. It's been years since I've had those sort of feelings for Aeron. It'd be great if you could both not make my life so awful." Then she turns and exits.

Huh. This might just work.



EPILOGUE



“Methodical Madness”—Manik

One year later

Who am I.

I'm neither Beatrice Kennedy or Amaya Corvo.

I am a survivor, not a victim.

I am a fighter, not a coward.

I'm a lover, not a hater.

I'm his Cub, for now, and forever.

“Lenny, you can’t just go around ordering people to move.” I roll my eyes, squeezing the railing of the gate.

“Ah, yes I can. You have cargo, the fucking prince, I will do what I want.”

I rub my belly, yes, my very swollen belly, and before you judge me about my contraception, he was planned. Not that it matters. We had been trying for months to get pregnant, but unfortunately, we weren’t one of the lucky ones who accidentally end up with a seed growing in their belly. Aeron has been out of the Bratva since that incident with me getting shot. There have been no interruptions as far as that goes either.

Antonio, or as I’ve recently started calling him, Poppa A, has been a big part of my life. I haven’t involved myself in that mafia family, but I keep my relationship tight with him. I’ve also slowly

started to get to know my aunts too and their children—my cousins. It's so strange that I'm twenty-four years old and I'm still learning the basics about my family. It's slow, but every day is progress. Although, Antonio is still scolding Aeron about the fact that he knocked me up without putting a ring on it. So old school.

Vlad is shockingly excited about the baby. He doesn't express this excitement, but every now and then I catch him looking at my belly, asking me questions, (and actually seeming interested). Our relationship is still on the fence, but again, progress. Darya is still around and Kat still hates her so there's nothing new there.

Kat and Kyle are married—another thing my poppa A likes to guilt Aeron about—and they've happily settled down in their own home. We just found out last week that she's pregnant so we're those annoying best friends that are buying everything together, doing everything together, and have even thought of names that sound good together.

"Alright then." I look down at my stomach. "You ready to hear daddy rap?"

I smile, bringing my eyes back up to the stage where a single spotlight shines on Aeron. He's standing there, shirtless and holding the mic. He licks his lip and smirks.

"So, I'm about to release a single that I'm dropping with one Jayelle Santana. Y'all know her, right?" The crowd goes wild.

I chuckle, shaking my head. He's so natural up there. Base starts thudding, a guitar starts strumming, and then Ae begins rapping. This time slowing it down a bit, every syllable licking his tongue smoothly, the soft low pitch vibrations of his voice rocking me to my core. Then the words catch me....

"I never wanted you there, but you fought at my despair, and let's not forget that from the very fucking start, you took my soul apart..."

You laid claim to my life, not just my heart and soul, I don't know how to say this, it's like a fucking scribble of madness ...

He turns, his eyes coming directly to me. *"But your pops Antonio is right, I gotta get this down tight, so Amaya Noel Corvo, will you be my wife?"* Then he drops to his knee.

The crowd gasps.

I stop breathing.

Tears stream down my cheeks as a smile takes over. "Don't leave me hanging, baby, you know how I get..."

I laugh, my head tilting back. "Yes!" I mouth, shaking my head.

He licks his lip and bites down, then brings the mic back to his mouth. "Yo, Chump! Bring my woman here."

Lenny and the guards open up the gates for me and I slip through. Lenny holds my hand, guiding me to the stage, so I don't fall on my two left feet.

The crowd goes crazy as I make my way to the center. He drops the mic, so it's just he and I now, and suddenly, the crowd silences, or maybe I block them out.

His hands come to mine, a smirk on his mouth. "I love you, Cub. For now, and forever."

"I love you too!"

He pushes the ring, the very heavy rock, I should say, onto my finger and the crowd erupts into roars. The love that I have for this man is pure, and the love he has for me is deadly, lethal even, but when they combine?

Well...

OTHER BOOKS

[Flip Trick](#)

[Razing Grace: Part 1](#)

[Razing Grace: Part 2](#)

The Elite Kings Club

[The Silver Swan](#)

[The Broken Puppet](#)

[Tacet a Mortuis](#)

[One Hundred & Thirty-Six Scars \(The Devil's Own, #1\)](#)

[Hellraiser \(The Devil's Own, #2\)](#)

[The Devil's Match \(The Devil's Own, #5\)](#)

[F*ucker](#)

[Crowned by Hate \(Crowned #1\)](#)

[Losing Traction \(Westbeach, #1\)](#)